



REAL DOG REHAB

The First 30 Days

*A Day-by-Day Quick-Start Guide to Restoring Food Drive,
Loading Markers, and Building Indoor Obedience the
Right Way*

BRIAN FERGUSON

A companion to the Real Dog Rehab video course library.

A note before we start

I'm not going to bury the lede on you. So let me say it up front: in the next 30 days, your dog is not going to become a finished product.

A finished dog — the kind I send home from my facility after four weeks of boot camp — has had something like 8,000 to 10,000 working repetitions on the five base commands by the time their owner picks them up. They've been put through pressure conditioning, marker work, threshold drills, and a hundred other small things that, stitched together, look like magic to people who haven't seen the stitching.

You and I are not going to do that in 30 days at home. I want to be straight with you about that.

What we *are* going to do is build the foundation that the magic sits on. We're going to fix the things that, if they're broken, are the actual reason every other piece of your training has fallen apart. We're going to put your dog in a position where, by Day 30, they have working obedience inside your home against real distractions — and where, when you do decide to take this work outside into the bigger world, you have a dog whose foundation can carry the weight.

That's the deal. Real, honest, foundational work. No shortcuts. No magic. No "ten tricks every dog owner needs to know." If you wanted that, there are a thousand YouTube channels happy to sell it to you. This isn't that.

If you read the next 30 entries and run the protocol the way it's written, your dog will be different at the end. Not finished. Different. And different in a direction that makes everything that comes after — every walk, every visitor, every moment in your real life — actually possible.

Let's go.

— Brian

Who I am, and why I do it this way

Quick introduction so you know who's talking to you.

My name is Brian Ferguson. I run a dog training facility where we do four-week board-and-trains, behavior consults, and rehab work on dogs that other trainers couldn't fix. I've been doing this for over twenty years.

The thing that makes my methodology work — and the thing I'm going to teach you over the next 30 days — is that I train dogs based on how their brain actually works at the chemistry level, not based on tradition or vibes or what some celebrity trainer said on TV. Almost every common pet-dog problem you've heard of — anxiety, reactivity, fear, "stubbornness," not listening, not coming when called, separation issues — has an actual neurochemical explanation. Anxiety isn't a personality trait, it's a state where the dog can't predict what's going to happen next and their stress chemistry is firing constantly. Reactivity isn't disobedience, it's a real arousal cascade where the dog's brain has been hijacked by neurotransmitters and they couldn't listen to you in that moment if they wanted to. Separation anxiety isn't the dog "missing you," it's a chemical dependency where the dog has no neural pathway to self-produce the soothing chemicals you've been supplying. Food motivation isn't about treats, it's about leveraging the most powerful reward chemistry the dog's brain has — the chemistry that's wired to keep them alive.

When you understand what's actually happening in the dog's brain, three things change. First, you stop blaming the dog for things that aren't choices. Second, you stop trying to fix problems by addressing the symptoms — barking, lunging, refusing — and start addressing the chemistry underneath them, which is the only thing that actually makes the symptom go away for good. Third, the techniques start making sense as a system instead of a bag of tricks, because they're all targeting the same underlying mechanism: build the right chemistry, and the right behavior follows.

That's the methodology in this guide. Every protocol I'll have you run for the next 30 days has a neurochemical reason it works, and I'll tell you what that reason is as we go, so you're not just doing what I say — you're understanding *why* and being able to adapt it to your dog as you go.

I want to flag a few things upfront so you know what you're reading.

I'm an actual dog trainer, with an actual dog training facility, that actually trains dogs 365 days a year. I'm not an influencer. I'm not selling you a course because I figured out that dog training videos do well on the algorithm. The methodology in this guide is the same one I use on every dog that walks through my facility's door, including the ones whose owners are paying me real money because their dog has bitten somebody.

My approach is balanced. I always flow in and out of all four operant quadrants with every dog, because that's how nature actually teaches and that's how dogs actually learn. If you've been told that "balanced training" is a euphemism for cruelty, you've been talked at by somebody trying to sell you their own methodology by trashing other people's. I use food. I use praise. I use freedom. I use pressure when the dog has earned the language to understand it. I use corrections after the dog fully understands what's expected and chooses not to do it. All four corners. Every dog. Every day. The order matters and the proportions matter — and the order and the proportions are dictated by the chemistry, not by ideology.

I'm direct. If something you're doing is the reason your dog is broken, I'll tell you. I'll tell you nicely, but I will tell you. Most of what's wrong with most pet dogs is a leadership and clarity problem, not a behavior problem — and the only way to fix it is to have a real conversation with the human about what they're doing. So don't expect a lot of hedging. If I'm soft about something, you'll know it's because the situation calls for soft. If I'm firm, the situation called for firm.

Here's what I'm not. I am not a vet. I do not give medical advice. I do not give nutrition advice beyond the basics that affect training. If something in this guide touches a topic that needs a vet, I'll tell you to go to your vet. (More on this in Day 1, because the most common bail-out from this program runs through "my vet said," and we have to deal with that head-on before we start.)

That's enough about me. Let's get into the work.

The big picture, in plain English

Before we start on Day 1, I want to give you the philosophy in five short pieces. Once you have these, the next 30 days will make sense as a coherent thing instead of a list of drills.

One — food drive is the foundation. Not "important." The foundation. Without a strong, restored relationship between your dog and food as a working reinforcer, none of the rest of this works. There's a reason Week 1 is dedicated to nothing but rebuilding food drive: it's because everything we do after that depends on it. Most owners want to skip this. Don't.

Two — pressure is a language, not a punishment. When I introduce a leash later in this program, the leash is not going to be a thing that holds your dog back. It's going to be a thing that *talks* to your dog. The dog is going to learn that pressure on the leash means *move toward your paycheck*. Not *fight against me*. Not *I'm in trouble*. Just *go this direction, food's coming*. This is one of the parts of my methodology that takes the longest to internalize, because every dog walks into training with the wrong instinct about leashes. Half of Week 3 is just teaching the dog the new instinct.

Three — structure is not a schedule. You're going to hear me say this a lot. Dogs don't need their meals at exactly 7:00 AM and 6:00 PM. Dogs don't need their walks at exactly 8:00 and 4:00. What dogs need is *clarity about what's expected of them when something is happening*. Structure is the rules. Schedule is the clock. Run the rules, vary the clock. A dog raised on a rigid clock will fall apart the day the clock breaks. A dog raised on rules will adapt because they know what the rules are no matter what time it is.

Four — clarity is kindness. This one is going to repeat in different forms throughout the manual. The single kindest thing you can do for a dog is be clear with them. Clear about what you want, clear about what you don't want, clear about what the consequence of each is. Dogs don't suffer from rules. Dogs suffer from rules that change without warning, from "sometimes" instead of "always" or "never," from a human whose mood is the only variable that determines what's allowed today. Clear rules let the dog's brain rest. Murky rules keep their nervous system on permanent alert.

Five — the work you do up front determines how kind the rest of training has to be. This is the deepest principle in the methodology and it's the one that most surprises owners when they finally see it in action. The math is this: there are only two ways to train a dog, through reward or through consequence and punishment, and you have to use both. But the *amount* of punishment you'll have to use over the course of your dog's whole life is a direct function of how strong your reward is. Strong reward = light correction needed. Weak reward = heavy correction needed. The work in Week 1 of this guide is specifically about making your reward as strong as it can possibly be — so that everything we do in Weeks 2 and 3 (and everything you do for the next ten years of your dog's life) can be done with the lightest possible touch.

That's the whole philosophy. Hold those five things in your head as you go through the days, and the protocol will make a lot more sense than just doing the drills one at a time.

How to use this guide

A quick orientation so you know what to expect from each day.

Each day is a single page (or two, for the longer ones), structured the same way. You'll see:

- **Before you start today.** This is a quick gate check at the top of every day. Did you complete what you needed to complete before this entry? If yes, proceed. If no, repeat the previous day and come back. The day numbers in this guide are reference points, not a calendar.
- **The story.** Most days open with a story from my facility — a dog I've worked with, a case I've seen, a moment that illustrates the principle. Stories are how I teach when I'm in the room with you. They'll do the same job here.
- **What you're going to do.** The actual protocol. Step by step. Read this section more than once if you need to. Better to spend ten extra minutes reading than to do the drill wrong and have to undo it.
- **Why this matters.** The principle behind the drill and the trap most owners fall into. This is the section that tells you not just *what* to do but *why* it works. If you understand the why, you can adapt when something doesn't go to script.
- **Common questions.** A small sidebar of "but what if..." questions I get asked all the time on this exact protocol. Read them. They'll answer the questions that are about to come up.
- **Today's checkpoint.** What "done" looks like, in terms you can observe. Pass the checkpoint, advance tomorrow. Fail the checkpoint, repeat the day. There is no penalty for taking longer.
- **Tomorrow.** A one- or two-line preview of what's next.

Time commitment. Two short training sessions a day, about 10 to 15 minutes each. That's it. If you can't do two on a given day, do one. If you can't do one, the day rolls forward to tomorrow. Better to skip cleanly than do a sloppy session that teaches the dog the wrong thing. More than two a day and most owners burn out and quit by Day 12. This is a marathon, not a sprint.

What if you miss a day? Pick up where you left off. Don't try to catch up. The dog is the clock. The calendar is the guide.

Pacing. The 30 days in the title is the *floor*, not the ceiling. Some dogs and handlers will move through this in 30 days flat. Most will take 35 to 45. Some will take 60. That's not failure — that's the program working correctly. The dogs who take longer at the foundation outrun the dogs who got rushed there, every single time. We're building something that lasts, not racing to a deadline.

If you get stuck. Each day's "Today's checkpoint" tells you what to do if you're not where you need to be. Some days have a major gate built in — Days 5, 10, 14, 20, and 30 are all "do not advance until this is clean" checkpoint days. Honor them. The whole program is a chain — one weak link, the whole thing collapses three days later.

A note on contact. If at any point in this guide you hit something that's specific to your dog and you can't figure out how to adapt the protocol, **DM me inside the Real Dog Rehab community.** That's the most reliable way to get an answer from me directly. The weekly live Q&A calls are also a great place to bring questions about your specific dog — bring video if you can, and we'll work through it

together. I'd rather you ask than guess wrong. Heads-up: most of the time, the honest answer back is going to be "your dog is fine, stick to the protocol." That's the most common right answer. But the cases where it's not are real, and I'd rather catch them than miss them.

Alright. Last thing before we start: equipment.

Equipment — the short list

You don't need much. I'd rather you have the right four things than the wrong fifteen. Below is what I actually recommend, with links to the specific gear I use and trust.

A flat collar. For ID tags and standard daily wear. Whatever fits and is humane. This isn't a training tool, it's just a collar.

A six-foot slip lead, in a thinner diameter. This is the leash you'll use for most of the in-home pressure work. I want it thinner rather than thicker, because the thicker the leash, the duller the pressure signal — and we want the pressure to feel crisp to the dog when we use it as language. **One safety note up front: slip leads are not for unattended dogs.** A slip lead can tighten without releasing if the dog catches it on something while you're not there, and that's a strangulation risk. Slip lead is for handler-present sessions. If you need a leave-on-while-watching-TV leash, use a flat collar with a regular leash or a martingale.

A decent off-the-shelf option (3/8" diameter, 6' length): [the slip lead I'd recommend on Amazon](#).

If you'd rather use the slip lead I personally use and run on every dog at my facility — we make our own, made to order, \$35 shipped. **DM me inside the Real Dog Rehab community if you want one** and I'll get you the order details.

A clicker. Any clicker. The cheap ones are fine. We want the click sound to be consistent every time, which means we don't want anything fancy that introduces variation. Pick one and use the same one for the whole 30 days. Buy a spare in case you lose it. [The clicker I use](#).

A place bed (a raised cot). This becomes essential starting Day 18. A raised cot — the kind that's a fabric platform stretched over a metal frame — is the right tool. Not a soft dog bed. The raised cot has clear edges, which means the dog can feel where "place" begins and ends. A soft pillow bed with no defined edges is much harder to teach the dog to "stay on." Get a cot. [The place bed I use](#).

A treat pouch. Any treat pouch. You're going to be reaching into food a lot, and digging into a pocket gets old fast. A small clip-on pouch on your hip makes this much easier. You can use a fanny pack if you don't have a treat pouch. Doesn't matter what it looks like.

Optional but recommended: a 15- or 20-foot long line. Not used in this 30-day guide, but it'll be the next major piece of equipment when you take this work outside in the next phase. A long flat line, not a retractable. Retractable leashes are fine for sniffing walks if your dog is otherwise trained, but they're terrible for actual training because the constant low-grade tension prevents you from communicating cleanly with the leash. For training, a regular long line.

Down the road — an e-collar. Not used in this 30-day guide, but the e-collar is part of the full program and you'll layer it in later, after the foundation is solid. When you're ready, [the e-collar I recommend](#). Don't buy this for the next 30 days. Buy it when the e-collar course in the library tells you to.

That's it for now. Notice what's not on the list. No prong collar. No gentle leader. No harness. None of those are tools we're using in this 30-day guide — some of them I do use later in my full program,

but none belong in the foundation work, and a few of them (harness, gentle leader) I have specific opinions against that I'll explain when they come up.

If you've already bought a bunch of equipment based on what some other trainer told you, you don't need to throw it away. But for the next 30 days, set it aside. Run the protocol with the list above. We'll talk about advanced tools when the foundation is in.

Alright. Tomorrow we start.

WEEK 1 · DAYS 1–10

Restoring Food Drive

Before any obedience can be installed, food has to mean something again. Ten days of pulling free food, holding the line, and rebuilding the most powerful reinforcer your dog has.

Day 1 — Why Your Dog Doesn't Work for Food (And Why That's Fixable)

Today is a reading day. You're not changing anything about your dog yet. Today is for you. Tomorrow we start.

► **Before you start today.** Nothing. There is no prerequisite for Day 1. You bought this guide and opened it — that's all you need. Read this entry today. If you're reading it in the morning, give yourself the rest of the day to sit with it. We start the actual protocol tomorrow morning at your dog's first meal.

THE STORY

A few years back I had a guy bring me a 94-pound Rottweiler. Fear-aggressive, didn't trust people, had bitten more than once. Owner was at the end of his rope and brought him to me as a last shot.

First thing I do with any new boarding dog is offer them food from my hand. That's how I find out who I'm dealing with. This Rottweiler? Wanted nothing to do with it. Wouldn't take a piece of kibble out of my palm to save his life. So we did what we do — bowl out, 10 minutes, food goes up, see you tomorrow.

He didn't eat the next day either. Or the day after that. Or the day after *that*.

This dog refused food for **twelve full days**. Twelve. Now, before you spiral about animal welfare, here's the thing nobody tells you: dogs can down-regulate their metabolism into energy conservation mode. They slow their burn rate way down. That Rottweiler lost a pound and a half in twelve days. He was still pooping for the first five — I was as surprised as anybody. The dog was fine. He was not in any kind of medical danger. He was making a choice.

Day twelve, he decided he was hungry enough. He took the food. And from that moment on, the case wrapped in four weeks. Four weeks. Because the second food drive came online, *everything else became possible*. Communication. Learning. Trust. All of it.

That's the dog I want you to think about today. Not because your dog is going to take twelve days — most don't take more than one or two. I want you to think about him because he is the absolute outer edge of this protocol, and **he was completely, totally, 100% fine**. Your dog will be fine. I promise you. We just have to get to the same place that Rottweiler got to: a dog who has decided that working for food is worth doing.

WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON WITH YOUR DOG

Let me say this plainly because it's the foundation of everything else in this guide and most owners don't want to hear it:

There is no such thing as a dog who isn't food-motivated. There are only dogs who have learned that food is optional.

I'm going to repeat that because almost every single person who reads this is about to argue with me about it in their head. *My dog is different. My dog is genuinely not into food. My dog has tried every*

kind of kibble and won't eat any of it. My vet said some dogs just aren't motivated by food.

No. Your dog has to eat to live. Food motivation is not a personality trait. It is a biological necessity. Every dog on this planet has food drive — because every dog on this planet would die without it. What your dog does or doesn't have is a *learned attitude toward food in your specific home*, and that attitude was built by you, accidentally, over months or years, and it can be unbuilt the same way.

Here's the version of the story that's probably playing out at your house:

Your dog is a puppy. You feed them three times a day because the bag says to. They eat fine. As they grow up, you keep feeding multiple times a day because nobody told you to stop. Maybe a year in, they start picking at the bowl. Skipping meals. So you panic — *what's wrong with my dog?* — and you cook up some chicken and put it on top. The dog inhales the chicken, leaves the kibble. You go, *huh, my dog likes chicken better*. So now there's chicken on the kibble most nights. After a month of that, the dog starts picking around the chicken too. So you go to the pet store and buy fancier food. The dog eats it for two weeks, then loses interest. So you buy the *next* fancier food. Round and round.

Six months later you are convinced your dog is "not food motivated." You're walking around with cooked chicken in a baggie in your pocket trying to bribe your dog into a sit, and even that's not really working.

I want to be clear about what actually happened: **your dog trained you**. They figured out, through trial and error, that holding out gets them better stuff. They used the same exact learning principles I'm going to teach you to use on them — except they used them on you first, and you didn't know what was happening, so they won. Every single time you cooked a piece of chicken because you were worried they weren't eating, you were running a textbook training session on yourself. The dog wasn't being picky. The dog was working.

Now, none of this is your fault. Nobody told you. The reason I'm telling you now is because we're about to undo it.

WHY THIS IS THE MOST IMPORTANT WEEK IN THE WHOLE PROGRAM

Let me explain something that almost no trainer talks about plainly, and that once you understand, the next ten days are going to make sense in a way they won't otherwise.

There are only two ways to train a dog. **Two**. Not five, not ten. Two.

You can train a dog through reward, or you can train a dog through consequence and punishment. That's it. Those are your options. Every methodology that has ever existed, every YouTube trainer you've watched, every book you've read — all of it sits somewhere on the spectrum between those two poles. There's no third thing. There's no secret door.

Now, in my methodology, we use both. I'm a balanced trainer. I tell people I always flow in and out of all four operant quadrants with every dog, because that's how nature actually teaches and that's how dogs actually learn. So this isn't a "punishment is bad" speech. Punishment, applied correctly and after the dog fully understands what's expected, is part of how I work. It is not the enemy.

But here is what is true, and what most owners never get told:

The amount of punishment you'll have to use with your dog over the course of their entire life is a direct function of how strong your reinforcer is.

Think about that for a second. The stronger your reward — the more your dog cares about getting it — the less you ever have to lean on the punishment side of the scale to get the same behavior. The weaker your reward, the more punishment has to fill the gap. That's not a moral statement. That's just the math of how learning works. If your reward isn't worth doing the right thing for, then the only other reason to do the right thing is to avoid the wrong thing being unpleasant. There's no third option.

So now ask yourself: what is the strongest possible reinforcer you can offer a dog?

Not toys. Toys are great for some dogs and meaningless for others, and even the toy-crazy dogs aren't going to choose a tug over a squirrel running across the yard.

Not praise. Praise is nice. Praise is not paying the mortgage.

Not affection. Affection is wonderful. It is not what your dog will give up chasing a deer for.

The strongest reinforcer available to a dog — and it isn't even close — **is the thing they need to stay alive**. Food. Because food is wired into their brain at the survival level. A dog's brain treats food acquisition as top-priority activity, because in the wild, that's exactly what it is. Food is not a treat. Food is a paycheck for the work of staying alive. Every dog has this wiring. We are not adding a new motivator — we are restoring access to the most powerful one that already exists.

Here's what that means in practice. A dog with restored food drive — a dog who genuinely wants their meals, will work hard for individual pieces of kibble, and treats a piece of food in your hand like the best thing happening in the room — is a dog you can train with very, very, very little punishment. Because the reward side of the scale is so heavy that the punishment side barely has to weigh anything to keep the balance. You can communicate corrections with low-level pressure, gentle leash work, simple "no" markers. The dog stays in motivation, stays in love with the work, stays light on their feet.

A dog *without* restored food drive — a dog who picks at their bowl, who's mildly interested in food but not really, who'll take a piece of cheese but won't work for kibble — is a dog you can only train with much heavier punishment. Because the reward side of the scale is empty. There's nothing on it. So the only way to shift behavior is to put more and more weight on the punishment side. Sharper corrections. Higher E-collar levels. More repetition of the same correction because the first one didn't mean enough to land. *That's* where you get the trainers and the methodologies that look harsh and feel harsh. They didn't choose harshness for fun. They chose it because they didn't bother building the reward side first, so harshness was the only tool left.

I want to be very clear about what I'm telling you: **the work you do in the next seven to ten days is the single biggest determinant of how kind the rest of your dog's training is going to be**. Get food drive back online and the rest of this program is reward-heavy, light-touch, fun for the dog, fun for you. Skip it or half-do it, and every subsequent day gets harder for both of you, and you end up using corrections to make up for the motivation that was supposed to be there in the first place. That's not the dog's fault. That's not even your fault. That's just how the math shakes out when one side of the scale is empty.

So when you're standing in your kitchen tomorrow night and your dog walks past their bowl for the third time and you feel the urge to cook something, I want you to think about it this way: *the*

discomfort I'm sitting with right now is the cost of admission to a year of training my dog with mostly food and very little correction. The alternative isn't "no discomfort." The alternative is a year of correction-heavy training because I never built a real reinforcer.

We do the hard thing now so we get to do the fun stuff for the rest of your dog's life. That's the trade. That's why this matters. That's why I'm not budging on it and why I won't let you budge on it either.

BRIAN-ISM

Either motivation goes up or punishment has to go up. It's one of the two, and it's totally your choice.

The hard part is this week. The fun part is everything that comes after.

WHAT WEEK 1 IS ACTUALLY GOING TO DO

For the next seven to ten days — and I'm telling you upfront, **it might take longer for your dog**, and that is fine — we are going to do exactly one thing: rebuild your dog's relationship with food.

That's it. That's the whole week. We are not teaching sit. We are not teaching down. We are not loading a marker. We are not doing any obedience whatsoever. **You are going to be tempted to skip ahead to the "real" training and you are going to ruin everything if you do.** I cannot say that strongly enough. The single biggest reason this program fails for people is they read Day 2, decide their dog is "fine on food," and try to start clicker work on Day 3. Then nothing sticks, the dog won't engage, the marker won't load, and they email me asking why their dog is broken.

Their dog isn't broken. They skipped Week 1.

Here's the simple truth you have to internalize before tomorrow: a dog who will not eat their normal food enthusiastically out of your hand, in clean rep after rep, for ten minutes straight — *cannot be trained using food as a reinforcer*. Not won't be. Cannot be. The mechanics of marker training literally do not work without it. So if I let you skip ahead, I'm setting you up to fail in two weeks, and you're going to blame yourself, and that's not what we're here to do.

Week 1 is not optional. Week 1 is the work.

WHAT YOU ARE GOING TO FEEL THIS WEEK (AND WHY IT'S WRONG)

Tomorrow you're going to switch your dog to one meal a day. You're going to put it down for ten minutes. If they don't eat it in ten minutes, the bowl goes up on top of the fridge and they don't see food again for twenty-four hours.

Some of you are going to read that and feel a knot in your stomach.

I want to address that knot directly because it is, by a long shot, the number one reason owners fail this protocol.

You are going to feel like you are starving your dog. You are not. You are introducing your dog to the consequences of their own choices in a framework that mirrors how their body actually works in nature. Wild dogs don't eat three times a day. They eat a handful of times a *week*. They work for every

meal. *If they don't work, they don't eat.* That's the system your dog's biology is wired for. The system you've been running — meals on a schedule, food always available, treats whenever — is the system that's actually unnatural for your dog. The reset isn't deprivation. The reset is normalcy.

You are going to feel the urge to "just give them a little something" if they skip a meal. This is the cooked chicken trap I just walked you through, and it's going to come back tomorrow night with new arguments. *He looks hungry. She didn't really refuse, she just sniffed it and walked away. Maybe one piece of chicken won't undo anything.* It will undo everything. The whole protocol works on one premise: **the dog learns that food is finite, that you do not negotiate, and that holding out makes things worse, not better.** The second you cook chicken, you've taught the opposite. You've confirmed the strategy. We're back to square one and now the dog has new evidence that you'll cave under pressure.

Remember why we're doing this. Every meal you hold the line on this week is one less correction you have to use on your dog for the rest of their life. That's the trade.

BRIAN-ISM

Brian does not beg. I do not beg for you to work with me. I'll give you a shot. If you don't take it, we'll try again tomorrow, and you can sit around hungry for the next twenty-four hours.

That's the energy. Not mean. Not angry. Just settled. The food is there. You eat it or you don't. Tomorrow we'll try again.

A FEW THINGS I HAVE TO FLAG BEFORE TOMORROW

Before I get into these, let me head off the most common bail-out at the pass. If you're looking for a reason to not run this protocol, you will find one. I promise you. Your dog will look at you a little sad tomorrow night and your brain will start writing the exception. *He's different. She has a sensitive stomach. The vet said. The internet said. My breeder said.* I have heard every version of this. Most of them are not real reasons. Most of them are guilt looking for a hat to wear.

So here's the deal. The list below is the *actual* short list of dogs who can't run this protocol the standard way. If your dog is on the list, deviate. If your dog is not on the list — and the vast majority of you are in this category — run the protocol as written, even if you can think of a story for why you shouldn't. Especially then.

If your dog is genuinely underweight — and I mean genuinely, as in *visible ribs you can count without touching the dog, hip bones poking through, the spine showing as a ridge through the coat* — do not run this protocol the standard way. Underweight dogs don't have the reserves to skip meals. The fix is calorie powder in their water to maintain nutrition while you transition more gradually. *Genuinely underweight* is a small category. "She's slim" is not underweight. "He's leaner than my friend's dog" is not underweight. If you're not sure, here's the test: stand over your dog and look down. You should see a clear waist tucking in behind the ribs. If there's a visible waist and you can feel ribs with light pressure but not see them — that's a healthy dog and the protocol applies. If you can clearly see every rib without touching the dog and the hip bones are sharp, that's underweight.

If your dog has an actual diagnosed medical condition — diabetes, Addison's disease, kidney disease, certain seizure disorders, a recent surgery with a vet-prescribed feeding schedule attached — that's a real thing and you need to talk to your vet before changing anything. I'm a dog trainer, not a vet, and I'm not telling you to ignore a medical protocol your vet put your dog on for a specific medical reason. In twenty-two years of training I've seen maybe three dogs who genuinely couldn't run this protocol because of a real medical condition. They exist. They're rare. **If you're not sure whether what your vet told you was a real medical instruction or just their general feeding-frequency opinion — DM me inside the Real Dog Rehab community before you start. We'll figure out the right adjustment for your specific dog. Heads-up: most of the time, the honest answer is going to be "your dog is fine, stick to the protocol." Don't take that personally if it comes back that way. It's the most common right answer.**

Now, here's where I have to be direct with you. *"My vet said dogs should eat twice a day"* is not a medical condition. It is a feeding-frequency opinion. Vets are excellent at medicine. Most of them are not nutritionists, and the standard "feed twice a day" recommendation is a default, not a prescription tied to anything specific about your individual dog. If your vet has not diagnosed your dog with an actual condition that requires multiple meals — they have given you general advice, the same way they hand out the same dental-cleaning recommendation to every dog that walks in. General advice is not a medical override. If you ask your vet *"is my otherwise-healthy adult dog going to be in any danger if I switch to one meal a day"*, the honest answer for the overwhelming majority of dogs is no. Some vets will tell you that. Some will hedge. A few will tell you the opposite. None of those answers change what your dog's biology is actually doing.

I'm not anti-vet. I work with vets. I send dogs to vets. I'm telling you this because I've watched too many owners use "my vet said" as the off-ramp the second this protocol gets uncomfortable on Day 3. If your vet has diagnosed an actual medical reason — listen to them. If they haven't, and you're using their general advice as a reason to feed three times a day because that's what feels easier — be honest with yourself that that's what you're doing.

If your dog is a puppy under ten months — feed twice a day, not once. Run a softened version of this protocol: ten-minute timer, food up if not eaten, but try again at the next meal rather than waiting twenty-four hours. Once they're past ten months, drop to one meal and run the full protocol.

Everyone else — and that's most of you — full protocol starts tomorrow morning.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog is healthy weight and eats fine — they finish their bowl every time. Can I skip Week 1?

A: No. Read Day 9 — there's a real test for whether your dog is actually trainable, and "eats their bowl" doesn't pass it. The protocol still applies. You'll move through it faster, but you have to move through it.

Q: My partner / kid / mother-in-law is going to undermine this. They're not going to be on board with the 'starving the dog' thing.

A: Then you have a household conversation to have today. Not tomorrow morning when the bowl goes down — today, before you go to bed. Everyone in the house has to be on the same page or this protocol dies in the first 48 hours, because the dog will figure out within one or two refusals that there's a back door, and they will go through it every single time. They don't have to. They will. That's not your dog being bad — that's your dog being a dog. I want to be direct about what "on board" actually means, because most people fudge this. On board does not mean "they said okay and rolled their eyes." On board means: nobody in the house slips the dog a piece of cheese in the kitchen. Nobody gives the dog a bite off their plate. Nobody opens a treat jar "just to see if she'll take it" when the bowl came up untouched. Nobody. For thirty days. If you can't get that agreement from the people you live with, you have a different problem than dog training, and I can't fix it from here. The protocol does not work around a household member who's running a back-channel feeding operation. I've watched it fail a hundred times. If somebody in your house is going to undermine this, the kindest thing you can do for your dog is figure that out today and either get the buy-in or accept that this isn't the right time to run the program. Coming back to it in three months when the household is aligned will get you further than starting it tomorrow with a saboteur in the kitchen.

Q: My vet said feeding once a day is bad for dogs.

A: Did your vet diagnose your dog with a specific condition that requires multiple meals — like diabetes, a known blood sugar issue, kidney disease, or a recent surgery with a feeding protocol attached? If yes, listen to your vet. If no — what your vet gave you was general advice, not a medical instruction. Vets are doctors. Most of them are not nutritionists, and the "twice a day" line is a default recommendation, not a prescription based on anything specific about your dog. There is research out of Arizona State showing dogs fed once a day actually have lower disease rates and longer lifespans than dogs fed multiple times. The single-meal protocol is what I run on every dog in my facility. They live long, healthy lives. Your dog will be fine. If you genuinely can't tell whether what your vet told you is general advice or a medical instruction tied to an actual condition — DM me inside the Real Dog Rehab community. I'd rather you ask than guess wrong in either direction. We'll figure out together how to create this same desire for food in your specific situation. I'll just tell you up front: don't be surprised when, nine times out of ten, what comes back from me is "your dog is fine, there's no medical issue here, stick to the protocol." That's the most common honest answer to that question. But the tenth dog is real, and I'd rather catch them than miss them, so if you're not sure — reach out.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** You don't have to do anything physical today. The checkpoint for Day 1 is internal. Before you go to bed, ask yourself this honestly: *Am I willing to let my dog skip a meal — or two, or three — without caving?* If the answer is yes, we're good, you're ready for tomorrow. If the answer is *I want to but I don't know if I actually can*, that's also fine — read this entry one more time tonight, talk to whoever else lives in the house, and we'll start in the morning. If the answer is *no, I can't do that to my dog* — close the guide. Come back when you're ready. There's no version of this program that works around a handler who isn't willing to hold the line on meals. That's not me being harsh. That's me being honest with you about what this takes.

TOMORROW

The bowl comes down to one meal. Ten-minute timer. Food up if it's not eaten. Twenty-four hour cycle if it's refused. We're starting.

Day 2 — Pull All Free Food. One Meal a Day Starts Now.

Today we change one thing about your dog's life: how often they eat. That single change is the entire foundation of everything we'll do over the next 30 days.

► **Before you start today.** You should have read Day 1 in full. You should have had the household conversation if there's anyone else in your house who feeds the dog. You should be willing to let your dog skip a meal without caving. If any of those three are still loose, fix them today before tonight's meal. If they're solid, proceed.

THE STORY

There's a question I get asked on every single member call, in some version: *"How long does this actually take? When will my dog start eating like they care?"*

Most dogs? One to two cycles. They miss a meal. They miss the next meal. They eat the third meal like they've never seen food before. The whole reset takes 24 to 48 hours for a normal dog with no major prior food trauma.

Now here's where I always get the small-dog version of the question. A member on a recent call had a 5-pound Pomeranian, eating roughly a third of a cup twice a day per the bag, and she wanted to know whether the protocol *really* applied at that size — or whether tiny dogs got a different rulebook.

They don't. The protocol does not change for small dogs. Doesn't matter what your dog prefers, what their body weight is, or what the bag of food says about meal frequency — we're going to feed them once a day because that's what's healthy for them, and that's what the training relies on. The math of the daily ration changes (her dog goes from 1/3 cup twice a day to 2/3 cup once a day — same total, half the frequency), but every other piece is identical to what I'd run on a 90-pound shepherd. The dog's brain doesn't care about their body weight when it comes to food drive. The brain is wired the same way.

The other thing that came up on that call, and comes up on a lot of calls, was treats. The member admitted she'd been using treats heavily because the dog had been picky earlier. Same trap as the cooked chicken story I told you yesterday, just with smaller fuel. The fix is the same too: pull the treats. Switch to kibble entirely. We want to use the thing they have to survive for, because it's far more powerful than something they don't have to survive for.

I'm telling you this because you're about to put a bowl down for the first time, and you need to know what's normal and what isn't. Most dogs eat the first meal. Some don't. Both of those are fine. We have a plan for both.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Today is mechanical. Here's the protocol, in order.

Step one — calculate the day's ration. Look at the back of your dog's food bag. Find the recommended daily amount for your dog's **ideal weight** (not their current weight if they're overweight). That's the daily total. If you've been feeding 1 cup twice a day, the new daily ration is 2 cups, fed once. **Same total calories. Same food.** The only thing changing today is frequency.

Step two — pick the meal time and commit. Doesn't really matter when. Morning works for most people because the dog has the whole day to be trained from that bowl. Evening works fine too. Pick one and use the same time every day from now on, give or take half an hour.

Step three — put the bowl down. Today, just for today, this is the standard "here's your food" presentation. Bowl on the floor. Walk away. Go do something else. Don't hover. Don't watch.

Step four — start a 10-minute timer the moment you put the bowl down.

Step five — at the 10-minute mark, pick up the bowl no matter what.

If the dog ate everything: great. Bowl gets washed and put away. See you tomorrow.

If the dog ate some of it but not all: bowl still gets picked up. Whatever's left goes in the trash or in the fridge for tomorrow's portion (your call, doesn't matter for the protocol). Dog gets nothing else until tomorrow's meal time.

If the dog ate none of it: bowl gets picked up. Food goes on top of the fridge or wherever the dog can't get to it. **No food, no treats, no chews, no bully sticks, no anything edible until tomorrow's meal time, 24 hours from now.**

Step six — pull all the free food sources, today, before tonight. This part is critical and most owners forget it. Walk around your house and remove every food source the dog has been able to access on demand:

- Pick up any food bowl that's been sitting out
- Put away the treat jar on the counter
- Put away rawhides, bully sticks, yak chews, anything edible the dog grazes on
- If you've got a kid who feeds the dog from the table, the kid stops, today
- If you've got a partner who slips the dog cheese, the partner stops, today
- If the dog has access to cat food, block the cat food

The dog needs to be in one of two states: **working, or resting.** Nothing in between. Entertainment-mode, all-day-grazing-mode, free-snacking-mode — those are the modes we're killing. There is one source of calories now, and it comes from you, in a bowl, once a day, with a 10-minute window.

WHY THIS MATTERS

I've explained the *why* in Day 1 — the cooked chicken trap, the reward-vs-punishment math, the survival wiring. I'm not going to repeat all of that here. What I want to flag is the specific mechanism that makes today's mechanics work, because if you understand what the bowl-going-up actually does to the dog's brain, you'll be much less tempted to bail tomorrow night.

When you remove the bowl after 10 minutes of refusal, you are running a textbook **negative punishment** sequence. *Negative* means you're removing something. *Punishment* means you're decreasing the likelihood of a behavior. In this case, the behavior you're decreasing is "*refusing to eat when food is offered.*" The thing you're removing is the food itself.

The reason the 24-hour window matters — and why "well, I'll just try again in a couple of hours" is the most common way owners break this protocol without realizing it — is that the consequence has

to be intense enough for the dog to actually feel it. Negative punishment based on hunger requires the dog to *experience hunger*. That doesn't happen in two hours. It takes most of a day. So if you re-offer food after a couple of hours, you've not delivered any consequence at all — you've just confirmed to the dog that holding out a little gets them a fresh attempt, which is the opposite of what we want.

The 24-hour cycle is the smallest window in which the consequence actually lands. That's why it's the rule.

BRIAN-ISM

It's his consequence. He chose it. The decision they made is what causes them to deal with their hunger over the next 24 hours. That needs to be an experience in order for the behavior to not return.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog ate their entire bowl in 90 seconds. Now what?

A: Great. That's the easiest possible Day 2. Bowl gets washed, put away. Tomorrow, same thing. Watch over the next few days for the dog to start "testing" — slowing down, walking away, picking. That's the dog probing whether food is really finite now or if you'll cave. Don't cave. Most dogs that eat fine on Day 2 will throw at least one test refusal somewhere in the first week. We have a plan for that on Day 3.

Q: My dog walked over to the bowl, sniffed it, walked away. Is that a refusal?

A: Wait the full 10 minutes. Some dogs come back. Some don't. At minute 10, the bowl goes up regardless. If they ate nothing in 10 minutes, that's a refusal. Read Day 3 — that's exactly what tomorrow's entry is for.

Q: What about water?

A: Water stays. Free water access, all day, every day. We are not restricting water. We are restricting food.

Q: Can I do training treats during the day if I'm working on something?

A: Not this week. Not until food drive is restored. The whole protocol depends on food being scarce and high-value. If you're handing out treats on the side, you've broken the scarcity. After Day 10, when the foundation is in, the entire daily ration becomes training food (we'll get into that in Week 2). For this week, the only food is the once-a-day bowl.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Easy one — did you get one meal in the bowl, with a 10-minute window, with all free food sources pulled? If yes, you're done for today. If you forgot to pull a free food source (like the treat jar on the counter), go fix that tonight before bed. Tomorrow morning will tell you which kind of dog you have — the easy track or the test-the-handler track. Either way, we have a plan.

TOMORROW

We meet whichever dog you have. Either the dog who eats fine and we move forward, or the dog who refused tonight and now we hold the line. Tomorrow's entry has both paths.

Day 3 — The First Refusal (Or: What If My Dog Eats Fine?)

Today's entry is forked. Read the path that matches your dog's behavior at last night's meal.

► **Before you start today.** You ran Day 2's protocol. You put a bowl down for 10 minutes. You either picked up an empty bowl or a full one. That's all that needs to be true. Find your path below.

PATH A — YOUR DOG ATE THE BOWL

Good. Easy track. Most dogs do this on day one. Here's what you do today: **exact same thing as yesterday**. Same time, same amount, same 10-minute window. Bowl down, walk away, come back at 10 minutes, pick up whatever's left.

You're going to do this every day for at least four to five consecutive days of immediate eating before we move to hand-feeding. That's the rule. Not "they ate three days in a row, let's go." Four to five consecutive days. The reason for the consistency requirement is that we're not just looking for the dog to eat — we're looking for the dog to have *internalized* that this is how food works now. That takes more than one or two reps. The dog who eats fine for three days and then suddenly refuses on day four is the dog who hadn't actually internalized anything yet. They were testing the boundary by complying first to see what happened. Now they're testing the boundary by refusing to see what happens. Don't be surprised when this comes. Have your reaction ready: bowl up, 24 hours off, no negotiation.

For the rest of today's entry, scroll down to "*Why this matters*" — the principles apply to both paths. You can skip Path B unless your dog refuses a future meal, in which case you'll come back and read it.

PATH B — YOUR DOG REFUSED LAST NIGHT

Welcome to the real protocol. This is the dog who's about to make you genuinely uncomfortable. Take a breath. Let me walk you through it.

First — what happened last night. Bowl went down. Dog sniffed, walked away, came back, sniffed again, walked away. Or maybe the dog didn't even come over. Or maybe they ate two bites and quit. Whatever the variant, at minute 10 you picked up the bowl with food still in it. **Good**. You did the right thing. Now we hold the line.

Today's protocol: **nothing changes**. Same time, same amount, same 10-minute window. Bowl down, walk away, come back at 10. If they eat, we're back on track and you'll read Path A tomorrow. If they don't eat, bowl goes up, no food until the next meal time, and we run it again tomorrow.

That's it. That's literally the whole protocol today.

What you're going to feel today is much harder than what you have to *do* today. The doing is putting a bowl down and picking it up. The feeling is the part that gets owners to break.

You're going to feel guilty. You're going to look at your dog and convince yourself they look thin (they don't — one missed meal does not change a dog's body composition). You're going to want to "just try one little thing." You're going to remember a pet store treat in the cabinet and think *what's the harm*. Don't do it. The harm is the harm. The whole protocol breaks the second you cave.

Here's the cooked chicken trap I warned you about in Day 1, in real-time, on Day 3:

Dog refuses bowl. Owner panics. Owner cooks chicken. Dog eats chicken. Owner thinks "see, my dog will eat, they just don't like the kibble." Dog has just been trained that refusing kibble produces chicken.

Notice what happened in that sequence. The dog made a choice (refuse kibble), got an outcome (chicken), and the outcome was *better than what they were originally offered*. That is, in technical terms, a textbook positive reinforcement of the refusal behavior. You have just *paid your dog* to refuse food. You will get more refusal. You will get it for the rest of your dog's life unless you reset.

I'm laying this out in detail because today is the day this trap is most likely to spring. The dog's first refusal is when the owner's resolve is highest *theoretically* and lowest *practically*. Theoretically you're committed. Practically you have a hungry-looking dog in front of you. Practically wins.

Don't let it. Hold the line.

WHY THIS MATTERS

What's happening biologically right now, on the inside of your dog, is exactly what we want.

Yesterday they had food in a bowl. They didn't really care. Today their body is starting to register that hunger is a thing that's going to persist. The hormones associated with food motivation are starting to ramp up. Their brain is starting to do the math.

This is the whole point. We are not depriving the dog. We are *restoring the natural relationship* between hunger and food acquisition that years of free-feeding suppressed. In nature, dogs are hungry between hunts. That hunger is what motivates the next hunt. Hunger is not suffering — hunger is *function*. What we did to our pet dogs was eliminate hunger from their experience by making food infinite, and in doing so, we eliminated the thing that makes them work.

We're putting the function back.

The dog will be fine. I keep saying this because you need to hear it. A healthy dog skipping a meal — or two, or three — is not in distress. They are in *learning*. Their body has the reserves to handle this without missing a step. The Rottweiler from Day 1's story went twelve days. Your dog will not go twelve days. Your dog will probably eat tomorrow. The worst-case outcome is they go three or four days and then they eat. Either way, they are *fine*, and on the other side of this you have a dog who works for food, which means a dog you can train.

BRIAN-ISM

Brian does not beg. I do not beg for you to work with me. I'll give you a shot. If you don't take it, we'll try again tomorrow, and you can sit around hungry for the next 24 hours.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: How will I know if something is actually medically wrong vs. just refusing food?

A: A dog who is genuinely sick usually shows other signs — lethargy, vomiting, abnormal stool, weakness, hiding, refusing water. A dog who is just refusing food because they're testing you looks completely normal otherwise — bright-eyed, walking around, drinking water, interested in the world. If you're seeing the second pattern, it's behavioral, not medical, and you hold the line. If you're seeing genuine sickness signs, that's a vet conversation, not a training conversation.

Q: My dog vomited bile this morning. Is that the protocol's fault?

A: Some dogs vomit a small amount of yellow bile when their stomach has been empty for a long stretch — it's stomach acid pooling. Doesn't usually mean anything dangerous, but if it persists across multiple days, talk to your vet. The fix some owners use: a small handful of dry kibble at the original "second meal" time of day for the first few days of the transition. It doesn't break the protocol — same total daily ration, just spread differently. The 10-minute timer and 24-hour rule still apply.

Q: My dog is now staring at me from across the room with the saddest eyes.

A: They're working you. That's literally what they're doing — they're applying social pressure because the food withdrawal is uncomfortable for them, and you are the lever they have access to. Recognize the manipulation for what it is and don't reward it. Get up, go do something else, take a walk, leave the house if you need to. The dog learns nothing from staring at you sadly except whether it works. Make it not work.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did you put the bowl down at the same time as yesterday, leave it for exactly 10 minutes, and pick it up regardless of what was eaten? If yes, you're on protocol. If no — if you adjusted the time, extended the window, added something to the bowl, or gave a treat between meals — you're off protocol, and tomorrow we restart Day 2. There is no shame in restarting Day 2. There's a lot of damage in continuing while pretending you didn't break protocol.

TOMORROW

If your dog ate today: same drill. We're building the streak of consecutive eating days. If your dog refused: same drill. We're holding the line. Tomorrow's entry is about what happens *inside you* when this stretches into day two of refusal, which is the next moment most owners break.

Day 4 — Holding the Line

Today is not about the dog. Today is about you. Specifically: what happens to your willpower at the 36-to-48-hour mark, and what to do about it.

► **Before you start today.** You're on protocol — bowl down, 10 minutes, bowl up. That's all I need to know. If you're on Path A from Day 3 (dog eating fine), today's entry is still worth reading because tomorrow your dog might decide to test the boundary, and you'll want to have already absorbed this. If you're on Path B (dog refused), today's entry is for you specifically.

THE STORY

I want to tell you about how I think about this when I'm running the protocol on a board-and-train dog at my facility.

Dog comes in Sunday afternoon. Sunday night I offer a bowl. Some dogs eat it. Some don't. Doesn't matter to me — I run the same protocol either way. Bowl up at 10 minutes. See you tomorrow morning.

Monday morning, bowl down. Some dogs that didn't eat Sunday eat now. Most do. The ones that don't get the bowl up at 10 minutes again. See you tomorrow.

Tuesday morning, bowl down. By now, almost every dog is eating. The few that aren't — those are the dogs that are going to teach me something interesting about themselves. We hold.

Most dogs eat by Wednesday at the latest. The longest hold I ever had was that 12-day Rottweiler. Between him and the average dog there's a whole spectrum, but the *protocol does not change*. I do the same thing on day two as I do on day twelve. Bowl down, 10 minutes, bowl up. Same time tomorrow.

The reason I tell you this is to point out something important: **my willpower does not waver based on what day of the protocol it is**. Day three I'm not panicked. Day five I'm not panicked. Day eight I'm not panicked. The protocol is the protocol. The dog will eat when the dog decides to eat. My job is to be there with the bowl at the same time every day and not negotiate. That's it.

You need to develop the same mindset. Not because you're a robot. Because if your willpower wavers based on how long the holdout has gone, you've handed the dog a strategy: *just hold out longer*. Every time you cave at hour 36 instead of hour 24, you've taught the dog that 36 is the magic number. Cave at hour 48 next week and you've taught them 48 is the magic number. There is no magic number. The number is *however long it takes for the dog to decide to eat*.

BRIAN-ISM

If we sit here for two hours, we sit here for two hours. I don't care. I have stronger willpower than you do.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Same protocol. Same time. Same 10-minute window. Don't change anything.

What I want you to do *additionally* today is take a hard look at your environment and ask yourself if there are any failure points you missed.

Walk through your house and check for accidental food access.

- Any food on counters at dog-height?
- Any open garbage cans?
- Crumbs under the dining room table?
- A kid's snack stash in a low cabinet?
- The cat's food bowl?
- A bird feeder in the yard the dog grazes under?
- Compost bin?
- Any neighbor who's been slipping treats over the fence?

Anything the dog can self-feed from, the protocol is not actually running. We are running the protocol on whatever the dog is intentionally being fed by you, while the dog is being secretly fed from these other sources. The dog is not stupid. They will find the access points. Your job is to find them first and close them.

Talk to whoever else lives with you. Yes, again. The household conversation from Day 1 was preventive. Today's is enforcement. Nicely, no fight: *"We're three days into this. Has anyone slipped him anything? It's important — even one piece of cheese resets the whole thing."* If the answer is yes, you don't yell, you don't lecture. You just say: *"Okay. We can't do that. Let's restart from today."*

Check your own behavior. This one is uncomfortable. The number of owners who've sworn to me they were running the protocol perfectly and then admitted, three weeks later, that they'd been giving the dog a piece of cheese here and there — it's a lot. Be honest with yourself today. If you've slipped, restart from Day 2 tomorrow. There's no shame. There's only the work.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The reason willpower is the active ingredient in this protocol is that the dog is constantly running tests on you. Not maliciously. They're not plotting. It's just how dogs learn — they try things, they observe what happens, they adjust their behavior based on the outcome.

Dog's test today: *will my human cave if I refuse one more meal?*

Your answer needs to be: no.

If your answer wavers — if today you say no but tomorrow at hour 47 you say yes — the dog learns that refusal works at scale. The number of refusals goes up over time, not down, because every time you finally cave it confirms the strategy.

Conversely, the dog who refuses one meal, gets nothing, and then eats normally at the next meal — that dog has learned the opposite lesson. *Refusal does not produce a better outcome. Refusal produces nothing. Eating produces eating. The right answer is to eat.*

Notice that lesson is much, much faster to install than its opposite. Most dogs need one or two cycles of refusal-then-acceptance to get it. The dogs who go five days and then eat — those are dogs whose

owners caved early in some prior food relationship and the dog learned that holding out can take days but does eventually pay off. We're un-installing that prior learning. It takes a little longer.

The dog isn't fighting you. The dog is just running the strategy that's worked for them in the past, and they'll keep running it until it stops working.

Today, your job is to make sure it stops working.

Remember what I told you in Day 1: every meal you hold the line on this week is one less correction you have to use on your dog for the rest of their life. That's the trade.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: What if I cave one time? Like, I really did slip them a treat. Is the protocol dead?

A: Restart from Day 2 tomorrow. Don't try to "continue from where you were minus the slip." Restart clean. Yes, that costs you a couple of days. The cost of pretending it didn't happen and continuing is much higher — you'll get inconsistent results and won't know why. Restart, run clean from there, get back on track.

Q: My dog has been throwing up bile every morning since we started. Should I stop?

A: Same answer as Day 3 — small bile vomits on an empty stomach are usually harmless but if it persists across multiple mornings, that's a vet conversation. The protocol-friendly fix is to keep a small portion (1/4 to 1/3 of the daily ration) reserved for an evening "settle-the-stomach" handful at the same time each evening. Same total daily food, just spread to give the stomach something at night. The 10-minute and 24-hour rules still apply to both portions.

Q: I gave in. He looked so sad. I gave him a piece of chicken.

A: Restart from Day 2 tomorrow. Don't beat yourself up — this is the most common failure point in the entire program and you're not the first. But restart. Don't try to continue from Day 4. The dog has now logged that Day 4 is when chicken happens, and if you don't reset, you'll see refusals at Day 4 of every future cycle.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did you hold the line today? Same time, 10-minute window, no extra food, no slip-ups, no household members slipping anything? If yes, you're on track. If no, you reset to Day 2 tomorrow. Don't continue while pretending. The dog can tell.

TOMORROW

By tomorrow most dogs are eating. If yours is, we keep going. If yours isn't, we keep going. The only thing that changes day to day is which one of us is feeling the discomfort more — them or you. Don't let it be you.

Day 5 — The Bowl-Eating Checkpoint

This is the first major gate in the program. You either pass and start Phase 2, or you stay here until you pass.

- ▶ **Before you start today.** You've been on the bowl-feeding protocol for at least three full days (Days 2, 3, 4). You've held the line on any refusals. Today is a checkpoint day — we measure where we actually are before we move on.

WHAT "PASSING" LOOKS LIKE

The gate to leave Phase 1 (bowl-feeding) and enter Phase 2 (hand-feeding) is one specific thing: **your dog has eaten their bowl meal immediately upon presentation, finishing it within a few minutes, for four to five consecutive days.**

Read that again, because the words matter:

- **Immediately upon presentation.** Not "after I leave the room." Not "ten minutes in." When the bowl hits the floor, the dog goes to it.
- **Finishing it.** All of it. Not most of it. Not "they ate the meaty parts and left the kibble." All of it.
- **Within a few minutes.** Not "they grazed and finished by the 9-minute mark." Real working interest in the food — head down, eating, done in maybe 2 to 5 minutes for a normal-sized dog.
- **Four to five consecutive days.** Not "they had three good days and one bad day." A clean streak.

If all of those are true, you've passed the gate. Tomorrow we add hand-feeding.

If any of those are not true, **you are still in Phase 1.** Today's entry is "do exactly what you've been doing for another day or two until you pass the gate." There is no penalty for staying here. The penalty comes from advancing before you've passed.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IF YOU HAVEN'T PASSED YET

Most likely scenarios at the Day 5 mark, and what each means:

"My dog has eaten the bowl every time but takes the full 10 minutes to finish."

You're close but not there. The dog is eating because the food is finite, but they're not yet *enthusiastic* about it. They're eating reluctantly. We need eating that has energy in it. Stay here a few more days. Most of these dogs flip from reluctant to eager within another 2-3 days as the routine settles.

"My dog has eaten some days and refused others."

Not passed. The streak isn't clean. Stay in Phase 1, hold the line on the refusals, look for 4-5 consecutive clean days. This dog is still testing. A few more refusals usually closes the test.

"My dog has refused for multiple days in a row and we're now on day 4 or 5 with no eating."

You're in the genuinely-holding-out group. Hold the line. Re-read Day 4. The dog is fine. Most dogs in this category eat by day 5 or 6. Some go longer. The protocol does not change.

"My dog ate the first day, refused the second, ate the third, refused the fourth."

Classic alternating pattern. The dog is still figuring out the rules. Hold the line. After two or three more cycles of this, the alternating usually collapses into consistent eating.

"My dog has eaten enthusiastically every day from Day 2."

You probably passed the gate around Day 5 or 6 with no drama. Read tomorrow's entry. You're moving on.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The reason the gate is rigid is that hand-feeding is a much harder ask of the dog than bowl-feeding. In bowl-feeding, the dog goes to the bowl on their own terms. The bowl doesn't move, doesn't make demands, doesn't require attention. In hand-feeding, the food is in your hand, requires the dog to engage with you, requires the dog to be actively oriented toward you, and requires the dog to take individual pieces from a moving target.

A dog who is reluctant about the bowl will be flatly unable to do hand-feeding. They'll back away, refuse the hand, or take a single piece and walk off. We won't be able to get the rep volume we need for the next phase, and the whole thing will stall.

So we wait until the bowl phase is rock solid. The dog has to be at the level of *eager bowl-eating* before we can step up to *hand-feeding*. There is no shortcut.

The other thing this gate does is build *your* confidence as a handler. By passing this checkpoint cleanly, you've now successfully run a multi-day behavioral protocol with consistency, on a dog, in your home. That's not nothing. Most owners have never done that. The reason their dog is in the state it's in is because they've never strung together five consecutive days of consistent rule-enforcement on anything. Today, you have. You're a different handler than you were on Day 1, and your dog can already tell.

BRIAN-ISM

There is never a danger in just going slower and making sure the dog fully understands something before you move on.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog passed all four criteria. Can I start hand-feeding today?

A: Wait one more day. Just to be sure. Tomorrow's entry assumes you've had a clean streak going into hand-feeding day, and an extra day on bowl-feeding never hurt anybody. Take the buffer.

Q: My dog has been on the protocol for 7 days and still won't eat consistently. Is something wrong with them?

A: Statistically, no. Behaviorally, this is a stubborn dog who's still figuring out the rules. The protocol does not change. Keep going. Most of these dogs flip somewhere between day 7 and day 14. If you hit day 14 with no consistent eating, DM me in the Real Dog Rehab community — at that point we want to look at edge cases (medical, environmental, diet-history) and figure out what's specific to your situation. Up until then, just hold.

Q: Should I be praising the dog when they eat?

A: No. Not yet. Eating from the bowl is just how things work now — it's not a behavior we're reinforcing with praise. Don't make it a big deal. The dog eating their bowl should feel like the dog drinking water. Just the baseline. Praise comes later, when we start training behaviors. For now, neutral, no fanfare.

Q: My dog is losing weight. Is that okay?

A: A little weight loss in the first week is normal and almost always healthy — most pet dogs are overweight, and a slight cut is doing them a favor. If you're seeing dramatic weight loss (visible bones appearing where there weren't bones before) or if the dog seems lethargic or weak, that's the medical-edge case I told you about. Otherwise, slight loss in week one is expected.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did your dog meet all four criteria — immediate eating, finishing the bowl, within a few minutes, four to five consecutive days? **Yes:** advance to Day 6 tomorrow. **No:** stay here. Run today's protocol again exactly as written, and check the criteria again tomorrow. There is no rush.

TOMORROW

If you passed: hand-feeding. The single biggest jump in the program. Your dog goes from eating-out-of-a-bowl to eating-from-your-hand, and the second is what unlocks every training behavior we'll build over the next 25 days. If you didn't pass: same drill. Same time. Same line.

Day 6 — The First Hand-Feeding Session

Today the bowl goes away. The food now comes from your hand, one piece at a time. This is the first day your dog learns that you are the source of the thing they need.

- **Before you start today.** You passed Day 5's checkpoint. Your dog has been eating their bowl meal immediately, finishing it within a few minutes, for four to five consecutive days. If that's not true, do not run today's protocol — go back to Day 5 and hold there until the gate is passed.

THE STORY

There's a moment in every board-and-train at my facility that I look forward to. It happens somewhere around day 5 or 6. I'm sitting in a chair in the training room, a fresh bowl of the dog's daily ration on the table next to me. The dog walks in. They're hungry — they earned it through the bowl-feeding protocol the same way you've been running yours at home. They look at the bowl. They look at me. They look at the bowl again.

Then I take a piece of kibble out of the bowl. I hold it in my open hand, palm up, at about my waist level. I don't say anything. I don't move toward the dog. I just hold the food there.

What happens next tells me almost everything I need to know about how the next four weeks will go.

The dog who's ready — really ready — will come over within about three seconds. They'll sniff the food, take it cleanly, and look back up at me like *what's next*. That dog is now a trainable dog. Everything we'll do for the rest of the program is going to be paid out one piece at a time from my hand, and that dog has just walked through the door that makes it possible.

The dog who's *almost* ready will come over a little slower, take the food a little more cautiously, and maybe back up a step before chewing. That dog is fine — we just need to do this for a few days before we layer anything else on top.

The dog who's *not yet ready* will come over, sniff, and walk away. Or they'll take the piece and drop it. Or they'll glance at it from across the room and not approach. That dog is going to spend another few days in food-drive work before we can move forward. There's no penalty. We just take the time we need.

You're going to find out today which of those three dogs you have.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Today's session replaces the bowl meal entirely. Same time of day as your normal bowl meal. Same total amount of food. The only thing changing is the delivery method.

Setup:

- Sit in a chair in the middle of a quiet, low-distraction room
- Put the dog's daily ration in a bowl on a side table next to you, within easy reach but not on the floor
- Put the dog on a leash if they tend to wander, with the end of the leash under your foot — this

gives them about 6 feet of slack, enough to move but not enough to leave you. (This is the "modified Skinner box" setup we'll use for marker work next week. Get used to it now.)

- Have nothing else interesting in the room. No toys. No other people. No TV. Just you and the dog and the bowl.

The drill:

1. Take a piece of kibble from the bowl. Hold it in your open hand, palm up, at about waist level.
2. Wait. Don't extend your hand toward the dog. Don't say anything. Don't make kissy noises. Just hold the food there and let the dog notice.
3. When the dog approaches and takes the food, that's a successful rep.
4. Take another piece. Hold it. Repeat.

That's the entire session. Sit there, take a piece out, let the dog come get it. Take another piece, repeat. Run this for as long as the dog stays engaged — usually 5 to 15 minutes for the first session.

What to do if the dog doesn't take the food:

- Wait the full 10 minutes (same rule as bowl-feeding)
- If the dog hasn't engaged with the hand-feeding by minute 10, the bowl goes up — entire portion in the trash or saved for tomorrow — and **no food for 24 hours**, same as a bowl refusal
- Try again at the next meal time tomorrow

What to do if the dog takes food but reluctantly:

- Keep going. Reluctant is okay for the first session. It's not great, but it's workable.
- Run the same setup tomorrow.
- We're looking for the dog to get *eager* over the next 2-3 days. Eager is the target state.

What to do if the dog takes food and is enthusiastic:

- Beautiful. This is the easy version of Day 6.
- Keep going through the entire daily ration if the dog stays engaged.
- The whole bowl, piece by piece, from your hand. That's today's session.

WHY THIS MATTERS

You just unlocked the single most important capability in the entire training relationship: **the ability to pay your dog in the moment.**

Up until today, food existed in your dog's life as something that came in a bowl, on a schedule, separately from anything else they did. There was no connection between any specific behavior and food. Food was just *there*.

Starting today, food only happens *because of you*. It comes from your hand. Your hand is the source. You are the source.

This single change rewires your dog's entire relationship with you over the next two weeks. The dog who used to ignore you because food came from a bowl whether or not you existed — that dog now starts noticing you, because you control the food. The dog who used to walk away from you in any

situation where there wasn't an obvious reason to engage — that dog now starts orienting toward you, because something might happen that involves the bowl on the side table.

This is what trainers mean when they talk about "engagement." Engagement is not a behavior. Engagement is a *state* — the state where the dog is locked onto you, looking to you, waiting to see what you do, because what you do is the most relevant thing in their world.

You can't train engagement. You install the conditions that produce it, and then engagement happens. Today is the first day you installed those conditions.

BRIAN-ISM

I am the button you have to push in order to get the thing that you want.

That's the lesson, in one sentence. From today onward, everything the dog wants — and food is just the first thing in a long list — comes through engaging with you. Tomorrow they'll still want food. The day after, they'll start wanting *you*, because you are where food comes from. That's the engine.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog took every piece. We did the whole bowl in 10 minutes. Now what?

A: Best-case Day 6. Tomorrow, do the same thing. Same setup, same approach, same delivery. We'll run hand-feeding sessions for at least 3-4 days before moving to the marker work in Week 2. Volume of clean reps is what builds the foundation.

Q: My dog took a few pieces and lost interest after 3 minutes.

A: Two possibilities. One — your dog is still over-satiated. They got a partial reset on bowl-feeding but they're still not at maximum food drive. Cut the daily ration by about 1/4 cup tomorrow and re-run. Two — the rep pattern was off; you might have been moving your hand too much, or the room was too distracting, or the dog wasn't quite ready yet. Pick a quieter room, sit still, and try again at the next meal time. If the same thing happens, refuse the rest, bowl up, 24 hours.

Q: My dog took the first piece, then snatched at the second piece and bit my hand.

A: Don't react with a yelp or a yank — that turns it into something interesting. Instead: close your fist around any food the moment the dog gets aggressive about it, hold the closed fist still, and wait. The dog will eventually back off, lose interest in the closed hand, and re-orient. The instant they re-orient cleanly, open the hand, give the food. That hand-in-face engagement drill teaches the dog to take cleanly. We'll do this drill formally in Week 2.

Q: My dog took food from my hand fine but my partner tried later and the dog wouldn't take from them. What gives?

A: Engagement is initially handler-specific. The dog has just learned that you are the food source. They have not yet learned that humans-in-general are food sources. Have your partner run their own first hand-feeding session, separately. The dog will pick it up faster the second time around because the concept transfers, but it has to be installed person-by-person at first.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did your dog take food from your hand for at least the first half of today's session? **Yes — eagerly, finished most or all of the ration:** outstanding. Run Day 7 tomorrow as written. **Yes — but slowly or reluctantly:** workable. Run today's drill again tomorrow before

advancing. **No — refused entirely, took a piece and dropped it, or backed away:** the dog is not yet at the trainable state. Bowl up, 24 hours, run today's protocol again at the next meal time. Don't advance until the dog is taking food readily from your hand.

TOMORROW

We consolidate. Two more days of hand-feeding to make sure the new pattern is locked in before we layer anything on top. Resist the temptation to start clicker work tomorrow. The drill is boring on purpose. Boring is what builds foundations.

Day 7 — Hand-Feeding Consolidation

Today is the same as yesterday. Tomorrow will be the same as today. Boring is the point.

- **Before you start today.** Yesterday's hand-feeding session went reasonably well — at least the first half of the ration got eaten from your hand. If the session crashed early or the dog refused, you should not be on Day 7 yet. Repeat Day 6 until you've had a session where the dog cleanly takes food for at least 5-10 solid minutes.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Same setup as Day 6. Same chair, same bowl on the side table, same leash-under-the-foot, same quiet room, same time of day. Take a piece, hold it palm-up, let the dog come take it. Repeat through the whole bowl.

Two small additions today:

One — start moving the food location around. Yesterday you held the food in the same spot every rep. Today, vary it slightly. One rep, food in your right hand. Next rep, left hand. Next rep, right hand a little higher. Next, left hand a little lower. Don't make a game of it — don't be flashy — just introduce a tiny bit of variation so the dog has to *find* the food each rep instead of just dropping their head into the same spot.

This serves a purpose. It starts teaching the dog to *track you with their attention* rather than just dropping their face into a fixed location. Engagement is the goal. If you hold the food in the same place every time, the dog learns to engage with the spot, not with you.

Two — start noticing the dog's body language. You're not training anything yet, but I want you to start paying attention. After the dog takes a piece of food, what do they do? Do they look up at your face? Do they look back at the bowl? Do they look around the room? Do they look at the door?

What you're hoping to see, gradually over the next few days, is the dog look up at *your face* after each piece. That's the first sign that engagement is starting to install. It usually doesn't happen on day one of hand-feeding. It usually starts emerging on day two or three. By day four or five it should be reliable.

Don't try to make it happen. Don't reward it specifically. Don't say "good." Just notice it. We'll work with it deliberately starting in Week 2.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Owners get bored on Day 7. I know they do. They've now had a couple of successful hand-feeding sessions and they want to start *training*. They want to make the dog do something. They want to introduce the clicker, start saying "sit," start luring positions, do the things they imagined themselves doing when they bought this guide.

Don't.

The single most common way this program fails between Day 7 and Day 11 is the owner getting impatient and starting to layer training behaviors on top of hand-feeding before hand-feeding is

consolidated. What happens is the dog is still figuring out the new food relationship, and now you've added clicker noises and verbal cues and shaping attempts on top of a foundation that wasn't dry yet. The result is a dog who's confused on multiple fronts at once and a marker that never quite loads cleanly because the food-drive piece wasn't all the way solid when you started layering.

The fix is what you're doing today: be patient. Run another day of just hand-feeding. And then another. The boring days are the days that pay you back the most when you start the actual training.

There's an old principle in training: *you can't go too slow on the foundation*. If anything, the dogs that look the most spectacular after 30 days are usually the dogs whose owners spent an extra two days on hand-feeding when nobody was telling them to. The dogs that flame out at Day 18 are the dogs whose owners advanced from hand-feeding to clicker work after two sessions of hand-feeding because they were excited.

BRIAN-ISM

Calm repetitions win.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog is now mugging my hand for food. Is that engagement?

A: No, that's the dog targeting the food directly. Engagement is the dog targeting **you** because you're where the food comes from. The hand-in-face drill from Day 6's Q&A is the fix — close fist, wait for the dog to back off and re-orient, then open and pay. We'll do this systematically next week.

Q: How do I know I'm not over-feeding? My dog is eating a lot of small pieces.

A: Total daily food = same as it was when you started, which is the bag's recommendation for ideal weight. It just gets delivered piece by piece instead of in a bowl. If your dog was getting 2 cups a day before, they get 2 cups a day now. If anything, hand-feeding tends to under-feed slightly because some pieces get dropped, sniffed-over, or you stop a session early. Periodically weigh the dog and adjust the ration up or down by a quarter cup based on the trend. Don't change anything based on a single weigh-in.

Q: Can I start adding the clicker now? I'm getting impatient.

A: No. Wait until Day 11. The next 3-4 days are pure hand-feeding consolidation. The protocol works because the foundation is built in this order: food drive first, hand-feeding second, marker third, behaviors fourth. Skip a step and the next step doesn't load right.

Q: My dog is eating fine but seems sad.

A: Define sad. If the dog is alert, drinking water, walking around, sleeping normally — they're fine. They're not "sad." They're a dog with a slightly different food schedule than they had a week ago. Most of what owners read as "sadness" in the first week of this protocol is the owner's own discomfort projected onto the dog. The dog is fine.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did your dog work through the hand-feeding session today with reasonable engagement — taking pieces, eating them, coming back for more? If yes, you're on track. If no — if the session crashed early or the dog refused mid-way — that's a step back. Bowl up, 24 hours, repeat tomorrow.

TOMORROW

More hand-feeding. Same drill. We're building the rep count and the attention pattern that will be the foundation for the marker work in Week 2.

Day 8 — Building Hunger, Not Starving

Today's entry is short. By now the protocol is the protocol. What matters today is understanding the difference between a hungry dog and a starving dog — and why the first one is what we want.

► **Before you start today.** You've done two days of hand-feeding. The dog is engaging with the hand and taking food. If they're not, go back to Day 6 — don't run today's content yet.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Run hand-feeding again. Same setup. Same time. Whole ration through the hand.

There is one new thing to think about today, and it's about **calibration of the daily food amount**.

Pull up the food bag. Find the recommended daily amount for your dog's *ideal* weight (not current). If your dog is overweight, that ideal-weight ration is going to be less food than what they were originally eating. That's correct. That's the protocol.

What I want you to do today is take a hard, honest look at your dog and ask: *am I feeding the right amount?*

Here's the test. Stand over your dog and look down. You should see a clear waist tucking in behind the ribs — not bulging out, not flat. From the side, you should see the belly tuck up slightly behind the ribcage, not hang down level with the chest. You should be able to feel ribs with light pressure (touching, not squishing) but not see them sharply.

If your dog has visible waist, slight belly tuck, and findable-but-not-visible ribs — that's lean, athletic, healthy. Keep the ration where it is.

If your dog has no waist, no belly tuck, and you have to push hard to find ribs — that's overweight. Cut a quarter to a half cup off the daily ration. Re-evaluate weekly.

If your dog has visible ribs without touching, sharp hip bones, visible spine ridge — that's underweight. Add a quarter to a half cup to the daily ration. Re-evaluate weekly. (This is the dog who needed the underweight modification flagged in Day 1 — if you're seeing this for the first time today, that's the alert. Read Day 1's medical caveats and consider messaging me before tomorrow.)

WHY THIS MATTERS

There is a distinction between **hungry** and **starving** that most pet owners have lost track of, and it's worth installing today.

A hungry dog is a dog whose stomach is empty, whose body is in normal energy-conservation mode between meals, and who is highly motivated to acquire food when food becomes available. A hungry dog is alert, eyes bright, body language oriented toward food sources, willing to work. **Hungry is the state we want.** It's the state every wild canid lives in for most of their life. It's the state that makes training possible.

A starving dog is a dog whose body has burned through its reserves and is breaking down muscle tissue for energy. A starving dog is lethargic, weak, has visible bone structure, is not interested in

working, may not even be interested in food because their body has down-regulated past the point of motivation. **Starving is what we are not doing.** Starving is genuinely harmful. Starving is what owners are afraid of — and what they would never actually produce by running this protocol.

The gap between hungry and starving is enormous. Multiple weeks. Many missed meals. Significant body composition change. **You will not accidentally starve a healthy dog with this protocol.** It is mechanically not possible inside the timeline we're working with.

What you may be doing if you're feeding too much is keeping your dog perpetually *over-satiated* — never quite hungry, never really motivated to eat, never building the food drive that this whole program rests on. That's not a kindness either. That's actually the state most pet dogs live in, and it's the reason their behavioral problems exist.

The right state for a working dog — for the next 30 days and ideally for the rest of their life — is **healthy lean weight, mildly hungry between meals, eager when food appears.** That's where we're aiming.

BRIAN-ISM

If you go to offer your dog food and your dog's like, "man, I'll take it, but I'm not excited about it" — that means they're over-satiated. Cut the food more.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: How quickly should I cut the food if my dog is overweight?

A: Quarter cup per day off the recommended ration, hold for a week, weigh, adjust. Don't cut dramatically all at once — that's not safer or faster, it's just chaotic. Steady incremental adjustments held for a week each.

Q: My dog finished the hand-feeding session but seemed less excited today than yesterday. Bad sign?

A: Possibly over-satiated, possibly the room was different, possibly your timing was off. First check is the food amount. If the dog was very enthusiastic on Day 6 and 7 and is gentler today, they may just be eating into their normal appetite curve as the protocol stabilizes — not a problem. If the energy keeps dropping over the next 2 days, cut a quarter cup and see if they re-spark.

Q: Will I have to do this once-a-day feeding forever?

A: Yes, that's my recommendation for almost every adult dog. Once-a-day matches their digestive cycle (24 to 48 hours) better than multiple meals. The pet industry trained people to feed multiple times a day because that's what dog food companies sell more of. Biologically, once a day is better. I do it with all of my dogs and have for many years.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did the hand-feeding session run cleanly? Did you assess your dog's body condition and either confirm the ration is right or make an incremental adjustment? If yes to both, advance to Day 9 tomorrow. If the session crashed, repeat today's drill before advancing.

TOMORROW

The trainable-dog test. The real diagnostic for whether you're ready to start marker work.

Day 9 — The Trainable-Dog Test

Today we run the actual diagnostic that determines whether you're ready to start training behaviors. This is more rigorous than just "they ate from your hand."

- ▶ **Before you start today.** You've done at least three days of hand-feeding sessions. Your dog has been taking food from your hand for the majority of each session. Body condition is being monitored.

WHAT "TRAINABLE" ACTUALLY MEANS

There's a difference between *a dog who will eat from your hand* and *a dog who is trainable using food as a reinforcer*. They sound the same. They're not.

A dog who will eat from your hand is willing to take food from your hand under cooperative, low-distraction conditions. Most dogs reach this state within 2-3 days of hand-feeding once food drive is restored.

A dog who is *trainable using food as a reinforcer* is a dog whose food drive is high enough that food can compete with other things the dog wants in the moment — distractions, novelty, the urge to wander off. That's a much higher bar, and it's the bar we actually need to clear before we start marker work, because the marker work is going to involve the dog making choices about whether to engage with you when other things are also available.

Today's test is designed to find out which of those two states your dog is actually in.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Today's session is structured slightly differently. Instead of the standard hand-feeding setup, we're going to deliberately introduce some mild competing motivators and see how your dog responds.

Test 1 — the hand-take-and-look-up test.

Setup: standard hand-feeding setup — chair, leash, side table, bowl. Take a piece of kibble. Hold it palm-up. Wait for the dog to take it. After they take and chew the piece, what do they do?

- **They look up at your face within 1-2 seconds:** great. That's developing engagement. Pass.
- **They look around the room, not at your face:** the dog has the food drive but isn't yet paying attention to you specifically as the food source. Workable, but we want to see this shift over the next few days. Conditional pass.
- **They walk away from you and disengage entirely:** food drive isn't strong enough yet. Fail. Stay in hand-feeding consolidation.

Test 2 — the closed-fist test (the hand-in-face drill).

Setup: same. Take a piece of kibble. **Close your fist around it.** Hold the closed fist 4-6 inches in front of the dog's nose. Don't open the fist. Don't say anything.

The dog will try to get to the food. They'll nose your hand. They'll lick. They might paw. They might try to nibble.

Do nothing. Hold the fist completely steady. Don't open it. Don't react. Don't push the dog away. Just hold.

Eventually — could take 10 seconds, could take a minute — the dog will give up trying to access the food directly and re-orient. Most commonly they'll back off, sit down, and look at your face like *what's the puzzle here*.

The instant the dog re-orient's away from your fist and looks at your face — open the hand, let them eat the piece.

That's the test. We want to see the dog give up the direct approach and pivot to engagement. That pivot is the proof that engagement is starting to install.

- **Dog pivoted within 30 seconds:** pass. Strong food drive plus emerging engagement. Ready for Week 2.
- **Dog pivoted, but it took 60-90 seconds:** marginal pass. Workable, but you might want one more day of hand-feeding before starting marker work.
- **Dog never pivoted — gave up entirely and walked away:** fail. The food drive isn't strong enough yet to keep them in the puzzle. Stay in hand-feeding for another 2-3 days.

Test 3 — the brief-distraction test.

Setup: same. Take a piece. Hold it palm-up. As the dog starts to approach to take it, have someone in the household walk through the room — or, if you're alone, drop a quiet object (like a wadded-up piece of paper) onto the floor 4 feet away.

What does the dog do?

- **Notes the distraction but takes the food and re-engages with you:** strong pass. Food is competing successfully with the environment.
- **Looks at the distraction, hesitates, then takes the food:** workable. Food is competing but barely. Conditional pass.
- **Abandons the food entirely to investigate the distraction:** fail. Food isn't yet strong enough as a motivator. Stay in hand-feeding.

WHY THIS MATTERS

We're not doing these tests because they're entertaining. We're doing them because **the rest of this program does not work if your dog isn't actually at the trainable-dog state.**

In Week 2, we're going to start marker conditioning, which requires the dog to associate a sound (the click) with food in the moment. That association only forms if the dog is paying attention when the click happens. If the dog is still indifferent to your hand most of the time, the click goes by unnoticed and the marker doesn't load.

Then we're going to free-shape the base positions, which requires the dog to *try things* — to offer behaviors voluntarily, to engage with the puzzle of figuring out what earns the click. That problem-solving only happens if the dog is motivated enough to keep working when easy answers don't immediately produce food. A dog who'd rather walk away than figure out a puzzle is not going to free-shape.

So the trainable-dog test is the gate. Pass, and Week 2 will go smoothly. Fail, and Week 2 will be a frustrating mess where neither you nor the dog understand what's happening.

The honest assessment is the kind one. There is no shame in spending another 3, 5, or 7 days at hand-feeding consolidation. There is significant pain in advancing too early.

BRIAN-ISM

There is never a danger in just going slower and making sure the dog fully understands something before you move on.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog passed two of three tests but failed the distraction test. Where does that put me?

A: Conditional pass. You can advance to Day 10 tomorrow, but you'll want to keep distraction levels low when you start marker work in Week 2. Run marker conditioning in your quietest room. We'll build distraction tolerance later.

Q: My dog passed all three tests on Day 6, before any consolidation. Can I skip ahead?

A: Pass on Day 6 is fast. It happens, especially with already-engaged dogs whose food drive just needed to be restored to baseline. You can advance, but I'd still recommend running through Days 7, 8, and 9 as written rather than skipping. The reps build a foundation that pays back in Week 2 even if it feels redundant now.

Q: My dog failed all three tests. Now what?

A: Stay here. Run the standard hand-feeding session for another 3-5 days, then re-test. If you're still failing on Day 14 or Day 15, DM me in the community. Some dogs take longer because of prior food trauma, particular breed traits, or specific household conditions. The protocol may need a small adjustment for your specific situation.

Q: Have I been adjusting the food amount through this whole week?

A: You should have been making small adjustments based on body condition (Day 8). If you haven't and your dog still seems over-satiated, drop the daily ration by a quarter cup tomorrow. The under-fed-but-not-starving state is what unlocks the trainable-dog test.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** How did your dog perform on the three tests? **Strong pass on all three:** advance to Day 10. **Conditional pass on most, fail on one:** advance to Day 10 with awareness that you'll need to manage distraction levels carefully. **Failed two or three tests:** stay in hand-feeding consolidation. Repeat today's tests every 2-3 days until you pass.

TOMORROW

The Week 1 checkpoint. The major gate before we leave food drive work and enter the actual training phase. You'll know exactly where you stand.

Day 10 — Week 1 Checkpoint: Are You Ready to Start Training?

This is the major gate. Pass it and Week 2 begins. Fail it and you stay here until you pass.

- **Before you start today.** You've completed Days 1-9. You've run the hand-feeding protocol for at least 4 days. You ran the trainable-dog test yesterday and saw where you stand.

THE GATE

Five questions. Answer each honestly. All five need to be yes before you advance to Day 11.

1. Is your dog eating a single daily meal, immediately upon presentation, with enthusiasm — every day for the past 5+ days?

Not "most days." Every day. Immediate. Enthusiastic.

2. Is your dog taking food eagerly from your hand for the duration of a full hand-feeding session?

Not just "the first few pieces." The whole session. The whole bowl.

3. Has your dog been free of any food source other than your hand for the past several days — no treats, no bully sticks, no scraps from the table, no food sneaked by household members?

Honesty matters here. If anyone in the house has slipped the dog anything, the answer is no.

4. Did your dog pass the trainable-dog test yesterday — the hand-look-up, the closed-fist pivot, and competing with at least mild distraction?

Conditional pass on test 3 (the distraction test) is okay. Hard fail on tests 1 or 2 is not.

5. Are you confident — actually confident, not "I hope so" — that you can hold the line on the food protocol for another 20 days while we add the rest of the training on top?

This is about you, not the dog. If you've been wavering this whole week, that wavering is going to get worse when training adds more variables. Be honest.

WHAT IT MEANS IF YOU PASSED

Move to Day 11 tomorrow. Welcome to Week 2.

You should know what you've actually accomplished this week. You've: - Restored your dog's food drive to a working level - Shifted your dog's relationship with food from passive consumer to active worker - Built the daily structure of one meal, hand-delivered, contingent on engagement - Started installing the early signs of engagement — the dog looking to you as the source - Held the line through whatever resistance the dog (and your own discomfort) threw at you - Become a different handler than you were on Day 1

Most pet owners never do any of this. You did it in ten days. You can be proud of that. Don't let the pride make you sloppy in Week 2 — the foundation is in but it's not load-bearing yet, that takes another two weeks of consistent application.

WHAT IT MEANS IF YOU DIDN'T PASS

Stay here. Don't move on.

I want to be very direct about this because the temptation right now will be enormous. You've done a week of hard work. You want progress. You want to start "real" training. You want the next entry to be exciting, not the same hand-feeding session for the fourth time.

Resist. The cost of advancing now, before the gate is passed, is that Week 2 will fall apart. The marker won't load. The dog won't engage with shaping sessions. You'll end up confused and frustrated, blaming the dog or the protocol or yourself, when the actual problem is that the foundation wasn't ready and you knew it but pushed forward anyway.

Stay here for 3-5 more days. Run the same hand-feeding sessions. Re-test on Day 13 or so. The gate will pass when the gate passes — not when you want it to.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The reason for the rigid gate is that everything in Week 2 is *mechanically downstream* of having a fully restored food drive. There is no version of the marker work that succeeds with a half-restored food drive. There is no version of free shaping that succeeds with a dog who isn't fully engaged with their handler as the food source. The whole structure of the next 20 days assumes the foundation is in.

This is why — even though I know it's frustrating — I tell every owner the same thing: the dogs who take longest at the foundation outperform the dogs who got rushed every single time. Always. Without exception. The slow start is the fast finish.

The other thing I want to acknowledge: if you're reading this on Day 10 and you're still on Path B from Day 3 — meaning your dog is still throwing refusals after a week-plus — you're not failing. You have a hard case. Hard cases happen. The protocol does not change. Hold the line. Most of the genuinely-tough holdouts I see at my facility cave between day 7 and day 10. A few go longer. The one outlier in 22 years was the 12-day Rottweiler. Your dog will get there.

BRIAN-ISM

*Their brain will go back to nature. The rabbit doesn't run off if you don't eat?
Yeah, that's not how it actually works.*

A NOTE BEFORE YOU MOVE FORWARD

Whether you passed today or you're still working toward it, I want to flag one thing for the next phase.

The food drive work doesn't stop on Day 10. It continues *forever*. What we're going to do starting in Week 2 is **transition the daily ration from being delivered all at once at a hand-feeding session to being delivered in pieces throughout the day during training sessions**. Same total food. Same once-a-day model. Different delivery.

Every piece of kibble your dog eats from now until graduation comes through work. Either through a marker session, or a shaping session, or pressure work, or — eventually, in week 3 — through holding

obedience in the face of distractions. The bowl-meal is going to disappear entirely as a concept. Food just becomes the paycheck for whatever training rep happened that day.

This is what I call the *existential food model*. Every calorie comes through work. If the dog refuses to work mid-day, training stops, food goes away, the 24-hour cycle re-engages. Same protocol you've been running for the last 9 days, just embedded inside the larger training structure.

Why am I telling you this now? Because some of you have been thinking the food drive thing was a *Week 1* thing — a temporary pain you have to push through to get to the "real" training, after which the bowl comes back. It does not. The bowl is gone. The food protocol is the air your training program now breathes in.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Five questions. All yes? Advance to Day 11. Any no? Stay here, repeat the consolidation drills, re-check in 3-5 days. There is no penalty for waiting. There is significant penalty for pretending.

TOMORROW (OR WHENEVER YOU PASS)

We meet the clicker. We start loading the marker that will be the engine of the next 20 days of training. This is where the program gets visibly fun.

WEEK 2 · DAYS 11–20

Markers, Engagement, and Three Base Positions

With food drive restored, we install the marker, build voluntary engagement, and free-shape the three foundational positions — sit, down, and place — without a single verbal cue or pound of pressure.

Day 11 — Pick Your Markers and Load the Clicker

Today the clicker becomes a thing in your dog's life. The drill is mechanical and easy. The mistake everyone makes is being sloppy about the order of operations. Don't be.

- **Before you start today.** You passed the Day 10 checkpoint. Your dog has restored food drive, takes food eagerly from your hand, and is starting to look at your face after each piece. If any of that's not solid, go back to Day 10 — don't run today.

THE STORY

I want to tell you about a moment that happens in almost every member call I run. Somebody describes a training problem — their dog won't sit, won't stay, won't recall, whatever. I ask a few questions. Then I ask the diagnostic question: *"Did you load the marker before you started teaching the behavior?"*

Maybe a quarter of the people I ask have actually done a real marker load. The rest say one of two things. Either *"I think so?"* — which means no — or *"I clicked while I gave the food, isn't that the same thing?"* — which also means no.

The reason this matters is that almost every training problem people bring to me at the early stage of their dog's training — the dog who won't engage, the dog who isn't responsive to corrections, the dog who tunes out the cues — traces back to a marker that was never properly loaded in the first place. The marker was used like a noisemaker, not a conditioned signal. The dog never learned that the click *means* food is coming. So when the click happens, the dog doesn't react to it the way a properly-loaded dog does — they don't break their neck spinning toward the handler. They just kind of glance over, like *huh, weird sound*.

You don't want that dog. You want the dog whose marker is, as I like to say, **loaded with dynamite**. Where you can be standing across the yard from the dog while the dog is sniffing something, and you click once — and that dog is in the air toward you before the sound has finished traveling.

Today we start building that dog.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Today is mechanical. Two short sessions, maybe 5-10 minutes each, separated by a few hours.

Setup:

- The standard hand-feeding setup: chair, leash-under-foot, dog with about 6 feet of slack, daily ration in a bowl on a side table beside you
- The clicker in the hand that's *closest to the bowl*, not the one you'll feed from
- Your other hand free for delivering food

The drill — the rep that loads the marker:

This is the most important rule of today's session, and the one that decides whether your marker actually loads or just makes noise:

1. **Click.** One distinct click.
2. *Pause.* Count "one one-thousand" in your head. Don't move yet.
3. **Reach** for a piece of food from the bowl.
4. **Pay** the dog — hand the food directly to them.
5. *Pause.* Hands back to neutral position.
6. **Click.** Repeat.

That's it. Click, pause, reach, pay. In that exact order. Run that sequence over and over for the entire session.

Two things you must absolutely not do:

Do not click and reach simultaneously. This is the most common mistake. People click with one hand while the other hand is already moving toward the food. The problem with this is that the dog reads the *hand movement* as the marker, not the click. The dog's brain says "the moving hand means food is coming." The click becomes background noise — useless. It will never load if you do this. The pause between click and reach is what teaches the dog that the *sound* is what predicts food, not your body language.

Do not pre-load food in your hand. Some people, trying to be efficient, hold a piece of food in their fist while they click, then open the fist after the click. Same problem. The dog can smell the food in your hand. They're already focused on the food before you click. The click is just noise that happens between when they noticed the food and when they got it. It doesn't load. Take the food *after* the click. Every rep.

The order is non-negotiable: **click** → **one one-thousand** → **reach** → **pay**. If you have to slow yourself down so you can do this in the right order, do that. Speed will come. Cleanliness comes first.

HOW LONG TODAY'S SESSIONS SHOULD RUN

Two sessions today, ideally with a few hours between them. Each session can run anywhere from 5 to 15 minutes — whatever it takes to get through about a third of the daily ration in each session, with the remainder going in a third session tomorrow morning if needed.

Don't power through the entire daily ration in one marathon session. The dog's attention starts to fade after about 15 minutes of intense rep work, especially early in the conditioning. Better to do two crisp 10-minute sessions than one sloppy 25-minute session.

PICKING YOUR MARKERS

While we're here, let me make a recommendation. You're going to use three markers in this program eventually. Pick them today and use them consistently.

Terminal marker — the clicker. A double-click means *behavior is complete, come get paid*. The food gets delivered to the dog (or the dog comes to the food source) once they hear the double-click. We're starting today with a *single* click during conditioning, but once the marker is loaded I'll start using double-clicks deliberately when I want a high-energy "come get it" moment.

Continuation marker — the word "yep." Spoken short and clipped. Means *you're doing great, keep doing exactly what you're doing, the paycheck is coming to you*. This marker we'll load in Week 3 once the clicker is solid. The reason for "yep" instead of "yes" is that "yes" sounds different when you're calm versus when you're excited. Same word, two different sounds, the dog gets confused. "Yep" is short enough that you can't deform it — it sounds the same whether you're calm or thrilled. Consistency matters more than enthusiasm.

Negative marker — the word "no." Spoken once, calm, not yelled. This is not how most people use the word "no" with their dog. Most people use "no" as an emotional reaction. We're going to use it as a *marker* — a deliberately conditioned signal that means *that was the wrong thing, pressure is coming back, fix it*. We'll formally introduce this in Week 3 when we have something the dog can actually be wrong about. For this week, just don't use the word "no" at all. We don't want it to mean anything yet because we haven't conditioned it.

For today, the only marker that matters is the click. Use it cleanly. Repeat the rep.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Markers exist because dogs have about a 1.25-second window in which they can associate a reinforcement (or a punishment) with a behavior. Beyond that window, the connection is lost. The dog can't tie the food to the behavior because too much time has passed.

The problem this creates: there's no human on earth who can reliably deliver food into a dog's mouth within 1.25 seconds of the moment a behavior happens. By the time you've reached for the food, opened the bag, gotten a piece out, and handed it over, you're at 3-4 seconds easily. The window has closed. The dog gets the food, but they don't tie it to the specific moment of the behavior.

The marker is what fixes this. The click happens *the instant* the behavior occurs — well within the 1.25-second window. The click triggers the dopamine response immediately, because by the end of conditioning the click is food in the dog's brain. The actual food can then arrive 5 seconds later, 10 seconds later — doesn't matter. The marker locked in the connection at the moment it had to be locked in.

Think of the marker like a Polaroid camera. You snap the picture at the exact moment the behavior happens. The picture freezes that moment. The dog can look at the picture and know exactly which behavior earned the reward, even after the reward arrives later.

Without a loaded marker, you're trying to train a dog with a 5-second delay between behavior and reward. Outside the 1.25-second window. Doesn't work, ever.

BRIAN-ISM

Click, one one-thousand, reach, pay. That's literally all I'm doing.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog flinched at the first click. Should I worry?

A: No, very common. Dogs are sound-sensitive and clickers are sharp. If your dog is genuinely scared, you can muffle the click by clicking inside your pocket or wrapping the clicker in a sock for the first session — same drill, quieter sound. After a couple of reps where click predicts food, the flinch usually disappears completely. If your dog stays seriously freaked out about the sound after a session, switch to a softer marker — some trainers use a ballpoint pen click, which is quieter. The principle is the same; the sound is just different.

Q: My dog isn't reacting to the click at all. Just chews the food and waits.

A: That's normal for the first session. The marker isn't loaded yet — that's what today's session is doing. The click is currently meaningless to the dog. By the end of today's session and tomorrow's, you should start to see the dog look at you the moment the click happens, before you've reached for the food. That's the marker starting to load.

Q: Can I just say 'yes' or 'good' instead of using a clicker?

A: Eventually, yes — that's what the continuation marker work in a few days is about. But the clicker is better as the first marker because it's mechanically consistent. Same sound every time. You can't accidentally make the click louder when you're excited or softer when you're tired. The verbal markers come after the clicker is established because the verbal piggybacks on the conditioning the click already did.

Q: How many reps until the marker is loaded?

A: Some dogs get there in 50-100 clean reps, which is one or two sessions. Most need a few hundred reps over 2-3 days. Some take a week. There's a test for it tomorrow. Don't try to speed it up — clean reps build the load, sloppy reps break it.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did you run two sessions today using the click → one one-thousand → reach → pay sequence in clean order? If yes, you're on track. If you found yourself reaching while clicking, or pre-loading food in your hand, the reps don't fully count — clean those up tomorrow.

TOMORROW

Same drill, second day. We'll also test whether the marker is starting to load.

Day 12 — Marker Conditioning, Session Two (And the "Break Their Neck" Test)

Today we run more reps and we run the test that tells us whether the marker is actually loading.

- ▶ **Before you start today.** Yesterday you ran the click → pause → reach → pay drill cleanly across two sessions. The dog is taking food from your hand reliably. If yesterday's reps were sloppy (clicking and reaching simultaneously, pre-loading the hand), back up to Day 11 and clean those mechanics first.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Two more sessions today, same setup, same drill, same order: click, pause, reach, pay. Run them just like yesterday.

The new piece is **the test**. Run this test at the end of today's second session (not the first one — give the marker reps another half-day to consolidate before testing).

The "break their neck" test:

1. After your second session, put a few pieces of kibble in your pocket.
2. Take the leash off the dog. Let them go do whatever they want around the house.
3. Wait until the dog is doing something *other than paying attention to you* — sniffing, lying in the corner, looking out the window, whatever.
4. From wherever you are, **click once**.
5. Watch what the dog does.

What you want to see: the dog **breaks their neck** spinning toward you. Like a string on the back of their head got yanked. They beeline straight to you, eyes locked on you, with the absolute expectation that food is about to happen. You give them a piece. Done. Test passed.

What you might see instead:

The dog looks over at you with mild interest, then goes back to what they were doing. The marker is starting to load but isn't there yet. They've made the connection that click *might* mean food, but they're not sold on it. Run another day or two of conditioning and re-test.

The dog ignores the click entirely. The marker hasn't loaded. There are two likely reasons: (a) yesterday's reps were sloppy and the dog never made the clean association, or (b) the dog needs more reps. Either way, run another full day of clean conditioning tomorrow and re-test on Day 13.

The dog looks at you, comes over slowly, and waits to see if food is going to happen. Conditional pass. The marker is loaded but at a low intensity. You can probably advance, but the snappy "break their neck" reaction tells you the marker has fire — you'll get cleaner training results from a fully-loaded marker than a partially-loaded one. Maybe one more day.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The reason we test specifically by clicking when the dog *isn't paying attention* is that this is the actual condition under which we'll use the marker in real training.

In a free-shaping session, you're going to be sitting there silently while the dog wanders around offering behaviors. You're going to click the *moment* the dog accidentally does something we want — sits, lies down, looks at the place bed, whatever. The dog is not going to be staring at you when this happens. They're going to be in the middle of doing something else. The click has to penetrate that distraction and pull the dog's attention to you.

If the marker is fully loaded, this works. The click triggers an immediate, automatic dopamine response — the dog's brain says *food*, and the body follows. The dog is at you before they've consciously processed what just happened. That's the dynamite-loaded marker.

If the marker is half-loaded, the click triggers an attentive look but no urgent action. The dog turns their head, considers, and either ambles over or doesn't. The training moves at a tenth of the speed and the timing of the dog's response gets fuzzy.

We want dynamite, not a maybe.

BRIAN-ISM

If they break their neck, you have a solidly loaded marker. You are now ready to use that marker to capture free-shaped behavior and begin building the dog of your dreams.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog passed the test on the first try, end of session one. Can I jump ahead?

A: Test it again tomorrow with a different room and different timing. If it passes a second time, your marker is loaded fast — that happens with food-driven, focused dogs whose drive came back hard during Week 1. Run Day 13 as written for one more session of consolidation, then advance to Day 14 with confidence.

Q: My dog passed the test in the kitchen but failed in the living room.

A: The marker hasn't fully generalized across contexts yet. Run more conditioning sessions in the room where it's failing. Markers are conditioned to context as well as to the sound itself, especially early in their life. A few sessions in a different room and the generalization usually catches up.

Q: I clicked and my dog jumped at me with full force and almost knocked me down. Is that the right reaction?

A: That's the reaction. It's a little intense, which is fine — it tells you the marker is loaded with maximum dynamite. We'll channel that energy into shaping next week. For now, brace yourself when you click during the test. Some dogs come in like a freight train.

Q: My dog ignored the click during the test. What did I do wrong?

A: Most likely candidates: (1) you were reaching with the food before the click finished, so the dog associated the hand movement, not the sound; (2) you pre-loaded food in your hand at any point, so the smell of food was the predictor; (3) you didn't run enough clean reps yet; (4) the dog wasn't paying attention to your earlier sessions and the conditioning didn't take. Re-run Day 11 tomorrow with strict attention to the click → pause → reach → pay order. Add an extra session if you have the time.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did the dog pass the "break their neck" test? **Solid pass:** advance to Day 13 tomorrow. **Conditional pass (slow approach, mild interest):** repeat today's drill tomorrow and re-test. **Failed:** repeat Day 11 with attention to clean mechanics. Don't advance until the marker is loaded.

TOMORROW

We start using the marker for engagement work. The dog learns that *you* are the source of everything, not the food in your hand.

Day 13 — Engagement: I Am the Button You Push

Now that the marker is loaded, we use it to install the single most important state in dog training — engagement. This is the master skill that everything we'll ever do downstream depends on.

► **Before you start today.** Your marker is loaded. The "break their neck" test passed. The dog snaps to you on a cold click. If that's not yet true, go back to Day 12 — don't run today.

THE STORY

There's a question I ask every single dog at my facility, on the very first day, before we do anything else: *can this dog give me their attention?*

Not for a couple of seconds. Not when they're already eating from my hand. **Sustained attention, voluntarily, while the world is doing other things.**

The honest answer for most dogs that arrive on day one is no. They can't. They're locked onto the environment — the sounds, the smells, the new surroundings, the random visual stuff — and they're treating me as one input among many. I'm just a guy in the room. Possibly an interesting guy if I have food, but my interestingness is conditional on what I'm holding, not on me as a person.

By the time those same dogs leave my facility four weeks later, the relationship has flipped. *I* am the most relevant thing in the dog's world. Not because I demand it, not because I'm physically dominating them, but because we've spent four weeks installing a single principle in the dog's brain:

Everything I want comes through this human.

Food. Movement. Freedom. Play. Access to the world. All of it. The dog learns to look at me, automatically, all the time, because looking at me is the path to everything else they care about.

That's engagement. And that single change in the dog's orientation to you is more important than every specific behavior we'll ever teach them. A dog with engagement is trainable in any new behavior. A dog without engagement isn't really trainable in anything at all — they're just being managed.

Today, we start installing engagement.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Two short sessions today, 10-15 minutes each. Same setup as marker conditioning — chair, leash under foot, bowl of food on the side table, clicker in one hand, food delivery from the other.

The drill:

1. **Sit still and wait.** No food in your hand yet. Just sit there.
2. The dog will eventually look at you. Could take a few seconds, could take 30. Doesn't matter. Wait for it.
3. **The instant the dog's eyes meet yours — click. Reach. Pay.**
4. After the dog finishes the food, look back to neutral, hands down.
5. The dog will look at you again. **Click. Reach. Pay.**

6. Repeat.

What you're doing is **rewarding the dog for looking at your face**. That's it. That's the whole drill. We're not asking for a sit, not asking for anything specific — just rewarding eye contact every time the dog offers it.

Within a few minutes, the dog will start staring at you continuously, like *more please*. That's good. That's exactly what we want.

Now we add the second piece — the toss-and-reset.

Once the dog is staring at you reliably, we don't want them stuck in static stare-mode. We want them to learn the cycle of *engage* → *get paid* → *release* → *re-engage*. The reward for engagement always comes directly from your hand. The toss is a separate event — a cued release — that comes *after* the payment, not as the payment.

Here's the sequence:

1. Dog gives eye contact.
2. **Click** → **reach** → **pay directly from your hand**.
3. Now grab another piece of food. Cue "**get it**" as you toss it a few feet away.
4. Dog goes to get the tossed piece. They've now broken their gaze. Good.
5. They eat it, then come back to you.
6. Wait for them to look at your face again.
7. **Click** → **reach** → **pay directly from your hand**. Cycle.

The order matters. The click-and-pay always comes directly from the hand because that's what teaches the dog *eye contact* = *food appears in the human's hand*. If you toss the food *as* the payment, you'd accidentally teach the opposite — *eye contact* = *food gets thrown away from the human* — and you'd undermine the engagement default we're building. The toss is its own thing: a cued release that breaks the dog out of engagement so they can voluntarily come back into it.

This cycle — *eye contact* → *click* → *pay* → "*get it*" toss → *re-engage* → *click* → *pay* — is the engine. The dog learns that they have to break engagement and then *choose* to come back to it. The choosing is the lesson. A dog who can voluntarily re-engage after being released to do their own thing is a dog who's truly engaged.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Almost every reactive, fearful, distractible, anxious, "won't listen" dog has the same root problem: their attention defaults to the environment, not the handler. They're more interested in what's happening *around* them than what's happening *with* them.

Engagement work fixes that at the foundation level. We're not trying to make the dog ignore the environment — that's impossible and undesirable. We're trying to install the default that *the human is the most relevant thing in the room*. When that default is in place, the dog naturally looks to the handler when something happens. When something happens that worries them, they look to the handler for guidance. When they want something, they look to the handler to ask. When they're not sure what to do, they look to the handler for direction.

A dog with that default never reacts to a passing dog the same way as a dog without it. A dog with that default never bolts after a squirrel the same way. A dog with that default never has to be repeatedly called because their attention was already on you. The whole training relationship operates from a different baseline.

The flip side is also true: every behavior problem that traces to "my dog ignores me" is, at root, a missing engagement default. You don't fix it by getting better at calling the dog. You fix it by installing the engagement first.

BRIAN-ISM

I am the button you have to push in order to get the thing that you want.

The dog who's learned that — really learned it, all the way down — has been transformed. They've stopped trying to get to the food directly, the squirrel directly, the door directly, the visitor directly. They've learned that the path to all of those things runs *through you*. You're the button. They have to push you.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog won't look at me at all. They keep looking at the door.

A: Two fixes. First — quieter room. Find the most boring spot in your house with the fewest distractions. Second — start with shorter waits. If the dog is going more than a few seconds without looking at you, click the moment any part of their attention turns toward you, even if it's not full eye contact yet. We can shape the eye contact specifically in later sessions; right now we're rewarding the orientation toward you.

Q: My dog is staring at the food in my hand, not at my face.

A: Hide the food. Have the bowl on the side table behind you, or in your pocket, or behind your back. Every rep, you reach back, take a piece, deliver it, hide the source again. The dog can't stare at what they can't see, and they'll naturally start looking at the only visible part of the equation — which is your face.

Q: What if my dog stares at me but won't break gaze even when I want them to do the toss-and-reset?

A: Some dogs lock in hard. Make the toss obvious — literally toss the kibble in an exaggerated arc so it lands clearly in the dog's view. They'll usually go for it. If they ignore the toss, just wait. Eventually they'll look away from you (even briefly), which gives you the chance to click them back to you. Don't reward the static stare — we want the cycle.

Q: My dog will look at my face, but only for like one second before they look away.

A: That's normal at this stage. We're rewarding the moment of looking. Duration of looking comes later. Right now, every glance gets a click. Build volume of glances. Sustained eye contact follows naturally as the dog realizes that looking at your face is the high-value behavior.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Two sessions in, are you seeing your dog voluntarily look at your face multiple times per minute when you're sitting still and silent? Are they completing the toss-and-reset cycle and re-engaging after eating the tossed piece? **Yes:** advance to Day 14 tomorrow. **No:** repeat today's drill until the dog is reliably offering eye contact and re-engaging after the toss.

TOMORROW

The hand-in-face engagement drill — the second-level work that proves the dog has actually internalized "I am the button you push."

Day 14 — The Hand-in-Face Engagement Drill

Today we install the lesson that going directly at what you want doesn't work. The path is through the human. This is the lesson that carries into every reactivity, impulse-control, and obedience situation we'll ever face.

► **Before you start today.** Yesterday's basic engagement work went well. Your dog is offering eye contact reliably and re-engaging after the toss-and-reset. If those aren't happening cleanly, go back to Day 13.

THE STORY

There's a misconception I have to clear up before we run today's drill, because it shows up in nearly every owner I work with: the idea that a dog who's interested in food should *go for the food* — that food drive looks like the dog launching themselves at whatever has food in it.

That's not what we're trying to build. That's actually the opposite of what we're trying to build.

What we want — and what today's drill installs — is a dog who has very high food drive *and also understands that the path to the food is through the human*. Not through the food directly. Through the handler. The dog who barrels at your hand to grab food is a dog who has food drive but no engagement. The dog who *sees food in your hand and looks at your face first* is a dog who has both. That second dog is the one we're building.

The way you teach this is the hand-in-face engagement drill. It's a tiny piece of mechanical work — closed fist, food inside, held in front of the dog's face — but the lesson it installs in the dog's brain is one of the most important lessons in their entire training career. The lesson is: **going directly at the thing you want doesn't work. Engaging with the human gets you the thing you want.**

The dog will figure this out for themselves, in 30 to 60 seconds, the first time you run it. They'll try the direct approach first — sniffing the fist, nosing it, maybe trying to bite it open. Holding the fist completely still removes the direct approach as an option. The dog runs out of moves. The only remaining variable in the room is *you*, the human attached to the fist. So they try you — they back off, they look at your face. The instant they do, the fist opens and they get paid.

That's the whole drill. And that small loop — direct doesn't work, look at the human does — is the underlying template for almost every impulse control behavior we'll ever teach. Counter-surfing prevention. Door manners. Reactivity rehab. Recall away from prey. All of it sits on top of this same single lesson, just extended into higher-stakes contexts.

We install it today, in low stakes, with food in a fist.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Two sessions today, 10-15 minutes each. Same setup as yesterday — chair, leash under foot, bowl on the side table, clicker in one hand, food delivery from the other.

The drill — the hand-in-face engagement work:

1. Take a piece of kibble. **Close your fist around it.**

2. Hold the closed fist 4 to 6 inches directly in front of the dog's nose, at the dog's natural head level.
3. Don't say anything. Don't move. Don't react to whatever the dog does.
4. The dog will engage with the fist directly — sniffing, licking, nudging, possibly pawing or trying to bite.
5. **Hold the fist completely still.** Do not pull the fist away. Do not push the dog away. Do not open the fist. Do not say "no." Just be a statue.
6. Eventually — usually within 15 to 60 seconds — the dog will give up the direct approach and **re-orient**. They'll back off, sit down, look at your face like *what's the puzzle here*.
7. **The instant the dog re-orient away from the fist and looks at your face — click, open the fist, and let them eat the whole piece.**
8. Reset. Take another piece. Close the fist. Repeat.

The first few reps may take 30-60 seconds each. By the fourth or fifth rep, the dog is going to start anticipating the puzzle. They'll see the closed fist and *immediately* sit and look at your face. When that happens, click and pay instantly — that's the dog telling you they've figured it out.

By the end of today's two sessions, you should be able to present the closed fist and have the dog immediately sit and offer eye contact, looking for the click.

WHY THIS MATTERS

This drill installs the most important lesson in your dog's training career, and it does it in 10 minutes a day for two days.

The lesson is: **going directly at the thing you want doesn't work. Engaging with the human gets you the thing you want.**

Once that lesson is installed, it generalizes everywhere. The dog who's learned the closed-fist drill doesn't lunge at food on the counter — they look at you. They don't bolt at the door — they look at you. They don't chase the cat — they look at you. They don't react to the passing dog — they look at you. Because the closed-fist drill is just one specific instance of a much bigger principle: *the path to what I want runs through the human*.

This is also the foundation for every impulse control behavior we'll teach. When we get to "leave it alternatives" and counter-surfing prevention and reactivity work in later programs, the closed-fist drill is the underlying template. The dog has already learned the principle in a low-stakes context (food in a fist). We're just extending the principle into higher-stakes contexts.

If you do this drill cleanly today and tomorrow, the dog who comes out of Week 2 is going to look fundamentally different from the dog who went into Week 2 — even though we haven't taught them a single command yet.

BRIAN-ISM

Once we teach our dogs that the key to getting whatever you want is engaging with your human — changes the game.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog is being aggressive trying to get the food out of my fist. They're biting at my hand.

A: Hold completely still. The instinct is to yank the hand away — don't. The dog is doing what dogs do when something is in the way of food: try harder. Your job is to outlast the trying. The instant the dog gives up and re-orient, they get the food. They will figure out within a few reps that biting doesn't open the fist. If you yank, you've taught them that biting moves the obstacle, which is the opposite lesson. Hold still.

Q: My dog won't engage with the fist at all. They just walk away.

A: Either food drive isn't quite where it needs to be (back to hand-feeding consolidation), or the room is too distracting (try a quieter spot). A dog with strong food drive will engage with a fist that smells like food. If yours won't, the food drive isn't fully restored.

Q: My dog re-orient after a few seconds, but doesn't actually look at my face — they just look down at the ground or to the side.

A: Click any re-orientation away from the fist for the first few reps, even if it's not full eye contact. Once the dog has caught on that re-orienting (as opposed to pushing into the fist) is what works, start holding out specifically for face contact. Build the standard up gradually.

Q: My dog re-oriented but then immediately went back at the fist. Now what?

A: Reward speed matters. The instant they re-orient — click and open the fist immediately. If you wait too long after the click to deliver the food, they'll go back at the fist before you can pay. Click → open → food, in one motion. You can pause between click and reach during marker conditioning. During this drill, reaction time matters more.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** By the end of today's two sessions, can you present the closed fist and have the dog immediately sit (or offer some clear re-orientation) and look at your face within 5 seconds? **Yes:** advance to Day 15 tomorrow. **Mostly, but inconsistent:** run today's drill again tomorrow before advancing. **No, the dog is still nosing the fist most of the time:** more reps. Stay here until the lesson clicks.

TOMORROW

The first behavior. We start free-shaping the first base position — usually sit. The closed-fist drill was the warmup. Now the engine starts running.

Day 15 — Free-Shape Session #1 (The First Base Position)

Today we shape your dog's first command. We do it without saying the command word. We do it without showing the dog what to do. The dog teaches themselves the command. Your job is to mark it and pay it.

► **Before you start today.** Marker is loaded (Day 12 test passed). Engagement is solid (the closed-fist drill from Day 14 worked cleanly). If either of those is shaky, do not run today's content yet.

THE STORY

There's a line I picked up early in my career, from a police-K9 mentor, that I've come back to more times than I can count:

"If you want to be successful training the strongest dogs in the world, all you got to do is make them think it was their idea."

That single sentence is the entire principle behind what we're doing today, and behind a huge portion of everything we'll do from here on out. It's the difference between a dog who *complies* with what you ask and a dog who actually *owns* the behavior. The first dog does the thing because you told them to and they know they'll get a reward or a correction. The second dog does the thing because somewhere along the way they figured out, on their own, that the thing was a good idea — and now it's part of who they are. The second dog is significantly more reliable, especially in the moments that matter most: high distraction, high arousal, real-world chaos.

We are not going to teach your dog to sit today. Your dog already knows how to sit — they did it nine times in the kitchen this morning. What we're going to do is let your dog *discover* that sitting pays. And we're going to do it without telling them, because the moment we tell them, we steal the discovery from them — and the discovery is the whole point.

Behavior the dog discovers through self-exploration ingrains at an exponentially higher rate than behavior they were shown. That's not motivation talk; that's how the dog's brain actually works. The dog who figured something out is running a different circuit than the dog who got shown.

Today, we let the dog figure something out.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

You'll need: your dog, the chair, the leash, the bowl of kibble on the side table, and the clicker.

Set up the box. Sit in your chair in the middle of a small, quiet room. Put the leash on the dog. Step on the end of the leash so the dog has about six feet of slack. The dog can move around but can't leave you. This is the modified Skinner box you've been using all week — same setup, different purpose today.

Be a statue. Hands in your lap. Don't talk. Don't make eye contact yet. Don't lure. Don't point at your dog's butt. Don't say "sit." Don't even *think* the word "sit" hard enough that your face shows it. You are going to sit there and let the dog figure out that something is going on.

Wait. The dog will do things. They'll sniff your shoes. They'll paw at you. They'll wander to the end of the leash. They'll stare at you. They'll bark, maybe. None of that gets a click. You wait.

Eventually, the dog will sit. Maybe on purpose, maybe because they got bored and their butt found the floor. **It does not matter which.** The instant their butt touches the ground:

1. **Click.**
2. *One one-thousand.*
3. **Reach** into the bowl, take a piece of kibble.
4. **Pay** the dog directly from your hand — they're sitting right next to you, deliver the food right to their mouth.
5. **Take a second piece of kibble. Cue "get it" and toss it a few feet away.** The dog gets up to eat it. Good — that's the cued release that breaks the position so we can do another rep.
6. Dog eats the tossed piece, comes back to you. Hands back in your lap. Be a statue again.
7. **Wait** for the next sit. Click, pay directly, "get it" toss. Repeat.

That's the whole drill. Click — pause — reach — pay direct — *then* the "get it" toss as the reset. In strict order. The pay always comes from your hand, the toss is always cued. We're using the same engagement loop you installed on Day 13, just now layered onto a specific behavior (sit) instead of pure eye contact. The cue you're loading — "get it" — is going to do real work for the rest of your dog's training career: it's the directional release that tells the dog *the rep is done, you're free to chase the food*. Every time you cue it during shaping, you're conditioning the cue further.

Run this for 10 to 15 minutes. Stop before the dog gets tired or before *you* get sloppy, whichever comes first. You're aiming for somewhere between 10 and 25 reps in the first session. If you get 8, that's fine — quality beats volume on Day 15.

WHAT IF THE DOG OFFERS SOMETHING OTHER THAN SIT?

This is the part where I need to give you a little flexibility.

I told you this is "free-shape sit." But your dog doesn't know that. They're going to offer whatever behavior they offer first. For most dogs, this is sit (it's a comfortable resting position they fall into naturally). For some dogs, it's down (some dogs collapse to a down faster than they sit). For a few dogs, it'll be something weird — paw-lift, head-tilt, spin.

The rule for today: pay the first thing that's a real position, not a transient behavior.

If your dog offers a down before they offer a sit — pay the down. We were going to teach down on Day 17 anyway. Your dog has just decided to do the curriculum out of order. That's fine. Let them lead.

If your dog offers a paw-lift or a spin or some other non-position thing — don't pay it. Wait for sit, down, or place-behavior to emerge. We're after the foundational positions, not party tricks.

If 15 minutes passes and the dog hasn't offered any position at all — they've been pacing or trying to leave or sitting only when leaning into you (which we don't pay because it's contact-driven, not voluntary) — end the session, put the bowl up, and try again at the next session time. Most dogs sit within 5 minutes of the first session. A few take longer.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Most people can't do this. I'm going to be honest with you. Most people sit down to free-shape their dog, last about 90 seconds, and then start "helping." They lean forward. They wiggle a treat. They say "sit, sit, sit." They tap the dog's hindquarters. And in the process, they hand the dog the answer instead of letting the dog earn it.

Here's the problem with that. A dog who has been *shown* the answer to sit looks completely different on the other end of training than a dog who *figured it out themselves*. The figured-it-out dog has more drive, more confidence, more flexibility. They're a problem-solver. They walk into new situations and ask themselves *what works here?* — instead of waiting around for a human to physically arrange them.

There's also a chemistry argument. Self-discovery dumps dopamine. When the dog connects A to B on their own, the reward chemistry is exponentially higher than when we drag them through the connection. That's not metaphor. That's the brain.

And the trap is this: free shaping looks like nothing is happening. The first few minutes feel like a waste. Your dog is wandering around, you're sitting on your hands, nothing seems to be moving. You will be tempted to step in. **Don't.** In free shaping, you have to have more patience than the dog. As long as you help her, it will never be her idea.

BRIAN-ISM

Make them think it was their idea.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: How long do I wait if my dog won't sit?

A: About 10 minutes per session, two sessions today. If 10 minutes goes by and you've gotten zero sits, end the session — put the food up, no more food until the next scheduled session time. The dog needs to come into the next session a little hungrier and a little more motivated to figure it out.

Q: Should I say 'good boy' when I click?

A: No. The click is the marker. Stacking your voice on top of it muddies it. Save your voice for next week when we add the verbal cue. Right now, the click and the food are doing all the talking.

Q: My dog never sits during the session. They lay down instead. Now what?

A: Lay down works. Pay it. The dog naturally offered down before sit — fine. We were always going to teach both this week. Run today's session as the down session instead, and we'll catch sit on Day 17. The dog leads on which behavior comes first.

Q: My dog tried to leave halfway through and got stopped by the leash. Should I say something?

A: No. Be a statue. The leash holds them in the box. They'll come back to you. Engagement work from Day 13-14 should have made you the most interesting thing in the room — let that work do its job.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did the dog offer a sit (or other base position) during today's sessions and get paid for it multiple times? **Yes:** advance to Day 16 tomorrow. **No, the dog wandered the whole session without offering anything:** check that food drive is at the right level (probably under-hungry) and try again tomorrow with a slightly cut ration. If three sessions go by with no offered behavior, DM me in the Real Dog Rehab community — there's likely a specific issue we need to troubleshoot.

TOMORROW

We continue the free-shape work on the same position. Volume of clean reps is what locks the behavior in.

Day 16 — Free-Shape, Second Session of the Same Position

Today we run more reps of yesterday's behavior. Same drill, same setup, more volume. Boring repetition is what builds reliable obedience.

- ▶ **Before you start today.** Yesterday's session produced sits (or whatever the first offered position was) and the dog earned multiple clicks for it. If yesterday produced no behaviors at all, repeat Day 15 instead of running today.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Two sessions today, same as yesterday. Same room. Same chair. Same leash. Same bowl. Same drill: silent statue, click the position the instant it happens, pay it.

The thing that should be different today: **the position should be offered faster and more often.**

Yesterday, the dog might have wandered for two or three minutes before offering the first sit. Today, the dog should be sitting within 30 seconds of the session starting. By the end of today's second session, the dog should be sitting *immediately* every time you toss them off the position with a piece of kibble — they finish eating the toss-piece, come back to you, and sit. Not because you cued it. Because they've figured out that sit is what gets paid.

If that's happening — beautiful. The free-shape is taking. We're on schedule.

If the dog is still occasionally drifting into other behaviors (pacing, looking at you blankly, trying to leave) — they need more reps. Run another full session and re-evaluate.

TWO SMALL ADDITIONS TODAY

One — start running the position-then-toss-then-position cycle deliberately.

Yesterday you started the position → pay → "get it" toss → reset cycle. Today, deliberately tighten it up and run more reps:

1. Dog sits → click → **pay directly from your hand**
2. Take a second piece. **Cue "get it" and toss it away from you.**
3. Dog gets up, eats the tossed kibble.
4. Dog comes back to you.
5. Dog sits → click → pay direct → "get it" toss.
6. Repeat.

The cycle is: *sit → click → pay direct → "get it" toss → break → return → sit*. Run 10-15 cycles per session. Each cycle is one rep that builds the dog's understanding that sit-near-the-handler is the behavior that produces both the direct payment and the released toss.

Keep the "get it" cue clean and consistent. Same word every time. Said as you toss, not before, not after. By the end of this week you'll have used it hundreds of times — the cue will be loaded for life, and you'll be using it in every distraction-proofing drill we run for the rest of training.

Two — start watching for "suspicious behavior."

A "suspicious behavior" is when the dog stacks something else onto the target behavior — like sitting *while* pawing the air, or sitting *and* barking, or sitting *while* nosing your knee. The risk is that the dog interprets the click as paying the *combined* behavior, not just the sit. They'll start offering the combined version every time, because that's what got paid.

The fix: **only click pure sits**. No pawing, no barking, no nosing — just butt on the floor, body still. If the dog adds a behavior on top of the sit, don't click. Wait for the next sit (a clean one) and click that.

Don't try to suppress the suspicious behavior. Don't say "no." Just don't pay it. The dog will drop the suspicious add-on naturally as they learn that only the clean version produces the click.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Free shaping looks easy from the outside. Sit and wait, click the sit, hand over food. What's hard is the consistency — *every* clean sit gets paid, *no* dirty sit gets paid, the click happens exactly at the moment the butt hits the floor (not a half-second before, not a half-second after).

The reason consistency matters at this stage is that the dog is forming the *concept* of what the behavior is, and the concept is built from your timing. Click late and you're paying the dog for already being seated, not for the act of sitting — which produces a dog who'll sit but won't enter the position quickly. Click early and you're paying the dog for *intention to sit*, not the actual sit — which produces a dog who'll start to sit and then bail because the click already came.

Click *the moment the butt makes contact with the floor*. That's the moment that defines the behavior in the dog's brain. Get that timing right across enough reps and the behavior is rock-solid.

BRIAN-ISM

In the beginning, when you're shaping behavior, it doesn't matter whether the dog is doing it on purpose or by accident. It just matters that you are marking it and paying it.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog has started sitting and then immediately popping back up like they're waiting for the next click. Is that bad?

A: That's perfect actually. They've figured out the pattern: sit, get paid, reset, sit again. The pop-up between reps is the dog actively returning to neutral so they can try the rep again. Don't pay the pop-up; pay the sit. They're on rails.

Q: My dog sat without me having to wait at all this morning. I clicked and paid. Then they sat again immediately. Are we ready to move on?

A: Almost. We want to be sure the behavior is locked in across multiple sessions and slightly varied conditions. Run another full day of this (Day 16) before advancing to the second behavior on Day 17. Volume now saves you headaches in Week 3.

Q: *My dog is barking at me between reps. They sit, get paid, then bark, and I'm waiting for them to stop barking and they won't.*

A: *The bark is a frustration behavior — they're saying "do the thing again." Don't pay the bark. Wait it out. Often the simplest fix is to just wait longer than the dog can sustain barking. They'll eventually quiet down and offer the sit again. Click that. Within a few reps the bark will stop happening because it doesn't produce the click.*

Q: *How many reps total per behavior should I aim for before moving on?*

A: *Roughly 70-100 quality reps with the cue, spread across multiple sessions. We'll add the cue starting Day 21, so we're not at "with the cue" yet — but you can think of today and tomorrow as the foundational rep work. Don't count reps obsessively; just notice that across sessions the behavior is getting cleaner and faster. When the dog is offering the position immediately every time and holding it briefly before the click, you're at the level we want.*

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Is the dog offering the target position consistently and quickly across both of today's sessions? Are you clicking only clean reps and ignoring suspicious add-ons? **Yes:** advance to Day 17 tomorrow. **No:** repeat today's drill until the position is reliably offered.

TOMORROW

The second base position. If the dog offered sit yesterday, today we shape down. If they offered down yesterday, today we shape sit.

Day 17 — Free-Shape the Second Position

Today the dog learns that there's more than one right answer. This is where the puzzle deepens, and where you'll see the dog's brain visibly working in real time.

► **Before you start today.** Yesterday's free-shape sessions produced consistent, clean reps of the first position (sit or down — whichever your dog offered first). The dog returns to that position immediately after the toss reset. If they're not yet there, repeat Day 16.

THE STORY

There's a moment in every dog's training where you can see them think for the first time. Not respond, not perform — *think*.

It happens on day two of free-shaping, with the second behavior. Here's the moment:

The dog comes into the session. Sits down, the way they did yesterday. Looks at you expectantly. Waits for the click.

You don't click.

The dog sits a beat longer. You can see the *what?* register on their face. They glance away, glance back, sit a little harder, like maybe you didn't notice. You don't click.

Now the dog is genuinely working. *That worked yesterday. Why isn't it working today?* They might bark. They might paw at you. They might try a paw-lift, a head-tilt, a stretch. None of that gets a click.

And then, somewhere between 30 seconds and three minutes later, the dog runs out of options for what worked yesterday and tries something new. Usually they collapse to a down — because once they've exhausted standing options, lying down is the next-easiest body position. The instant they hit the down — *click*. They get the food. They look at you with an expression that I can only describe as *holy crap, I just figured out a new game*.

That moment is when your dog stops being a creature that responds to inputs and starts being a creature that solves problems. Once they've had that experience, they will look for new things to try whenever they're not getting paid for the old thing. You've just installed the most important meta-skill in dog training: *the willingness to try*.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Same setup. Chair, leash under foot, bowl on the side table, silent statue, clicker ready.

The drill:

1. Dog comes into the session. They will sit immediately, because that's what worked yesterday.
2. **Don't click.** Hold completely still. Don't respond.
3. Dog will hold the sit for a few seconds, then start trying other things. They might paw, bark, shift, stand up.
4. **Don't click any of that either.** Keep waiting.
5. Eventually — could be 30 seconds, could be 5 minutes — the dog will offer the second position.

For most dogs whose first position was sit, the second is down. For dogs whose first was down, the second is usually sit.

6. **The instant the dog hits the new position — click. Pay directly from your hand.**
7. **Take a second piece. Cue "get it" and toss it a few feet away.** Dog gets up, eats it, comes back.
8. Dog will probably sit again, because that just worked five minutes ago. **Don't click.** Wait.
9. Dog will eventually offer the new position again — usually faster this time because they've started to figure out that the new thing is what's earning the click today.
10. **Click. Pay direct. "Get it" toss.** Repeat.

The session looks slow at first and gets fast. By the end of today's second session, the dog should be offering the new position within a few seconds of returning from the "get it" toss. Some dogs get there in one session. Some take two. Both are fine.

One critical rule today: do not pay any sit during this session. Not one. The dog has to learn that today's behavior is different from yesterday's. If you pay even one sit out of pity or by accident, you've muddled the picture and the dog will keep trying sit instead of down.

We will pay sit again later — once both positions are independently locked, we mix them. Today is *only* the new position.

WHY THIS MATTERS

What the dog is experiencing today is what trainers call **extinction-induced variability** — a fancy phrase for "when the previously-rewarded behavior stops being rewarded, the dog tries new behaviors looking for the next reward." This is exactly the mechanism that makes free shaping work, and it's a mechanism most dogs never get to experience because most pet owners would step in and "help" within 30 seconds of the dog looking confused.

Don't help. The confusion is the work.

The reason today is so important is that it teaches the dog *the world has more than one right answer*. A dog who only knows one trick — sit, in this case — has a very narrow strategy for getting what they want. A dog who knows two tricks and has had the experience of *figuring out* the second one is a dog who, going forward, will look for new tricks whenever the old one stops working. They've built the meta-strategy of *try things until something works*.

That meta-strategy is what makes complex behaviors trainable. Place is a chained behavior — go to the cot, get on it, lie down — and we can only chain those steps together with a dog who'll keep trying things. Heel is a sustained behavior — stay in position while moving — that requires the dog to maintain effort even when the immediate paycheck isn't obvious. Recall is a high-stakes behavior that requires the dog to *choose* you over a competing motivator. None of these are teachable to a dog who gives up the moment a behavior stops getting paid.

Today is the day we install "willing to try."

BRIAN-ISM

That little bit of frustration is not a bad thing. That means her brain's working, trying to figure out what to do.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog has been sitting for five minutes and hasn't tried anything else. Should I help?

A: No. Wait. Some dogs hit on the new behavior fast. Some take a while. The dog who takes a while is going to learn the lesson more deeply because they had to work harder for it. As long as the dog hasn't given up entirely (lying down or walking away from you completely), keep waiting. If 10 minutes pass with zero variation, end the session, food up, try again next session.

Q: My dog stood up and stayed standing instead of laying down. Do I click standing?

A: No. Standing is just a transition state, not a behavior we're shaping. We want sit, down, or place. If the dog is just standing and looking at you, they're still working — give them time to keep trying. They'll either sit (don't pay) or eventually drop into a down (pay).

Q: My dog gave up and walked to the end of the leash. They're sniffing the floor and ignoring me.

A: They've disengaged. End the session, put the food up, no more food until the next session. They need to come into the next session a little hungrier. Do not chase them or try to re-engage them — that teaches them that disengaging produces handler effort. Just end. Reset.

Q: My dog offered a perfect down, I clicked, and now they're back to sitting again. Same problem.

A: Normal. Pay the down whenever it's offered. Ignore the sit. Within 5-10 reps of paying down (and not paying sit), the dog will start defaulting to down. The pattern reverses faster than you'd think.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did your dog offer the second position multiple times during today's sessions? Are they starting to favor the new position over the old one? **Yes:** advance to Day 18 tomorrow. **No:** repeat today's drill until the second position is being offered.

TOMORROW

The third base position — place. The hardest of the three to free-shape because it's a chained behavior, not a single body movement. Pull the place bed out tonight if you haven't already.

Day 18 — Free-Shape Place

Today we shape the most useful single behavior in your dog's life. Place is the off-switch. Place is the safe spot. Place is what makes everything from front-door management to "calm during dinner" possible. Today we install it.

- **Before you start today.** Two positions are now solid through free-shaping (sit and down, in whichever order your dog offered them). You have a place bed — a raised cot, like the equipment list specified. If you don't have one yet, today is a wait day until you do.

THE STORY

I tell every owner who comes through my facility the same thing on the day they pick up their dog: *the most important single piece of equipment in your house is a place bed, and the most important single command your dog has is "place."*

People nod politely on go-home day and they don't really get it until they've been home for a couple of weeks and the command has started doing real work in their actual life. Then they get it.

Here's what makes place so disproportionately valuable. Sit and down are positions — the dog can do them anywhere, which sounds like an advantage but is actually the limitation. Because they can be done anywhere, there's no specific *spot* the dog associates with the behavior. There's no landmark. There's no anchor. If the dog breaks a sit and wanders off, you have nothing concrete to direct them back to except your own body.

Place is different. Place is a behavior plus a location, fused into one command. The dog learns that *this specific cot* means *stay here until I tell you otherwise*. The cot can travel — to the office during work, to the kitchen during meals, to the entryway when someone knocks, to your in-laws' house at Thanksgiving — and wherever the cot goes, the behavior is anchored to it. The dog has a clear job: be on this thing. Dogs do well with clear jobs.

It's also a workhorse for fear and anxiety work later. A dog who knows place has a designated *safe spot* the handler can send them to when the world gets loud. That single capability solves a long list of household-chaos problems all at once: doorbell, dinner time, visitors, deliveries, kids running through the house. All of those become *go to your place and hold*, instead of separate management problems.

There's a reason we use a raised cot specifically and not a soft pillow bed: clean edges. The dog can feel exactly where the bed begins and ends. A pillow with no defined edge makes "stay on the bed" much harder to teach, because the boundary is fuzzy and dogs cannot reason about fuzzy boundaries. The raised cot is mechanically binary — on or off, no in-between — and that binary is what makes the command teachable in the first place.

One more thing while we're here. Once the dog has place, *only the cot is place*. Don't generalize the command to other objects ("just lie down on the rug") because if the dog learns various objects can be place, they'll start *place-hopping* on their own — you'll put them on the cot, walk out of the room, come back to find them on the coffee table. Place is *that cot*, that exact cot, the one we're starting today. It can travel with you, but it's the same physical object every time.

Today, we install the behavior.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

You'll need: the place bed (the raised cot), and everything else you've been using — chair, leash, bowl, clicker.

Setup:

- Put the place bed in the room where you've been training, about 4-6 feet from your chair
- Sit in your chair as usual. Leash on the dog, end under your foot.
- The dog should be in a position where they *can* easily get on the place bed if they choose to (within the slack of the leash)

The drill — successive approximation:

Place is not a single behavior. It's a chain: notice the bed → look at the bed → step toward the bed → step onto the bed → lie down on the bed. We can't free-shape the whole chain at once — the dog will never accidentally go through all five steps in one session. Instead, we shape each piece, then chain them.

The principle is **pay what's closer to the goal than what they did last time**. Each click slightly raises the bar.

Here's how it runs:

1. **Be a statue.** Wait. The dog is going to start running through their known behaviors — sit, down, looking at you, maybe pawing — because those have worked recently.
2. **Don't click any of those.** They eventually get bored of trying the same things and start offering new behaviors — looking around, glancing at things in the environment.
3. **The instant the dog's head turns even slightly toward the place bed — click. Pay directly from your hand.** Then take a second piece, **cue "get it" and toss it in the opposite direction from the bed** — this resets the dog away from the bed so we can re-shape the look toward it.
4. The dog comes back. They'll try the previous behaviors. **Don't click.** Wait again.
5. Eventually they'll glance at the bed again. **Click. Pay direct. "Get it" toss away from the bed.**
6. Within several reps, the dog will start *deliberately* looking at the bed because they've figured out that looking at the bed is what works.
7. Now we raise the bar. **Don't click for just a glance.** Wait for a more committed look — staring at the bed, leaning toward it, taking a step toward it.
8. The first step toward the bed — click. Pay direct. **"Get it" toss away from the bed.**
9. Build up: glance → look → step → multiple steps → standing on the bed → sitting on the bed → lying down on the bed. Each step gets paid (direct from hand), each rep gets reset with a cued "get it" toss, until the next step is happening reliably, then we hold out for the next step.

This is **successive approximation**. Each click pays a behavior that's slightly closer to the final target than the last paid behavior was. Don't try to skip steps. The full chain — *notice* → *look* → *step* → *climb on* → *lie down* — usually takes a couple of sessions to build.

By the end of today's two sessions, the dog should be at *getting on the place bed* — maybe not lying down on it yet, but at least standing on it confidently.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Place is the most generally useful command in the program because it's a **stationary holding behavior in a clearly-defined location**. Once the dog understands that the place bed means "stay here until I tell you otherwise," you can transport the place bed to anywhere in the world and have a way to anchor the dog in that location.

You can put the place bed in your office during work calls. In the kitchen during cooking. Next to the dinner table during meals. In the entryway when guests arrive. In the back of the SUV when you're traveling. Everywhere your dog needs to be calm and stationary, the place bed is the answer.

The other thing place does that no other position does: it gives the dog a physical landmark to *return to*. If your dog breaks position, you can communicate "back to your spot" by directing them to the bed. There's no equivalent for sit or down — sit and down can happen anywhere, which means there's no specific location for the dog to return to. Place is geographic. The bed is the answer.

This is also why we use a *raised cot*, not a soft pillow bed. The raised cot has clean edges. The dog can feel exactly where the bed begins and ends. A pillow bed with no defined edge makes "stay on the bed" much harder to teach because the boundary is fuzzy. The cot is mechanically clean: on the cot, off the cot. Binary.

BRIAN-ISM

The fastest and clearest way for dogs to learn is in the land of always and never.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog jumped on the bed in the first 30 seconds. Do I click that?

A: Yes! Pay it directly from your hand. Then "get it" toss the next piece away from the bed to reset, see if they do it again. Some dogs catch on instantly. Don't slow them down by holding out for "earned" reps if they're already there.

Q: My dog won't even look at the place bed. They're staring at me waiting for the next click.

A: That's the engagement work paying back almost too well — they're so locked on you that they're not surveying the environment. Try this: take a piece of food and toss it onto the place bed (no cue, no click — this one is a free placement, not a "get it" toss). The dog will go eat it. They've now physically been on the bed. Next rep, go back to the regular drill: just wait — most dogs will glance at the place bed because the food was just there. Click that glance, pay direct, "get it" toss away.

Q: My dog got on the bed but immediately got off after the click. How do I get them to stay on it?

A: Today we're not asking them to stay yet. The behavior we're shaping today is "get on the bed." Staying-on-the-bed comes Day 19 when we add duration. Pay the get-on, let them get off (that breaks position so we can rep again), wait for the next get-on, pay. We'll layer duration tomorrow.

Q: My place bed is too small / too big / too soft for what you described.

A: Get the right one if you can. A raised cot, fabric platform stretched over a metal frame, slightly larger than the dog when they're stretched out. \$30-60 on Amazon. The bed is going to be in your house for the next decade — the small upfront investment is worth it. If you have to use what you have for a few days while the right one ships, do that, but plan to swap.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Is the dog at least *getting onto the place bed* by the end of today's second session? **Yes:** advance to Day 19 tomorrow. **No, the dog is still in the early stages of the chain (just looking at it, just stepping toward it):** repeat today's drill — they're on the right track, they just need more reps to chain the full behavior.

TOMORROW

We add duration to place. The dog learns that getting on the bed isn't enough — they have to *stay* on it.

Day 19 — Cleaning Up: All Three Positions, All Reliably Offered

Today is the consolidation day. We work all three behaviors, mixed, no cues yet, just verify that each one is rock-solid before we add language to them tomorrow.

- ▶ **Before you start today.** Sit, down, and place all happen reliably in their individual sessions. Place includes at least getting onto the bed (we'll add duration today). If any of the three is still shaky, don't run today — go back and consolidate the weak one.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Two sessions today, slightly different format than the last few days.

Session one — duration on place.

Setup: place bed in the room, dog on the leash near the bed.

Wait for the dog to get on the place bed (they should now go to it deliberately). The first rep, click and pay directly the moment they get on, like usual. Then "get it" toss to reset.

Second rep — **wait an extra second before clicking.** The dog is on the bed. Don't click immediately. Just hold for one full second. Then click. Pay direct. **"Get it"** toss to reset.

Third rep — wait two seconds. Click. Pay direct. "Get it" toss.

Fourth rep — wait three seconds.

You're building duration on the place command. Each rep, the dog has to be *on the bed* a little longer before the click happens. Duration grows from 0 seconds to about 30 seconds across this session.

If at any point the dog gets on the bed and then immediately gets off before the click, you've waited too long. The dog isn't yet at that duration. Drop back a few seconds, build more reps at the easier duration, then try increasing again.

By the end of session one, you should be able to have the dog get on the bed and hold for 15-30 seconds before the click. They might be sitting on the bed, or standing on it, or even lying down on it — at this stage, body position on the bed doesn't matter. *Being on the bed* is the behavior.

Session two — mixed sit and down.

Setup: standard. No place bed for this session — back to the chair-and-leash setup from earlier in the week.

Run the basic free-shape, but now both sit and down are payable. The dog will offer sit, get clicked and paid. Then offer down, get clicked and paid. Then sit again. Then down again.

What you should see: the dog cycling between the two behaviors, getting paid for each, learning that *both* are right answers. By the end of session two, the dog should comfortably alternate between sit and down across reps without confusion.

If the dog gets stuck on one behavior and won't offer the other, **deliberately stop paying the stuck behavior for several reps.** They'll get frustrated and offer the other one. Pay it. Then resume paying

both.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Today's work does two things.

One — duration on place is the gateway to actually using place in real life. A place command that the dog gets on and off of within two seconds isn't useful. We need place to be a sustainable position — something the dog can hold while you make dinner, while you take a phone call, while you have guests over. Duration starts now, and we'll keep extending it through Week 3.

Two — mixing sit and down without confusion proves the dog has independent concepts of each behavior. A dog who only ever sees one behavior at a time can look fluent in each one separately, but the test is whether they can switch between them based on what's getting paid. If they get stuck on sit when down is what we want, they didn't really learn down — they learned "sit got paid yesterday." Mixing is what proves the concepts are independent.

You're also doing one more thing today that's invisible but important: **you're getting the dog used to longer training sessions and mixed behaviors.** Up until now, sessions have been fairly singular — one behavior, fairly mechanical. Today's sessions are more varied and require the dog to *choose* what to offer. That choosing is what builds the ability to follow cues later — when we tell the dog "sit," they need to choose sit out of their available behaviors, not just default to whatever they tried last.

BRIAN-ISM

Engagement is king.

The engagement work, the marker work, the free-shaping work, the duration work — all of it is engagement, in different costumes. The dog who's engaged with you and offers behaviors voluntarily and chooses correctly between options is a trained dog. We're approaching that.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog gets on the place bed and immediately lies down. Should I be paying the lie-down or the get-on?

A: Pay whichever they offer first, then build duration on whatever happens. If your dog is naturally lying down on place, that's actually great — lying down on place is the long-term target behavior. Build duration of the lying down. By the end of this week we want place = "lie down on the bed and stay there until released."

Q: My dog can hold place for like 5 seconds but then breaks position to come back to me for the click. They don't understand they need to stay there.

A: Two fixes. One — make sure you're paying on the bed, not luring them off it. Bring the food to them on the bed instead of having them come to you. Two — work with shorter durations for now. If 5 seconds is the wall, build dozens of reps at 4 seconds before pushing to 5 again. Duration extends through volume, not through pushing past the limit.

Q: *My dog mixes sit and down fine but down is much sloppier — like a half-down with their butt half-up.*

A: *Hold out for cleaner downs. Don't click the half-down. Wait for the dog to fully commit (chest and elbows on the floor, hips dropped). They'll get frustrated trying half-downs that don't pay, and eventually drop fully. Click that. The standard tightens through your patience.*

Q: *How long should each session be today?*

A: *About 15 minutes each. Today's sessions are slightly longer because we're doing more varied work and building duration. Watch the dog's energy — when they start losing focus or getting sloppy, end the session, even if you haven't worked through everything you planned. Quality over volume.*

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Can the dog hold place for 15-30 seconds before the click? Are they switching between sit and down comfortably in mixed sessions? **Yes to both:** advance to Day 20 tomorrow. **No to either:** repeat today's drill until both are solid.

TOMORROW

The Week 2 checkpoint. We verify that everything we've built this week is actually load-bearing before we move into Week 3, where we add cues, pressure, and indoor distraction proofing.

Day 20 — Week 2 Checkpoint: Are the Three Positions Locked In?

This is the gate before Week 3. Five questions. Same rules as Day 10. Pass to advance.

- **Before you start today.** Days 11-19 done. The marker is loaded. Engagement is solid. The three positions can each be free-shaped reliably. If any of those is still shaky, you're not at Day 20 yet — go back and finish the consolidation work.

THE GATE

Five questions. Honest answers.

1. Does your dog "break their neck" toward you on a cold click — full attention, immediate orientation, expectation of food?

If the marker has decayed at all from Week 2's start, today is the day to notice it. We can't add cues to a marker that's not loaded. If the answer is anything less than "full snap to attention," go back to marker conditioning for a couple of days before advancing.

2. Does your dog offer eye contact spontaneously when you're sitting still and silent — and do they re-engage after the toss-and-reset cycle?

This is the engagement default. Without it, every behavior we shape from here will be conditional on the dog being interested in you in the moment, rather than the dog defaulting to engagement as their natural state.

3. Does your dog reliably offer sit and down in free-shape sessions, mixed, without getting stuck on one?

If the dog can only offer one of the two, or if they get stuck on whichever one was paid most recently, the concepts aren't independent yet. More mixed-session work needed.

4. Does your dog get on the place bed deliberately when presented with the bed, and hold position for at least 15-30 seconds before the click?

Place is the most complicated of the three positions, and the slowest to install. If place is still wobbly — dog gets on but immediately gets off, or only gets on with a food toss as a lure — stay here.

5. Are you paying out the entire daily ration through training sessions across the day, with no extra food coming from any other source?

The existential food model is the foundation that holds the rest of the program together. If you've slipped back into bowl-feeding "to make sure they're getting enough," or if anyone is treating the dog on the side, the foundation is degrading and the pieces will start coming apart in Week 3.

WHAT IT MEANS IF YOU PASSED

You've now built — across two weeks of consistent daily work — the core foundation of dog training. You have:

- A dog with restored food drive
- A loaded marker
- An engagement default
- Three foundational behaviors offered voluntarily
- Duration on place
- A working training relationship where you're the source of everything the dog wants

That's not nothing. That's actually most of the work. Week 3 layers language and pressure on top of this foundation — cues for the behaviors, leash pressure as directional language, and indoor distraction-proofing — but the foundation itself is now in place.

Welcome to Week 3.

WHAT IT MEANS IF YOU DIDN'T PASS

Stay here. Identify which of the five questions is the weak link. Address that specifically before advancing. Common patterns and fixes:

- **Marker decay (#1):** repeat 2-3 sessions of pure marker conditioning (Day 11 drill) without any other behavior work
- **Engagement weakness (#2):** more sessions of the basic engagement drill (Day 13) and the closed-fist drill (Day 14)
- **Sit/down confusion (#3):** more mixed-position sessions, deliberately stop paying whichever behavior has become the default
- **Place weakness (#4):** more place-specific sessions, possibly back up to Day 18 to rebuild the chain
- **Slipping food protocol (#5):** the most serious. Reset to Day 6 and rebuild hand-feeding consolidation. Don't try to fix the downstream behaviors while the food drive is leaking.

There is no time pressure. Stay here as long as you need.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The whole program is a chain. Week 3 work depends on the marker being loaded — without a loaded marker, the cue can't be added cleanly because there's no reinforcement signal to attach the cue to. Week 3 work depends on engagement being solid — without engagement, leash pressure won't be received as language, it'll be received as restraint. Week 3 work depends on the three positions being known — without them, there's nothing for pressure to be married to. Each week's work is the soil that next week's work grows in. Skip ahead and the next week's work doesn't take root.

The good news is that Week 2's work is the kind that, once installed, stays installed. Engagement doesn't decay rapidly. The marker doesn't unload over a weekend. The positions don't disappear. As long as you continue to use them in subsequent training sessions — which Week 3 is going to do constantly — they get stronger, not weaker.

BRIAN-ISM

In the beginning, when you're shaping behavior, it doesn't matter whether the dog is doing it on purpose or by accident. It just matters that you are marking it and paying it.

You've crossed that threshold. Your dog is now offering behaviors deliberately, with intention. That's the inflection point. From here, we add words and pressure and the world.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Five yes answers? Move to Day 21. Any no? Identify the gap and address it before advancing.

TOMORROW (OR WHENEVER YOU PASS)

Cues. We start telling the dog what each of the three behaviors is called. The first verbal command of the program.

WEEK 3 · DAYS 21–30

Cues, Pressure, and Indoor Distraction-Proofing

We add the verbal cues, condition leash pressure as positive language, marry the two together, and prove the obedience holds through household distraction. By Day 30, you have a functional indoor obedience dog.

Day 21 — Add the Verbal Cue to the First Position

Today the first command word goes on the first behavior. We've waited two weeks to do this on purpose. There is a specific timing rule for this and if you get it backwards, the cue won't load.

- ▶ **Before you start today.** Day 20 checkpoint passed. Marker loaded, engagement solid, all three positions free-shaped reliably, place at 15-30 seconds duration. If any of those is shaky, do not run today.

THE STORY

I get this question from members on basically every call: *"When do I start saying the word?"*

People are dying to start saying the word. They've watched the dog free-shape sit a hundred times this week and they want to be the kind of person who says "sit" and has the dog sit. Saying "sit" feels like training. Sitting silently while the dog figures out the behavior feels like nothing.

I'll tell you what I tell them. The reason we've waited two weeks to put the word on the behavior is because **the word means nothing to the dog until the behavior is already there**. If you say "sit" before the dog reliably sits on their own, the word "sit" gets associated with the dog *trying things* — sometimes sitting, sometimes pawing, sometimes wandering off. The word becomes meaningless because the behavior under it isn't fixed yet.

When the behavior is already locked in — like yours is now — the word loads in just a few reps. I can usually get a verbal cue installed on a free-shaped behavior in one session. Sometimes two. The reason it's that fast is that the dog's brain is already doing the right thing automatically; we're just labeling it.

Today's the day we label it.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

One important rule that determines whether this works: **the cue goes on *before* the behavior, not at the same time, and definitely not after**.

Here's the order:

1. Wait until you can predict — within about a second — when the dog is going to offer the behavior. By now, after a week of free-shaping, you should be able to read the cues in their body language. They settle into the box, they look at you, they're about to drop into the behavior. You know it's coming.
2. **The instant you know the behavior is about to happen — say the cue.** "Sit." Once. Calm voice, not commanding, not loud. Just the word.
3. The dog drops into the behavior (because they were going to anyway).
4. **Click. Pay.**
5. Reset. Repeat.

That's the entire drill. Predict the behavior, say the word a half-second before it happens, mark it, pay it. Run this 20-30 times in your first session.

What this does to the dog's brain: the word "sit" starts to predict the behavior the dog was already going to do. After enough reps, the dog's brain starts treating the word as the cue *for* the behavior, not just a sound that happens around it. Within a session or two, you can say "sit" and the dog will drop into a sit even when they weren't about to offer it.

The mistake everybody makes: saying the word *during* or *after* the behavior. "The dog sat — sit! Good sit!" That doesn't load anything. The word didn't predict anything; it just arrived after the fact. The dog hears it as background noise, not as a cue.

The cue precedes the behavior. Always. By a half-second to one second.

THE ONE-SECOND RULE

This is from one of the foundational principles of marker training. You have about a 1.4-second window to make associations stick in a dog's brain. **The cue has to precede the behavior by less than 1.4 seconds for the dog to make the association.**

If you say "sit" and the dog sits two seconds later, the connection won't form. If you say "sit" and the dog sits half a second later, the connection forms beautifully.

This is why the timing has to be tight. Watch the dog. Predict the moment. Say the word. Wait for the behavior. Mark.

If your timing is off — if you're saying the word too early and the dog is sitting two seconds later — pause for a few reps and just watch the dog without speaking. Get your read on their timing back. Then resume saying the cue when you can predict the drop within a second.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The verbal cue is what unlocks the dog's obedience for use in real life. Up until today, every behavior has been *handler-presence-dependent* — the dog sits when they're in the box with you because that's the context they've learned. They don't sit yet on command in any other context.

The cue is what makes the behavior portable. Once "sit" means "do the sit behavior," you can use it anywhere — the kitchen, the back door, the front door, the car, the vet's office. The behavior travels with the cue.

But — and this is critical — *the cue is only ever as strong as the behavior under it*. If we put the word on the behavior before the behavior was solid, the word would be weak. Because the behavior is solid, the word inherits that solidity. The cue and the behavior become functionally equivalent in the dog's brain: hear the word, do the thing.

This is why I'm strict about waiting to add cues until after free-shaping is locked. Most owners want to teach commands by saying the command and then helping the dog into the position. That works in a way — the dog learns to comply when prompted. But it doesn't produce the reliability we're after, because the behavior under the word was never independently rehearsed. The dog only does the behavior when the word is present. They don't have an independent concept of the behavior.

With our approach, the dog has the behavior first (Week 2), then the word goes on it (Week 3). The dog can do the behavior with or without the word. The word is just a way to call up the behavior on demand. The behavior itself is independent.

BRIAN-ISM

The cue gets attached to the behavior. The behavior doesn't depend on the cue.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: *My dog sat the first time I said 'sit' today. Is that real, or did they coincidentally sit when I happened to say it?*

A: *Probably coincidence on the first rep. Real cue understanding requires multiple reps where the cue clearly preceded the behavior. Run another 20-30 reps with the cue. By the end of the session, if the dog drops into a sit when you say the word — even when they weren't about to sit on their own — the cue is loading.*

Q: *My dog hears 'sit' and stays still, looking confused.*

A: *Normal early in the session. Don't repeat the cue. Just wait — the dog will eventually offer the sit (because that's what they've been doing all week), and then you can mark and pay. Within a few reps where the word preceded the behavior, the connection will start forming. If you say the cue twice or three times in a row, you're teaching the dog that "sit, sit, sit" is the cue, not "sit." Say it once, wait.*

Q: *What tone of voice should I use?*

A: *Calm, conversational, normal speaking volume. Don't bark it like a drill sergeant. Don't sing it. Just say it the way you'd say "okay" to a friend. Consistent tone is what matters — the same word should sound the same every time you say it. Vary the tone and the word becomes a different cue depending on your mood.*

Q: *Do I keep saying the cue every rep, or do I phase it out?*

A: *Every rep. We're loading the cue today. Once it's loaded, we'll continue to use it for cued reps and we'll let the dog also offer the behavior uncued during free-shape sessions. Both contexts coexist — the cue means "do this," and the absence of the cue means "you can offer behaviors and they'll get paid." Both are useful.*

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** By the end of today's two sessions, can you say the word for the first behavior and have the dog drop into it most of the time, even when they weren't about to offer it on their own?
Yes: advance to Day 22 tomorrow. **No:** repeat today's drill — more reps, tighter timing on the cue.

TOMORROW

The cue goes on the second and third positions. Same drill, same timing rule. Three commands by end of day tomorrow.

Day 22 — Add the Verbal Cues to the Other Two Positions

Today we put the word on the second and third behaviors. Same drill, same timing. By end of day, your dog has three working verbal commands.

- ▶ **Before you start today.** Yesterday's first cue is loading — your dog drops into the first position when you say the word, most of the time, in the training setup. If they don't, repeat Day 21 — don't move on with a half-loaded first cue.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Two sessions today, same setup as the past few days. Each session targets one new cue.

Session one — cue on the second position.

Same drill as Day 21. Predict when the behavior is about to happen, say the cue word a half-second before, mark and pay. For most of you, this will be "down" if your first cue was "sit," or "sit" if your first cue was "down."

Run 20-30 reps. The cue should start to function — say the word, dog drops into the behavior — by the end of the session. If your dog is now starting to mix up the two cues (saying "down" sometimes produces a sit, or vice versa), don't worry. We'll clean that up in session two and tomorrow's reps.

Session two — cue on place.

Slightly different setup since place involves the cot. Place bed in position, dog on leash, you in your chair as usual.

Wait for the dog to start moving toward the place bed (they should now do this deliberately based on Days 18-19's work). **The instant you predict they're going to step toward or onto the place bed — say "place." Once. Calm.** Then mark and pay when they get on it.

Run 15-20 reps. By the end, "place" should function as a cue — say the word and the dog moves toward the bed.

ONE IMPORTANT RULE FOR TODAY

Don't mix the three cues yet. Today, run each cue in its own session. Sit-only in one session. Down-only in another. Place-only in a third (or worked into the same session as one of the others, with clear separation).

The reason: until each cue is independently solid, mixing them creates confusion. The dog hears "sit," does sit, gets paid. Hears "down," does down, gets paid. If you start switching between them too fast, the dog can lose the connection — they're scrambling to figure out what "sit" means versus what "down" means, and neither cue lands cleanly.

Tomorrow we'll start mixing them deliberately. Today, single-cue sessions only.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The reason today is two sessions instead of one is that adding a second cue to a dog who just learned their first cue creates the *sit-or-down* discrimination problem — the dog's brain has to start recognizing not just *that* a cue means a behavior, but *which* cue means *which* behavior.

If we tried to install both cues in the same session, the dog would fall into a pattern of just offering whichever behavior they happened to remember last, regardless of what cue you said. By running them in separate sessions today, we let each cue install cleanly with its own behavior. Tomorrow we'll cross-test the discrimination.

The same logic applies to place. Place is a different category of behavior (a chained, location-based behavior versus a single body movement), so it gets its own session today to install the cue without competing with the simpler positions.

By end of today, your dog has three loaded verbal cues. Tomorrow we make sure they actually mean what we think they mean by mixing them and seeing if the dog discriminates correctly.

BRIAN-ISM

The simplest form of communication for dogs requires the least amount of input from the human.

This is why we use just three commands instead of six or eight or twelve. Fewer cues = cleaner discrimination = more reliable obedience. We could keep adding commands forever, and most owners do, and most dogs end up with a vocabulary of 15 commands they kind of know. We have a vocabulary of three commands they really know. That's better.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog mixed up the cues — I said 'sit' and they did down. Is that bad?

A: Normal cross-talk early in cue installation. Don't pay the wrong behavior. Wait for them to offer the right one (which they will, eventually, after trying everything else), then mark and pay. Don't say the cue again — let them work it out. Mixed cues self-correct within a few reps as long as you don't pay the wrong answer.

Q: How do I know my dog actually understands the cue, vs. just guessing?

A: That's exactly what tomorrow's mixed-cue work tests. If you can say "sit" → dog sits → say "down" → dog downs → say "sit" → dog sits, in a random order, and the dog gets it right most of the time, the discrimination is real. If they keep defaulting to one behavior regardless of the cue, the cues aren't loaded yet.

Q: Place is harder than the other two. The dog isn't connecting the word to the bed.

A: Two fixes. One — make sure the place bed is highly visible and the dog is already oriented toward it before you say the cue. They have to be about to engage with the bed for the cue to load on the action. Two — pay generously for early reps. Place is a chained behavior and the cue takes a few extra reps to load compared to a single-action behavior like sit.

Q: *My dog gets the cue right in our chair-and-leash setup but I don't think they'd respond to it elsewhere in the house.*

A: *Correct — they wouldn't, yet. Cues are initially context-bound. We'll generalize across the house in Days 27-29 when we work on indoor distraction proofing. For now, get the cue solid in the training setup. Generalization comes after solidity.*

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** By the end of today, do you have three loaded verbal cues that produce the corresponding behaviors most of the time in the training setup? **Yes:** advance to Day 23 tomorrow. **No:** identify the weak cue and run another single-cue session on it before advancing.

TOMORROW

We start pressure conditioning. Important note: pressure conditioning is **separate from any obedience work** for the next few days. We're conditioning pressure as its own thing. Don't try to combine it with the cues yet.

Day 23 — Pressure Conditioning, Day One

Today the leash starts becoming language. We don't apply pressure to make the dog do anything yet. We condition pressure as a positive cue, completely separate from any obedience.

- **Before you start today.** Yesterday's three cues are loaded. Marker is solid. Engagement is solid. We're not doing any obedience work today — pressure conditioning runs in isolation.

THE STORY

The single biggest misunderstanding I see about leash work in pet dog training is the assumption that the leash is *restraint*. That its job is to physically prevent the dog from doing something. That the dog feels pressure on the leash and the natural response is to fight it, because the leash is in the way of what the dog wants.

That's how most dogs experience the leash. And it's why most dogs hate the leash and most owners hate walking their dogs.

Here's what the leash is, in my methodology: **the leash is a communication device that the dog wants to respond to**. Pressure on the leash isn't restraint. It's *language*. It tells the dog "move this direction, your paycheck is coming." The dog moves the direction the leash indicates, the pressure releases, food appears. Within a few sessions of teaching this correctly, the dog starts treating leash pressure not as something to fight but as a cue to follow toward a reward.

This inversion — leash from restraint to language — is the single most important conceptual shift in foundational obedience work. And it has a specific protocol for installing. We start it today.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

You'll need: the slip lead, a small handful of food in your closed hand, your dog, and a quiet room.

This is **not** an obedience drill. We are not asking the dog to sit. We are not asking the dog to do anything specific. We are conditioning the dog to associate pressure on the leash with *getting fed*.

Setup:

- Slip lead on the dog, fitted properly (high on the neck, just behind the ears, not down at the base of the neck where it can choke)
- You standing or sitting facing the dog
- Your closed fist with a piece of kibble in it, held about 4-6 inches in front of the dog's nose
- The leash held in your other hand, with very slight tension — *just enough to draw the leash taut*, not enough to physically move the dog

The drill:

1. Hold your closed hand 4-6 inches in front of the dog's nose. Food is inside.
2. Apply **slight** leash pressure — not pulling, not yanking, just enough that the leash is taut. The dog should be able to feel the pressure but it shouldn't be uncomfortable.
3. The dog will step forward toward the food. The leash goes slack as they move forward.

4. **The instant the leash goes slack — open your hand and let the dog eat the kibble.**

5. Reset. Step back to your starting position. Take another piece of kibble.

6. Repeat.

The sequence the dog is learning, rep by rep: *Feel pressure* → *move forward* → *pressure disappears* → *food appears*.

Run this for 10-15 minutes. Aim for somewhere around 50-100 clean reps in this first session.

Critical: pressure must be SLIGHT. Just enough for the dog to feel the leash become taut. Not enough to physically move the dog. The dog has to be *choosing* to move forward (toward the food), and that choice has to be what releases the pressure. If the pressure is so strong that you're physically pulling the dog forward, you're not conditioning anything — you're just yanking them around.

WHAT "SLIGHT" ACTUALLY FEELS LIKE

If you've never done this kind of work, your sense of what "slight" pressure means is probably off. Most people apply way too much pressure on the first few reps because they're used to leashes-as-restraint and they overcompensate.

Here's a calibration: you should be able to apply this much pressure with a single finger. Just one finger. Not your whole hand. The leash should become taut — meaning the slack is taken out of it — but the dog shouldn't be physically moving from the pressure. The pressure should be enough that the dog *notices* it, not enough that it does anything to them.

If your dog is digging in, bracing, or pulling away from the pressure — you went too high. Back off. Start lighter. The pressure has to be small enough that the dog's response is "huh, what's that, oh, food's right there, let me go get it" rather than "what is this thing pulling on my neck, I have to fight it."

WHY THIS MATTERS

This drill takes the leash, which the dog instinctively interprets as restraint, and inverts it into a positive cue. The mechanism is simple: pressure consistently predicts food. Over enough reps, the dog's brain rewires — instead of *pressure = aversive event*, the dog learns *pressure = food is about to appear*.

Once that inversion is complete, leash pressure becomes a *signal* the dog actively wants to respond to. We can then use leash pressure to communicate direction in obedience work — slight upward pressure to cue sit, downward pressure to cue down, directional pressure toward the bed to cue place.

But — and this is critical — none of that works if pressure means "fight" to the dog. So we install the inversion *first*, in isolation, before we ever try to use pressure as part of an obedience cue.

This is why today and tomorrow are pressure conditioning *only*. No obedience cues. No "sit" with pressure. No "place" with pressure. Just the basic pressure → forward step → food sequence, run over and over, in pure isolation. Once pressure is reliably positive in the dog's brain, we can start layering it under obedience cues — but not before.

BRIAN-ISM

Pressure needs to be a good thing and it needs to be controlled by the dog.

Both halves of that sentence matter. Pressure has to be *good* — meaning the dog associates it with reward, not punishment. And pressure has to be *controlled by the dog* — meaning the dog's own behavior is what releases the pressure. They are the agent. They are not being moved around against their will. They are choosing to move forward, and their choosing is what makes the pressure go away.

If either of those framings is missing — if pressure isn't paired with reward, or if pressure releases on something other than the dog's choice to move — the drill doesn't work and the leash won't ever invert.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog braced against the pressure and won't move forward.

A: Pressure is too high. Lighter. Use less. If you used a finger, use less of a finger. The dog should feel the pressure as a cue, not as a force. If they're bracing, they're feeling it as force. The fix is always to back off, not push harder.

Q: My dog moved forward but didn't seem to notice the pressure was the cue. They just ate the food.

A: Normal first session. The connection takes a couple of dozen reps to form. Keep running the drill. By the second day, you should start seeing the dog's head snap toward you the moment they feel pressure — that's the marker that the conditioning is taking.

Q: How do I know when pressure is conditioned?

A: Test in tomorrow's session: dog is doing something else (sniffing, looking around), not paying attention to you. You apply a tiny, subtle pressure on the leash. **The dog's head rockets toward you, expecting food.** That's conditioned pressure. Until you see that, keep conditioning.

Q: Can I use the slip lead during walks while we're doing this conditioning?

A: Not for the next few days. Use a different setup for walks (regular collar and leash, or skip walks if you can — frankly, most owners don't need daily structured walks the way pet culture suggests). The pressure conditioning needs to be the only context where the dog is feeling slip-lead pressure right now. If they're getting pressure from the slip lead during walks too, the conditioning gets muddled.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did you run 50-100 clean reps of the pressure conditioning drill, with light pressure, the dog moving forward to release pressure, and food delivered the moment the leash went slack? If yes, you're on track. If your pressure was too heavy or you didn't get the reps, repeat tomorrow before advancing.

TOMORROW

Day two of pressure conditioning. Same drill, more reps. We test the conditioning at the end of tomorrow's session.

Day 24 — Pressure Conditioning, Day Two

Today we run the second day of pressure conditioning, and we test whether the inversion has taken.

- ▶ **Before you start today.** Yesterday's pressure conditioning session ran cleanly — slight pressure, dog stepping forward, leash going slack, food. If yesterday's session was sloppy (heavy pressure, dog bracing, food not timed to leash going slack), repeat Day 23 instead.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Two sessions today, same drill as yesterday. Aim for another 50-100 clean reps across the day.

By the end of today's first session, you should start seeing the conditioning take. Specifically: the dog's head snaps toward you the moment they feel pressure, in anticipation of food. That snap is the signal that the leash has flipped from "restraint" to "predictor of food."

If you're seeing the snap reliably by mid-session, you can run **the test** at the end of your second session:

The pressure-conditioning test:

1. Take the leash off normal-tension. Let the dog wander. Let them get distracted by something — sniffing the floor, looking out the window, nosing a corner.
2. From wherever you are, apply a **tiny, subtle pressure** on the leash. Not enough to physically move the dog. Just enough that they would feel the leash become taut.
3. Watch the dog.

What you want to see: the dog's head **rockets toward you, expecting food**. Like the marker test from Day 12 — same kind of snap reaction. The leash pressure has now become a cue that means "look at the human, food is coming."

When you see that, you have **conditioned pressure**. The leash has been inverted. We're ready to use it under obedience cues.

What you might see instead:

- **The dog turns and looks at you, but slowly, with mild interest:** the conditioning is loading but isn't there yet. Run another full session of drilling tomorrow and re-test.
- **The dog ignores the pressure or fights against it:** you used too much pressure during the conditioning sessions, and the dog is still treating the leash as something to fight. Reset to Day 23, lighter pressure, more reps.

WHY THIS MATTERS

This test is the gate to start using leash pressure in any obedience context. If the leash hasn't inverted, every later use of pressure in obedience is going to fail — you'll cue with pressure and the dog will brace against it, or fight it, or try to escape from it. Pressure won't function as the directional cue we need it to be.

Once the leash has inverted, pressure becomes a tool you can use to communicate direction without any risk of the dog reading it as restraint. Slight upward pressure means "go up" (sit). Slight downward pressure means "go down." Directional pressure toward the bed means "go that way." All of those will load cleanly because the underlying state — pressure means food is coming — is already in place.

The other thing today does: it gives the dog a *positive emotional response* to the leash itself. Most dogs that come to me at my facility have a mild aversion to the leash. They tense up when the leash comes out, they avoid putting their head in the slip, they pull on the leash because they associate it with restraint. By the end of pressure conditioning, the leash is associated with food and the dog's emotional response to it changes. They get *excited* when the leash comes out. The leash has become the source of paychecks, not the source of friction.

BRIAN-ISM

We are teaching them that while normally they view the leash as the thing that keeps them away from doing fun stuff, this actually teaches them that the leash is the author of fun stuff.

That's the inversion. The leash goes from being the obstacle between the dog and what they want, to being the source of what they want. Once that flip happens, every leash interaction in the dog's life is different.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog passed the test on the first try. Can I move on?

A: Yes. If the dog is reliably snapping toward you on cold pressure during the test, the inversion is in. Advance to Day 25.

Q: My dog looks at me when I apply pressure, but doesn't really come toward me. They just look.

A: That's okay — the conditioning is partial. The looking-toward is the first half (orientation toward the food source). We'll naturally build the moving-toward when we start using pressure for actual obedience cues in Day 25. Advance, but be aware the response is at minimum threshold.

Q: My dog totally ignores the pressure during the test.

A: The conditioning didn't take. Most likely cause: too much pressure during the conditioning sessions, so the dog was fighting it instead of following it. Reset to Day 23 with strict attention to using less pressure. The dog's response should be "huh, food cue" not "what's pulling on me."

Q: My dog yelps or vocalizes when they feel any pressure on the slip lead.

A: Two checks. One — is the slip lead fitted properly? It should ride high on the neck, just behind the ears. If it's down at the base of the neck, even slight pressure can be uncomfortable. Two — are you using a thinner-diameter slip lead like the equipment list called for? Thicker leashes with bulky stoppers can dig in. If the equipment is right and the dog is still vocalizing on slight pressure, DM me in the community — there's likely something specific to your dog (skin sensitivity, prior trauma, anatomy) that we should adjust for.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did the dog pass the pressure-conditioning test — head snapping toward you on cold pressure, expecting food? **Yes:** advance to Day 25. **Conditional pass (slow look-toward):** advance with caution, more conditioning will continue to develop alongside the next drills. **Failed:** reset to Day 23, lighter pressure, more reps.

TOMORROW

We marry pressure to a known cue. The first time pressure becomes part of an obedience command. This is where the leash starts doing real work.

Day 25 — Marrying Pressure to a Known Cue

Today the leash and the verbal cue come together for the first time. We use pressure not to force the dog into the position, but as a tactile cue layered alongside the verbal one. By the end of today, your dog has both an audible and a tactile cue for the same behavior.

- ▶ **Before you start today.** Pressure is conditioned (Day 24 test passed, even at minimum threshold). Verbal cues for sit, down, and place are loaded. We're now combining the two systems.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

We'll start with one cue today — the first one you installed on Day 21. For most of you that's "sit." If yours was different, substitute accordingly.

Setup:

- Slip lead on the dog, fitted properly
- You standing in front of the dog, leash in one hand, food in your other hand or in a pouch
- A quiet room, low distraction

The drill:

1. With the dog standing in front of you, **say the verbal cue** ("sit") **and simultaneously apply slight upward pressure on the leash** — pulling the leash up gently, just enough that it draws taut but doesn't lift the dog.
2. The dog drops into the sit (because they know the verbal cue and because the upward pressure cues the same direction).
3. **The instant the dog's butt hits the floor, release the pressure.** Immediately. Same time as the marker.
4. Mark — click. Pay.
5. Reset. Stand the dog back up. Take another piece of food. Repeat.

That's the drill. *Cue + pressure together → dog enters position → pressure releases on completion → mark → pay.*

Run 15-20 reps of sit with pressure today. By the end, the dog should be: - Responding to the combined cue smoothly - Not bracing or fighting the pressure - Receiving the pressure release the instant they sit - Getting marked and paid right after

THE UNBREAKABLE RULE OF PRESSURE WORK

This is critical and I want it in your head every time you use pressure in any obedience context for the rest of your dog's training career:

Pressure stays on until the behavior completes. Pressure releases the instant the behavior completes. Then mark, then pay.

In order: 1. Pressure starts when you cue. 2. Pressure stays on through the dog's transition into position. 3. Pressure releases the *instant* the dog hits the position. Not a half-second early. Not a half-second late. The instant. 4. Marker happens. 5. Food gets delivered.

The reason this matters: **if you release pressure while the dog is doing anything other than the right thing, you've just rewarded the wrong thing.**

Example of how this breaks:

You say "sit" + apply pressure. Dog fights the pressure for two seconds, pulls backward, tries to escape. Owner feels uncomfortable about the pressure and eases up. Dog feels the pressure release.

What just got reinforced? The fighting. The pulling backward. The escape attempts. Because the pressure released *while the dog was doing those things*, the dog learned that those things produce pressure release.

The fix is to make sure pressure does not release until the dog completes the behavior — which means you have to maintain the pressure even when the dog is fighting, even when it feels uncomfortable to you. You hold until the dog gives up the fight and produces the correct behavior. The instant they do, pressure releases.

WHY THIS MATTERS

We've been building toward this moment for two and a half weeks. Today is when the obedience starts to get *bulletproof*. Up until now, every behavior the dog knows is *motivation-based* — they do it because they want the food. That works in cooperative settings, but it doesn't work when something else is more interesting than food. A motivated-only dog ignores the cue when a squirrel runs across the yard.

Pressure adds *obligation* on top of motivation. Now the dog has both: - *Motivation*: sit because food is at stake - *Obligation*: sit because the pressure cues sit and the pressure won't release until they sit

A dog with both motivation and obligation has what's called the 80/20 balance — most of their compliance comes from motivation (80%), and the remaining bit comes from obligation (20%). When motivation alone isn't enough to get compliance — say, in the face of a strong distraction — the obligation kicks in and finishes the job.

This is why Week 3 work matters so much for what comes later. A foundation of motivation + obligation can be deployed in any environment. A foundation of motivation only collapses the moment something interesting shows up.

The other thing pressure does: it gives the dog **a tactile cue independent of your voice**. This matters in real-life scenarios where you can't always speak — in the car, on a phone call, at a noisy event, in an emergency. A dog who's been trained on dual cues (audible + tactile) will respond to either one alone, which is operational redundancy that pays off when you need it.

BRIAN-ISM

*Pressure starts, pressure stays until behavior is done, then pressure goes away.
Then I mark with my appropriate marker, and then I pay the dog handsomely.*

That's the order. Burn it into your hand. Pressure → behavior → release → mark → pay. Every rep. Every cue.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog fought the pressure today, even though they didn't fight it during conditioning. What changed?

A: The pressure is now happening in a more demanding context (they have to do something specific to make it stop). Two things to check. One — was the pressure too heavy? Use less. Two — was the verbal cue solid enough? If the dog is unclear what behavior to do, the pressure feels like force without language. If the verbal cue is weak, go back to Day 21 and run more cued-only reps before re-introducing pressure.

Q: I released pressure too early — the dog was halfway down and I let go. Now what?

A: Don't pay that rep. Reset. Try again. The dog learns from clean reps; sloppy reps confuse them. Single mistakes are recoverable as long as you don't reinforce them by paying out.

Q: My dog responded to the verbal cue alone before I even applied the pressure. Should I still apply pressure?

A: Apply it anyway, this week. Even if the dog goes into position before the pressure has any effect, we want them to feel the pressure as part of the cue so the dual-cue system installs. After this week, when the dog is reliable on both cues, you can use either cue alone in real-life contexts. For the next several days of training, both go together.

Q: How light is too light? Can I use too little pressure?

A: Yes — if the pressure is so light the dog doesn't feel it, the tactile cue doesn't register and the dog only responds to the verbal cue. Pressure should be slight but perceptible. The right level is "the dog's neck moves a fraction of an inch in the cue direction." If the leash is going taut and the dog is showing no body response, increase slightly.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did you complete 15-20 reps of sit-with-pressure, with clean pressure-release timing on each rep, no fighting from the dog, and clean marking and paying? **Yes:** advance to Day 26 tomorrow. **No:** identify what was off (pressure too heavy, release too late, dog confused on the verbal cue) and rerun today's drill.

TOMORROW

We marry pressure to the other two positions — down and place. By end of day tomorrow, your dog has dual-cue (audible + tactile) understanding of all three base positions.

Day 26 — Marrying Pressure to the Other Two Positions

Today we layer pressure under down and place. Same drill, same rules, applied to the other two cues. By end of today, all three positions are dual-cued.

- **Before you start today.** Yesterday's sit-with-pressure work was clean — the dog responded to combined cue + pressure, didn't fight the leash, pressure released cleanly on completion. If yesterday was rough, repeat Day 25 instead.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Two sessions today. Session one — down with pressure. Session two — place with pressure. Same setup as yesterday: slip lead, you facing the dog (or near the place bed for session two), food in pouch, quiet room.

Session one — down with pressure:

1. Start with the dog standing in front of you.
2. Say "down" *and* simultaneously apply slight **downward** pressure on the leash — drawing the leash gently down toward the floor. Just enough that it draws taut and gives the dog a directional sensation downward.
3. Dog drops into the down (because they know the verbal cue and because the downward pressure cues that direction).
4. **The instant the dog's chest and elbows make full contact with the floor, release the pressure.**
5. Mark — click. Pay directly from your hand.
6. Reset — **cue "get it" and toss a piece of food a couple of feet so they get up to eat it.**
7. Repeat.

Run 15-20 reps. Same rules as sit: pressure stays on through the transition, releases the *instant* the position is complete, then mark, then pay.

Session two — place with pressure:

This one is different from the other two because place is a chained behavior (the dog has to go to the bed, get on it, and hold it). Pressure for place is *directional* toward the bed, not up or down.

1. Set up with the dog standing about 4-6 feet from the place bed, slip lead on, you near the bed.
2. Say "place" *and* simultaneously apply slight pressure on the leash *in the direction of the bed*. Just enough to give the dog a directional cue — not enough to pull them toward it.
3. Dog moves toward the bed (because they know the verbal cue and the pressure points the same way).
4. **The instant the dog's feet make full contact with the bed, release the pressure.**
5. Mark — click. Pay (deliver food *to the dog on the bed* directly from your hand, not by tossing them off it).
6. Hold position briefly (5-10 seconds), then release with "free" or pay another piece for staying.
7. **Cue "get it" and toss a piece off the bed to reset.** Repeat.

Run 10-15 reps. Place is more demanding than the other two because of the chained nature of the behavior.

A NOTE ON TROUBLESHOOTING PLACE PRESSURE

The most common issue with place + pressure: the dog turns the wrong direction, or stalls partway, or jumps off the bed mid-rep.

If the dog turns the wrong way — your directional pressure is unclear. Reposition yourself so the line from the dog to the bed is direct, and apply pressure clearly in that line. Don't wave the leash around — it has to feel like a single, clean directional pull.

If the dog stalls partway to the bed — they're not yet committed to the chain. Release pressure and reset. Don't hold the dog in a stalled state with constant pressure; that teaches them that stalling is the response that produces sustained pressure. Try again with a more confident verbal cue and slightly stronger directional pressure.

If the dog gets on the bed and immediately jumps off — common during early pressure work on place. Pay them faster, before they can jump off. Eventually they'll learn to *hold* on the bed for the click + pay. We'll work duration on place + pressure in the next few days.

WHY THIS MATTERS

By the end of today, your dog has three obedience positions, each on dual cues — verbal + tactile. That's the operational unit of obedience. From this foundation, you can deploy any of the three positions in any environment, with either cue or both cues, and the dog has the language to understand what's being asked.

The dual-cue system also gives you redundancy when the world gets noisy. In a busy environment where your voice might not carry, the leash can communicate the cue tactilely. In a context where you're trying not to draw attention, the leash can do the work without you saying anything. The dog reads either signal as the same instruction.

The other thing dual-cue work does: it makes corrections cleaner. When we eventually need to correct a dog for ignoring a cue, we have two channels to use. The dog can't claim "I didn't hear you" or "I didn't feel anything." Both signals went out. Failure to respond is failure to respond.

BRIAN-ISM

The dog "wants to" AND "has to."

That's the 80/20 balance. Mostly motivated, with enough obligation underneath to handle the cases where motivation alone wouldn't be enough. That's where you are at the end of today's session.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: Down with pressure is harder than sit with pressure. My dog half-downs and I'm not sure when to release.

A: Wait for chest AND elbows AND hips to be on the floor. A "sphinx" with the back end up is a partial. Hold pressure until the dog fully commits. The first few reps may feel awkward — that's normal. Within 10-15 reps the dog catches on and starts going to the full position quickly.

Q: Place with pressure isn't connecting. My dog goes to the bed without the pressure but with the pressure they get confused.

A: The pressure direction may be unclear. Stand directly between the bed and the dog at first, with the bed behind you, so the line of pressure is unambiguous. As the dog gets the concept, you can apply pressure from other angles. The clarity of the directional pressure matters more than its strength.

Q: My dog has started doing all three positions reliably with just the verbal cue, before the pressure has any effect. Should I drop the pressure?

A: Not yet — keep both cues paired this week. We're still building the dual-cue association. Once we get into Days 27-29 distraction work, you can experiment with cue-alone vs cue+pressure and see which the dog needs in different contexts. For today's reps, both go together.

Q: How does this connect to the leash on a walk?

A: Long-term, this is exactly how heel and direction-changes on a walk work — through directional leash pressure that the dog interprets as a cue, not as restraint. We're not getting into walk-specific work in this 30-day guide (that's outdoor work, which is its own project), but the foundation is identical. Today's drill is the engine that powers leash work for the rest of your dog's life.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Did you complete clean reps of both down-with-pressure and place-with-pressure, with the dog responding without fighting and pressure releasing cleanly on completion?
Yes: advance to Day 27 tomorrow. **No:** identify the weak position and re-run that session before advancing.

TOMORROW

The first day of indoor distraction proofing. We start small. The dog has to hold position while *you* do mildly interesting things in the room.

Day 27 — Indoor Distraction Proofing, Layer 1: Handler-Controlled

Today we start the work that turns "knows the cue in the chair-and-leash setup" into "responds to the cue in the actual world." We start with the easiest distraction: you. By end of week, the dog will hold obedience through real-life household chaos.

- **Before you start today.** All three positions are on dual cues (verbal + tactile pressure). The dog responds to both cues without confusion or fighting. If the dual-cue work is shaky, don't run today — go back to Day 26.

THE STORY

There's a moment in every board-and-train where the dog hits what I call the *fluent in the room, useless in the world* problem. The dog has been trained for two and a half weeks. They sit on cue, down on cue, hold place beautifully — when we're standing in the training room with no distractions and nothing else going on. Take that same dog into a different room with the dishwasher running and a kid walking through, and suddenly the cues mean nothing. The dog ignores them. The owner thinks the dog "forgot" the cues.

The dog didn't forget. The cues were never *generalized* in the first place. They lived only in the specific context where they were trained. The dog hadn't yet learned that "sit" means "do the sit behavior" *regardless of what else is going on*.

The fix for this is **proofing**. And the way you proof correctly is to start with the smallest possible distraction and build up gradually, in a controlled way, never letting the dog rehearse failure. You don't take a dog who's only worked in the training room and immediately throw them into a busy public environment — that's setting them up to fail at every cue, which trains them that cues are optional. You start tiny and work up.

The smallest, most controllable distraction in your environment is **you**. You moving around. You sitting and standing. You walking past the dog. You with your back turned. We start with you because you're the easiest variable to control, the easiest to scale up gradually, and the most useful to proof against (because in real life, you're going to be moving around all the time while expecting the dog to hold position).

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Two sessions today. Each session is the same drill: cue the dog into a position, then introduce a small handler-movement distraction, mark and pay if the dog holds, reset and adjust if they break.

Setup:

- Place bed in position
- Slip lead on the dog (we'll use pressure if needed)
- Pouch of food on your hip
- Quiet room — not the training chair setup, but a normal household room

The drill — graduated handler movement:

Start at the easiest level. The instant the dog can hold position cleanly through a level, advance to the next level. If they break, drop back a level and rebuild.

Level 1 — handler shifts weight while standing in front of the dog.

Cue the dog to sit. Stand in front of them. **Shift your weight from one foot to the other.** That's the distraction. Hold the dog in position for 5-10 seconds. Mark. Pay (deliver food *to the dog* in position, don't make them break to come get it).

Level 2 — handler takes one step to the side.

Cue the dog to sit. Stand in front of them. **Take one step to the side, then step back.** Hold position. Mark. Pay.

Level 3 — handler takes two steps to the side, pauses, then back.

Level 4 — handler walks a small circle around the dog.

Level 5 — handler turns their back to the dog briefly, then turns back.

Level 6 — handler walks 10 feet away, stops, walks back.

The progression is gradual. Each level adds slightly more distance, slightly more time, slightly more visual variability. The dog has to hold position through each one before you advance.

Run this with sit, then with down, then with place — any of the three positions can be the holding behavior. Vary which one you use across the session.

If the dog breaks position:

- **Don't pay.**
- **Calmly say "no."** Not loud, not angry — just a flat, neutral verbal marker that tells the dog *that wasn't it*.
- **Re-issue the command coupled with leash pressure.** "Sit" + upward pressure, "down" + downward pressure, "place" + directional pressure toward the bed. Same combined cue you installed on Days 25-26.
- The dog re-enters position. Pressure releases the instant they're in. **Do not click. Do not pay.** This part is critical and most owners get it wrong — read the next paragraph carefully.

Why you do NOT mark and pay the re-entry into position: because a smart, high-drive dog will figure out the chain very quickly. *Break → get told no → get pressured back into position → get clicked → get paid.* If that's the chain that ends in food, the dog will start *breaking on purpose* to run the chain, because the chain pays. You'll think you're correcting a mistake; the dog will think you're running a multi-step rep and they'll get progressively quicker about offering the break-and-recover loop because it's the most efficient path to the click.

The fix is simple but it has to be strict: **after a break and re-cue, the dog has to demonstrate a fresh, clean rep before they get paid.** Hold them in position for several seconds with no marker, no food, no acknowledgment. Then, separately, run a clean rep of the same level (or the easier level you've dropped back to) — *that* rep, the one that happened without a break, gets the click and the pay.

The break-and-recover never gets paired with reward. The dog learns that the only way to the click is *not breaking in the first place*.

If the dog keeps breaking on the same level, you've got one of two situations and you have to read the dog to figure out which:

Situation one — you moved too fast. The level of distraction you advanced to is genuinely beyond what the dog can hold right now. Their training isn't there yet. The fix is to drop back a level, build more reps at the easier level, and advance more gradually. This is the most common cause of repeated breaks and you should rule it out first.

Situation two — the dog understands and is choosing to leave anyway. By this point in the program — the dog has loaded verbal cues from Week 3, conditioned pressure as a positive directional cue, and married pressure to every position — they have the full language to know exactly what's being asked. If you're confident the dog *understands* and is breaking because the distraction is more interesting than holding position, that's a different problem than not knowing. That's the dog needing to learn that there's a consequence for leaving the position when they've been told to hold it. The calm "no" + re-cue + pressure is that consequence. Done consistently — and crucially, *without paying the re-entry* — the dog learns: *breaking position produces immediate, calm, predictable pressure that puts me right back where I was supposed to be, and produces no food. The only way to get paid is not to break in the first place*. Within a handful of reps, most dogs make the math: holding position is the path to food, breaking is the path to pressure with no payoff.

The judgment call — which situation you're in — is yours to make. If you genuinely don't know, default to situation one and back up the level. Easier-level reps cost you very little. Reps where the dog rehearses the wrong response cost you a lot. When in doubt, back up.

THE PAY-THE-DECISION RULE

There's a specific moment that's worth paying generously when it happens during this work.

You're at, say, level 4 — walking a small circle around the dog. The dog starts to break position. You can see it — they shift, they stand up halfway, they're about to leave the position.

Then they catch themselves. They stop mid-break. They settle back into the position. You can almost see the thought: *wait, I'm not getting off place*.

Pay that decision the moment they make it. Don't wait for the position to get cleaner. The decision-to-stay is what we want to reinforce — the moment of choosing the right answer when the wrong answer was easier. That moment is worth more than ten clean reps of the same position with no temptation.

This is one of the most important nuances in all of obedience work. The dog who's been paid for catching themselves in the act of breaking has internalized the lesson at a much deeper level than the dog who's only been paid for clean reps. You're rewarding their *judgment*, not just their compliance.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Every behavior lives somewhere on a continuum from *fragile* to *bombproof*. A fragile behavior collapses the moment the context changes — different room, different time, different person, different

distraction level. A bombproof behavior holds across changes.

What moves a behavior from fragile to bombproof is *graduated exposure to variability*. The dog has to perform the behavior under increasingly challenging conditions, with each step small enough that they can succeed. Every successful rep at a new level adds another brick to the bombproof wall. Every failed rep where the dog rehearses the wrong response (breaking, ignoring the cue, defaulting to a different behavior) chips away at the wall.

This is why we proof the way we do — small steps, no failures rehearsed, lots of reps at each level before advancing. The dog who comes out of three weeks of careful proofing has a foundation that'll stand up to almost any normal household variability. The dog who skips proofing has cues that work in some places but not others, and the owner spends years frustrated.

BRIAN-ISM

Pay that decision the moment she decides not to break.

The decision is the work. Reward the decision and the decisions get easier. The behavior follows the decisions.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog held position through every level. Should I push to harder distractions today?

A: No. Today is layer 1. Tomorrow we add environmental distractions (food on the floor, sounds), and the day after we add social distractions (other people, doors). Stay at handler-movement level for today even if your dog is breezing through it. Tomorrow we layer up.

Q: My dog kept breaking at level 4 (circling). What now?

A: Spend extra reps at level 3 (a few side steps) until it's solid. Then try level 4 again. If level 4 keeps being the wall, break it down further — instead of circling all the way around, walk halfway around and stop, mark and pay if they hold. Build up to the full circle in smaller steps. There's always a smaller step you can break into.

Q: My dog held the sit fine but kept breaking on place. What's the difference?

A: Place asks for more — it's a holding behavior in a specific location, which feels more demanding than just "sit here." Some dogs are stronger on sit than place at this stage. That's fine. Run more reps at lower levels of distraction on place until it catches up. Don't try to keep place at the same level of difficulty as sit before place is ready.

Q: Should I be saying 'place' / 'sit' / 'down' as I move around, or just trust the original cue?

A: Trust the original cue. Don't repeat the cue while the dog is in position — that confuses them about whether you're still asking for the same thing or asking for something new. If you cued sit, the dog is sitting until you give a different cue or release them with "free." Re-cuing during a hold trains the dog to interpret your voice as constant nagging instead of as discrete commands.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Can the dog hold each of the three positions through at least levels 1-3 of handler movement, and ideally through level 4 or 5? **Yes:** advance to Day 28 tomorrow. **No:** stay here, more reps at the lower levels.

TOMORROW

We add environmental distractions. The dog has to hold position while real environmental things are going on around them — food on the floor, a wadded paper rolling past, household sounds.

Day 28 — Indoor Distraction Proofing, Layer 2: Environmental

Today we add real-world distractions — food on the floor, sounds, objects in motion. These are the things your dog is actually going to face in daily life. By end of today they should be holding position through most of them.

- ▶ **Before you start today.** Day 27's handler-movement proofing is solid. The dog can hold the three positions through you walking around, sitting and standing, turning your back. If level 4-5 of yesterday's drill is still wobbly, repeat Day 27.

THE STORY

A while back, on a member call, a woman was telling me she'd been "wishy-washy" on her walks. Her words. Some days she let the dog sniff. Some days she pulled him off it. Some days she enforced a strict no-sniffing rule. The dog, as you'd expect, was confused — and the walk was a disaster.

I told her what I tell everybody in that situation, because it's the same answer every time: **the inconsistency is the actual problem, not the dog's behavior.** You can't be wishy-washy. You have to be the point of stability for the dog. You have to set the line, you have to go *this is the requirement, there are no other options*, and once you've made that decision you can't go the other way — because going the other way is what's creating the inconsistency in the first place.

This is just one specific instance of the bigger principle from a few days back: dogs live in the land of always and never. Sniffing on walks is an *always or never* call, not a *sometimes when I feel like it* call. And until you settle the always-or-never piece in your own head, the dog can't possibly settle it in theirs.

Then I gave her the prescription, which is the same one I'm about to give you, just translated indoors. Before you do *any* of this on a real walk — go to your fenced yard. Throw a handful of food on the ground. Walk the dog past it without letting them go nose-down. Reward keeping the head up and following your direction. Increase your intensity of distraction over reps. Start small. Win small. Then move to start winning.

That's the entire drill. Sounds almost too simple to be the foundation of a non-reactive walk, but it is. The reason it works is that it lets you teach the always-or-never rule about food on the ground in a controlled environment, with no triggers, no other people, no traffic — just the dog, the food, and you holding the line. Once that foundation is clean in the yard, you can take it onto walks. If you skip the yard step and try to install the rule in the chaos of a real walk, you'll never get it clean, because every breakdown is reinforcing the wrong pattern.

We're going to run a smaller, indoor version of this same drill today. The principle is identical: introduce the distraction in a controlled way, hold the line on the rule, build the dog's tolerance through structured wins.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Two sessions today, same setup as yesterday — one of the three positions is the holding behavior, you control the distraction, mark and pay successful holds.

Setup:

- Place bed in the room (we'll use place a lot today since it's the position most likely to be used in real life with environmental distractions)
- Slip lead on
- Some pieces of kibble in your pouch
- Some additional pieces of kibble or low-value treats to use as the *distraction*

The drill — graduated environmental distractions:

Each level is a slightly more demanding distraction. Cue the dog into position (sit, down, or place — whichever you're working). Then introduce the distraction. Hold the dog in position. Mark and pay if they hold. Reset and drop back if they break.

Level 1 — drop a piece of kibble on the floor 6 feet away from the dog.

Cue place. Get the dog on the bed. Then casually drop a piece of kibble on the floor, 6 feet away, without making a big deal of it. Dog has to stay on the bed.

If the dog holds — mark, pay (food delivered to them on the bed, not the dropped piece on the floor). Reset.

If the dog breaks to go after the dropped piece — **don't pay. Calmly say "no." Re-cue place coupled with directional pressure toward the bed.** The dog gets put back on the bed under pressure, not allowed to circle back to it on their own terms. **No click, no food on the re-entry** — same rule as yesterday. They have to demonstrate a fresh, clean rep before any reward appears.

Then make the next rep easier — greater distance to the dropped piece, or a smaller piece, or both — until the dog can succeed. Same logic as yesterday: if they keep breaking on the same level, either you advanced too fast (back up) or the dog understands and is choosing the food anyway (the calm "no" + re-cue + pressure with no reward on re-entry is the consequence). Use your judgment. When in doubt, back up the level.

The food-on-the-floor rule has a strictness to it that yesterday's handler-movement work didn't — and you'll see why in a minute.

Level 2 — drop a piece 3 feet away.

Level 3 — drop a piece 1 foot away.

Level 4 — drop a piece directly in front of the bed, within nose-reach.

Level 5 — toss a wadded piece of paper across the room (motion distraction, no food involved).

Level 6 — make a small household sound — drop a measuring cup on the counter, run the kitchen tap for a few seconds, open a cabinet door.

Level 7 — combine — drop a piece of food *and* make a sound, simultaneously.

By the end of today's two sessions, the dog should hold position through at least levels 1-4. Level 5-7 might still be wobbly — that's fine. We continue to build through the next couple of days.

THE "ALWAYS OR NEVER" RULE ON THE DROPPED FOOD

Important rule that applies starting today and forever:

The dog never gets to go after the dropped piece. Ever. Not as a reward at the end of the session. Not "just once." Ever.

If you let the dog go for the dropped piece even once, you've taught them that the right answer is to wait the human out and they'll eventually get to go for it. The whole drill becomes self-defeating. The dropped piece is *never* available to the dog. The dog gets paid from your pouch, with food delivered to them in position. The dropped piece sits on the floor through the entire session. At the end of the session, you pick it up and put it back in the bag.

This is what makes the lesson stick: food on the floor is *never* the dog's food. They don't get to challenge the rule and discover it's negotiable. The rule is absolute.

You'll see the lesson start to install around the third or fourth session: the dog stops even *looking* at dropped food. They cue right past it, eyes on you, waiting for the click. That's the lesson — *food on the floor is not for me*.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Environmental distraction-proofing is what turns the dog who's "trained at home" into a dog who's actually trained. The cues now have to compete with real-world stimuli — moving objects, sounds, food, novelty. A cue that holds through these is a cue that'll hold through almost anything.

The drill also installs an important meta-lesson: *the cue is the cue, regardless of what else is happening*. Up until today, the dog has done the cue in cooperative settings where nothing was competing for their attention. Now they're learning that the cue applies even when something else is also interesting. That generalization is what makes the cue durable.

The food-on-the-floor work also gets the dog used to the principle that **food the human didn't give them is not for them**. This is going to be hugely useful in real life — counter surfing, trash-eating, picking things up off the ground on walks, accepting food from strangers. All of those problems trace back to the dog not having internalized "food I wasn't given is not mine." Today is where that lesson starts.

BRIAN-ISM

Increase your intensity of distraction. Start small. Win small, then move to start winning bigger.

That's the whole proofing playbook in one sentence. Win small. Win small again. Then advance. The dog who's won 50 small reps before they ever face a hard rep is a dog who's going to win the hard rep when it comes.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My dog broke and grabbed the dropped kibble before I could stop them. Now what?

A: Doesn't reset everything, but it's a setback. Don't try to take the food out of their mouth. Just don't pay. Reset and drop way back — start with food at 10+ feet away. Build back up over more reps. The dog now thinks dropped food is sometimes available; you have to re-prove it isn't.

Q: What if my dog is so motivated by the dropped food that they can't hold position even at 10 feet?

A: Use lower-value distractions. Instead of dropping kibble (which they're motivated by), drop something neutral — a wadded paper, a sock, a small toy they're not particularly attached to. Build the holding behavior with neutral distractions first, then layer in food once the holding is solid.

Q: My dog held position through everything I threw at them. Are they distraction-proof?

A: They're indoor distraction-proof at the levels you tested. That's where the title of this guide ends — solid indoor obedience. Outdoor distractions are a whole different category (other dogs, prey animals, environmental novelty) and require a whole different progression. Read Day 30's "what's next" handoff for context.

Q: My dog held position but kept staring at the dropped food. They didn't break, but they were obviously locked on it.

A: Workable but not ideal. The dog is using willpower, not genuine indifference. Run more reps at that level — over time, as they realize the food is never going to be theirs, they'll stop locking on it. The lock-on fades faster than you'd think.

✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Can the dog hold position through at least levels 1-4 (food at multiple distances) and through some sound-based distractions? **Yes:** advance to Day 29 tomorrow. **No:** stay here, work the lower levels with more reps.

TOMORROW

The third layer — social distractions. Other people in the room, the doorbell, voices, deliveries. The hardest indoor distractions to proof against because they involve the most variables.

Day 29 — Indoor Distraction Proofing, Layer 3: Social

Today we add the hardest indoor distractions — other people, the doorbell, doors opening and closing, voices in the room. By end of today, your dog should be able to hold position through most everyday household chaos.

- ▶ **Before you start today.** Day 28's environmental proofing is solid. The dog can hold position through dropped food and household sounds at multiple intensity levels. If yesterday's higher levels are still wobbly, repeat Day 28.

WHAT YOU'RE GOING TO DO

Two sessions today. Same general format — cue the dog into position, introduce a social distraction, mark and pay successful holds, reset on breaks. The big change today is that you'll need a helper for some levels — another adult in the household, ideally.

Setup:

- Place bed positioned in a normal household location (entryway is great — that's where most social distractions actually happen)
- Slip lead on
- Pouch of food on your hip
- A second person available for the higher levels (if not, work the lower levels alone today and have someone help tomorrow)

The drill — graduated social distractions:

Level 1 — another household member walks through the room.

Cue the dog into place. Have your helper walk casually through the room from one side to the other, without acknowledging the dog. Dog has to hold position.

If they hold — mark, pay direct. If they break — **don't pay. Calmly say "no." Re-cue the position with leash pressure. No click, no food on re-entry** — same rule from the last two days. The reward only comes after a fresh, clean rep without a break. Then either drop back the level (helper walks slower or further away) or run the same level again, depending on whether the dog needs an easier rep or just needs to learn that breaking has the same consequence in this context as it did yesterday.

Level 2 — household member walks through the room and stops to talk to you.

Same as level 1, but the helper stops near you, says a few words, then continues. Dog still has to hold.

Level 3 — household member walks past the dog more closely (within a few feet).

Level 4 — household member walks past while making more noise (saying hi to the dog, even — tempting them).

Level 5 — sound-based: someone in the house knocks on the wall (mock doorbell).

Level 6 — actual doorbell rings.

Level 7 — someone walks to the front door, opens it, closes it, comes back. Dog holds through the whole sequence.

Level 8 — someone walks to the front door, opens it, calls out something casual, closes it. Dog holds.

By end of today's sessions, the dog should hold position through at least levels 1-5. Levels 6-8 (doorbell and door work) might require additional days — those are the hardest indoor distractions and often need more reps to fully proof. That's fine. We're not aiming for perfection on every level today — we're aiming for the dog to hold through the lower-level social stuff and to be making progress on the higher levels.

THE DOORBELL ISOLATION PRINCIPLE

If your dog has any history of going crazy at the doorbell or at people coming to the door, today's higher levels are going to be the most challenging part of the entire 30-day program. There's a specific way to break the door work down that I want to call out:

Isolate the variables. Most owners try to introduce all the door variables at once — knock, opening, closing, person, voice, hello — and the dog gets overwhelmed. Instead, peel the variables apart and proof them one at a time.

The breakdown:

1. **Walking to the door** while dog holds place. Just the walking. No knocking, no opening, no anything else.
2. **Knocking on the door** (from the inside, by you) while dog holds place. Just the knock.
3. **Opening the door, closing the door** (no person, no voice). Just the door operating.
4. **Combining knock + open + close** while dog holds place.
5. **Walking back to the dog** after closing. Dog has to hold through your return.
6. **Adding a voice** — you say "hello" from the doorway. Dog holds.
7. **Adding a person at the door** — helper at the door, but staying outside, not entering.
8. **Person enters** — but doesn't approach the dog.
9. **Person enters and approaches you (not the dog).**

That's the isolation pattern. Each variable gets its own reps before it gets combined with the next. By the time you get to "actual visitor enters and walks past the dog to talk to me," every individual variable has been independently proofed and the combined event is just *all the things the dog already knows how to handle, happening together*.

You will not finish all of this today. You'll start it. The doorbell-and-visitor work usually takes another week or two beyond Day 30 to get rock-solid, and that's the kind of thing you continue working as part of normal household life.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Social distraction is the hardest category of distraction to proof against because it involves the most variables and often the highest emotional charge. Other people moving in the dog's space, talking,

opening doors, ringing bells — these are the things that produce the dog's biggest reactions and the hardest training failures.

The reason isolation matters so much for door work specifically: most dogs that go nuclear at the doorbell aren't reacting to one thing. They're reacting to a *cascade* of stimuli that all happen at once — bell, footsteps, opening, voice, novel person, smell, social pressure — and their brain spirals. By isolating each variable and proofing them separately, we break the cascade. By the time the dog is facing the full event, every component is familiar and the brain doesn't spiral.

This is also the principle behind not pre-announcing visitors. Don't tell the dog "we have a visitor!" before the bell rings. That just primes them into a heightened state before the event happens. The visitor should be a non-event from the dog's perspective. They've held place through a hundred small social distractions; this is just one more.

BRIAN-ISM

Don't pre-announce visitors. They put the dog in an elevated state of mind. The visitor should be a non-event from the dog's perspective.

COMMON QUESTIONS

Q: My helper opened the door and the dog broke immediately. We can't even get past level 7. What do I do?

A: Drop way back. Spend more reps at levels 1-4 before trying door variables. The door is loaded for your dog — it has years of "doorbell = chaos" association behind it. The proofing has to be more gradual for door-loaded dogs. Spend a couple of days at the lower levels, then peel the door variables apart as described in the isolation breakdown.

Q: My dog can hold place when one person walks through, but if my partner AND my kid walk through together, they break.

A: Multi-person is its own variable. Proof it as a separate level — one person at a time first, then add the second person at greater distance, gradually closer, gradually with more interaction. Same isolation principle.

Q: My dog held place through the doorbell but barked while holding. Is that okay?

A: They held position, which is what we cued. Barking while holding is a separate behavior we can address. Two options. First — try negative punishment: when the bark starts, the next rep doesn't happen until the bark stops. Withhold attention and reward until quiet returns. Second — if negative punishment doesn't move the needle, we can add a verbal "no" marker (which we haven't formally introduced, but for a barking-on-place situation it works the same as for any other unwanted behavior). Either way, the holding is the win — the bark is the next thing to clean up.

Q: How do I know when this work is 'done'?

A: It isn't, and never quite is. Distraction proofing continues for the rest of your dog's training life. You'll keep adding new contexts, new distractions, new environments. What today and tomorrow are about is getting the foundation solid enough that the work can continue inside normal household life — most of your future proofing happens incidentally, just from running normal life with a trained dog.

- ✓ **Today's checkpoint.** Can the dog hold position through household-member movement (levels 1-4) and through some social-sound distractions (levels 5-6)? **Yes:** advance to Day 30 tomorrow. **No:** stay here, run more reps at the lower social levels.

TOMORROW

The final day. The 30-day diagnostic, and the honest handoff to what comes next.

Day 30 — Final Indoor Diagnostic + What Comes Next

Today is the final assessment of where you actually are at the end of 30 days. We run the diagnostic honestly, identify what's solid and what isn't, and I tell you exactly what the next chapter looks like.

- **Before you start today.** You've completed Days 1-29. Whether you got here in 30 actual days or 45 or 60 doesn't matter — what matters is that the work was clean.

THE DIAGNOSTIC

Run through this checklist in a normal household session today. Be honest. We're not looking for "perfect" — we're looking for "real."

Foundation level (Week 1):

- ☐ Dog eats their daily ration through training, with no need for bowl-feeding fallback
- ☐ Dog takes food eagerly from your hand for full sessions
- ☐ Dog responds to closed-fist drill — sits and re-orientes to your face
- ☐ Body condition is appropriate (lean, athletic, with visible waist and findable ribs)

Marker and engagement (Week 2 first half):

- ☐ Marker is loaded — dog "breaks their neck" toward you on a cold click
- ☐ Dog offers spontaneous eye contact when sitting still with you
- ☐ Dog re-engages voluntarily after toss-and-reset cycle

Three positions, free-shaped (Week 2 second half):

- ☐ Dog offers sit, down, and place voluntarily without cuing
- ☐ Dog can switch between positions in mixed sessions without confusion
- ☐ Place duration is at least 30 seconds, ideally longer

Verbal cues (Week 3 first half):

- ☐ Dog responds to "sit" with a sit, most of the time
- ☐ Dog responds to "down" with a down, most of the time
- ☐ Dog responds to "place" with a place, most of the time

Pressure conditioning (Week 3 middle):

- ☐ Slight leash pressure produces head-snap toward handler with food expectation
- ☐ Dog does not brace or fight against light pressure
- ☐ Dog responds to dual cues — verbal + tactile pressure together — for all three positions

Indoor distraction proofing (Week 3 final):

- ☐ Dog holds position through handler movement (walking around, sitting/standing, turning back)
- ☐ Dog holds position through environmental distractions (food on floor at 1-3 feet, household sounds)
- ☐ Dog holds position through some social distractions (household member walking through, low-level sounds)

If most of those are checked, congratulations. You have what I'd call a **functional indoor obedience dog at the foundation level**. That's exactly what 30 days of work is supposed to produce. That's what we promised at the start of this guide and that's what you've built.

WHAT YOU ACTUALLY HAVE NOW (AND WHAT YOU DON'T)

I want to be honest about both halves of where you are.

What you have:

- A dog whose food drive is fully restored and whose relationship with food has been re-tooled into a working system
- A loaded marker that you can use to capture and reinforce any behavior going forward
- A dog who defaults to engaging with you as the source of everything they want
- Three foundational obedience positions with both audible and tactile cues
- Pressure conditioning that has inverted the leash from restraint into language
- Indoor obedience that holds through normal household distractions

What you don't have yet:

- An *outdoor* dog. Everything we've built lives inside your house. The protocols for taking these foundations into the outdoor world — walks, real-world distractions, other dogs, environmental novelty, prey distractions — are a whole separate body of work that needs its own progression.
- A dog who's been *bulletproofed*. Bulletproofing is the next phase after foundation — adding duration, distance, and distraction at higher levels than we've worked. Your dog has the foundation. Bulletproofing builds on it.
- A dog who's solved any specific behavioral problems. If you came into this program with reactivity, fear-based behaviors, separation anxiety, resource guarding, or any other named behavior issue — those need their own targeted protocols. The foundation work in this guide is the *prerequisite* for those protocols, not a substitute. With the foundation in place, behavioral rehab becomes much more possible. Without it, behavioral rehab usually fails.

WHERE YOU GO FROM HERE

The 30 days of work you just did is the foundation. The rest of the curriculum — every protocol that builds on this foundation — already exists and is already in your membership. Here's the honest map of what's next, and which course in the library handles it.

Taking this work outside. Everything we've built lives inside your house. The next courses to work through are the heel and outdoor application modules. Same pressure conditioning you just installed, just applied to leash work in graduated outdoor environments. Most pet owners are headed here next. This is the phase where the dog goes from "trained at home" to "trained in the world."

Behavioral issues. If you came into this program with reactivity, fear-based behaviors, separation anxiety, resource guarding, or any other named behavior problem — those have their own dedicated courses in the library. The foundation you just built is the *prerequisite* for those protocols, not a substitute. With the foundation in place, behavioral rehab becomes much more possible. Without it, it usually fails. Now that you have the foundation, the behavioral courses will land much harder than they would have a month ago.

The e-collar. The e-collar course is in the library too. The e-collar in my methodology is a tool that gets layered in *after* the foundation is solid and the leash language is clean — never as a shortcut,

never instead of the work you just did. The course walks you through introduction, conditioning, and integration the same way I do it at my facility.

Off-leash, advanced obedience, sport-level work. Those courses are in the library for the owners who want to go further than the standard pet-life endpoint. The foundation you just built is the gate to all of them.

You don't have to figure out the order on your own. Show up to the **weekly live Q&A calls** — that's where I help members navigate which course is next for their specific dog, and where the protocols get tailored to your individual situation. Bring questions. Bring video if you have it. The members who get the fastest results are the ones who show up consistently.

If you hit something specific to your dog that you can't figure out from the courses, the Q&A, or this guide — **DM me inside the Real Dog Rehab community.** That's the most reliable way to get an answer from me directly.

FINAL WORDS

Whatever brought you to this program — whether your dog had a problem you couldn't solve, or you wanted a more responsive companion, or you just wanted to *do this right* — what you've built over the last 30 days is the same foundation that every working dog in my facility is built on. The same one. The methodology doesn't change based on the breed, the dog's history, or what they're being trained for. The foundation is the foundation.

The dog who comes out of this 30 days is a different dog than the one who started. Not because we taught them tricks. Because we changed the underlying relationship between them and you. They now look at you as the source of everything, they have language for the basic things you want from them, they can hold themselves together through normal household chaos, and they have the working relationship with food and pressure that makes everything else trainable.

That's the win. Not a finished dog. A dog whose foundation can carry the weight of everything that comes next — and everything that comes next is already waiting for you in the courses.

BRIAN-ISM

We do the hard stuff now so we can have more fun through training as we go.

You did the hard stuff. Now go put it to work.

— Brian

What Comes Next

You've finished the foundation phase. Here's the honest map of where to go from here — and I want to be clear about something up front: **you are not done**. The 30 days of work you just did is the on-ramp to the rest of the program, not a stand-alone training plan. Everything that comes next is already built, already in your membership, and already waiting for you. Let me walk you through it.

WHERE THE 30 DAYS FITS IN THE BIGGER PROGRAM

This guide is a quick-start companion to the full video course library inside Real Dog Rehab. Every protocol I had you run for the last 30 days is taught in deeper, more thorough form in the courses — with video demonstrations, multiple example dogs, troubleshooting modules for the edge cases I couldn't fit in here, and the kind of scene-by-scene breakdown you can only do on video. This guide exists to get you moving in the right direction on day one, with the right priorities, in the right order. The courses are where the full curriculum lives.

If you've been working through this guide in parallel with the video course material, beautiful — that's exactly how it's designed to be used. If you ran this guide first and haven't started the videos yet, your next step is to go back to the course library and dig in. The foundation you just built is the language; the courses are the conversation.

WHAT'S IN THE LIBRARY, AND WHICH COURSE IS NEXT

The Real Dog Rehab course library covers the full arc of what it takes to get a finished dog. Where you go next depends on your dog and your goals.

If your priority is taking the foundation outdoors and building a dog who behaves in normal pet-life environments — the next courses to work through are the heel and outdoor application modules. Same pressure conditioning you just installed, applied to leash work in low-distraction outdoor environments, then graduated up. This is where most pet owners are headed.

If your dog has a specific behavioral issue — reactivity, fear, separation anxiety, resource guarding, leash aggression, fence fighting, prey drive that runs the show — there's a behavior-specific course for that. The behavioral courses are designed to be layered on top of the foundation you just built, not run instead of it. You'll get a lot more out of them now than you would have a month ago, because you have the foundation to build them on.

If you're ready for the e-collar — that course is in the library too. The e-collar in my methodology is a tool that gets layered in *after* the foundation is solid and the leash language is clean. Not before. Not as a shortcut. The course walks you through introduction, conditioning, and integration the same way I do it at my facility.

If you want true off-leash reliability or you have a working-line dog with serious drive — the advanced obedience and off-leash modules are where you'll head once the outdoor foundation is in. That's typically a few months down the road from where you are right now.

You don't have to figure out the order on your own. The community and the weekly Q&A calls (more on those below) exist specifically to help you navigate which course is next for your specific dog.

THE WEEKLY LIVE Q&A IS WHERE THE REAL CUSTOMIZATION HAPPENS

Every week inside Real Dog Rehab I do a live Q&A call with members. That's where the protocols in the courses and in this guide get tailored to your specific dog. Bring your questions. Bring video if you have it. We'll work through it together. I'd rather answer your question on a live call than have you guess wrong for a week.

If you've never come to a Q&A — start. If you have, come more often. The members who get the fastest results are the ones who show up consistently and ask questions about *their* dog rather than trying to read a protocol and figure out the adaptation alone. Most of the time, the adaptation needed for your dog is small — but small adaptations make the difference between a protocol that works and one that doesn't.

HOW TO KEEP THE FOUNDATION ALIVE WHILE YOU WORK THROUGH THE REST OF THE COURSES

While you're moving into the next courses, the foundation you just built has to stay maintained. Three things keep it alive:

Keep feeding through training. Don't go back to bowl-feeding. Once you're past the 30-day arc, you can re-introduce the bowl as an *occasional* meal — but the default should remain that food comes through engagement and training. The moment you go back to free-fed bowl meals as the standard, the food drive softens within a couple of weeks and you lose the reinforcer you spent ten days rebuilding.

Keep the marker conditioned. Use it. Catch behaviors you like with a click and a reward. The marker stays sharp through use and dulls through disuse. Two-minute marker games scattered through the day cost you nothing and keep the system alive.

Keep cues precise. Once cues are loaded, do not let them slip. Don't say sit five times. Don't say it and then physically push the dog into a sit. Don't tolerate a slow sit when you know the dog can do a fast one. Cues stay clean through enforcement. They get muddy through tolerance.

If you keep those three things alive, the foundation holds. If you let them slide, the foundation softens, and within a few months you'll find yourself with a dog who's *kind of* trained but doesn't really respond — which is exactly where most pet dogs live.

HOW TO REACH ME

If you hit something specific to your dog that isn't covered in the courses or in this guide — or if you're not sure which course to work through next — **DM me inside the Real Dog Rehab community.** That's the fastest and most reliable way to get an answer from me directly. The community is also where the rest of the members are working through the same material, asking the same kinds of questions, and sharing wins and setbacks. Some of the best troubleshooting in the program happens member-to-member in the community feed before I even see the question.

Between the video courses, the weekly Q&A calls, the community feed, and the option to DM me directly — you have more access to me and to a working program than most owners get from a private trainer. Use it.

Equipment Reference

The complete equipment list for the 30-day program. Everything here was introduced in context within the relevant day, but this is the consolidated reference.

REQUIRED FOR WEEK 1 (FOOD DRIVE)

A regular food bowl. What you already use. Nothing special. The protocol doesn't change based on the bowl.

A timer. Phone timer is fine. Used for the ten-minute meal window.

A high spot to put the bowl. Top of the fridge, top of a tall shelf — somewhere the dog cannot reach and cannot see. Out of sight matters.

Your dog's normal kibble. Do not switch foods for this protocol. Whatever they eat now is what we use. The protocol works with any quality kibble.

REQUIRED FOR WEEK 2 (MARKER AND ENGAGEMENT)

A clicker. Standard box clicker, the kind with a metal tongue inside a plastic shell. A few dollars. [The clicker I use](#).

A treat pouch or a deep pocket. Somewhere food is fast and accessible from. Fishing food out of a Ziploc bag in slow motion will mess up your marker timing. Get a pouch or use a deep coat pocket.

A flat collar. What your dog already wears. We're not using it for pressure work yet — just keeping the dog dressed for sessions.

REQUIRED FOR WEEK 3 (CUES, PRESSURE, DISTRACTION)

A slip lead. Six-foot, 3/8" diameter. Leather or rope. The slip lead is what we use for pressure conditioning. Fitted high on the neck, just behind the ears — *not* down at the base of the neck where it can choke. If you don't know how to fit a slip lead, look up a video before Day 23. [A decent off-the-shelf slip lead on Amazon](#) — or, if you want the slip lead I personally use and run on every dog at my facility, we make our own (\$35 shipped, made to order). DM me inside the Real Dog Rehab community for ordering details.

A raised cot or place bed. Something elevated, with clear edges, sized so your dog has room to stand up, turn around, and lie down comfortably. The elevation and clear boundary matters — that's what makes the place command teachable. A flat blanket on the floor doesn't work the same way because the dog can't *feel* where the boundary is. [The place bed I use](#).

OPTIONAL / SITUATIONAL

A long line, 15-30 feet. Not used in this guide but useful for the outdoor work that comes next.

An e-collar. Not used in this guide. Layered in later, as part of the e-collar course in the library, after the foundation is solid. When you're ready, [the e-collar I recommend](#). Don't buy this for the next 30 days — wait until the e-collar course tells you to.

Calorie powder. For dogs in the genuinely-underweight category who can't run the standard food drive protocol. Mixed into water for nutrition support during the transition.

WHAT YOU DO NOT NEED

You do not need a prong collar for this work. You do not need a head halter, a no-pull harness, a treat dispenser, a remote feeder, a clicker app, or any of the gear marketed at people trying to fix dogs without doing the foundational work. Everything in this guide runs on a flat collar, a slip lead, a clicker, and food. That's it.

Glossary

The terms used in this guide, defined the way I use them. Some of these have other definitions in other places. These are the operational definitions for this program.

Always or never. A principle of dog training that says behaviors are either reliably allowed or reliably forbidden — never sometimes. Dogs cannot reason about exceptions. If something is allowed half the time, the dog learns it's allowed all the time and the prohibition becomes background noise.

Balanced trainer. A trainer who uses both reward and consequence, fluidly, with every dog. Not a euphemism for "harsh." A description of how nature actually teaches and how dogs actually learn.

Bulletproofing. The phase of training that follows foundation. Adding duration, distance, and distraction to known behaviors at higher levels than the foundation work covered. Comes after the 30-day arc.

Capture. The act of marking and rewarding a behavior the dog offers spontaneously, as opposed to luring or shaping it. Free-shaping uses capture.

Closed-fist drill. The diagnostic where you hold a closed fist with food in it in front of the dog's face. A dog with restored food drive sits and re-orient to your face. A dog without restored food drive paws, mouths, or wanders off.

Cooked chicken trap. The pattern where an owner, faced with a dog who's refusing kibble, escalates to higher-value food to get the dog to eat — which trains the dog that holding out produces better food and confirms the strategy. The single most common reason food drive protocols fail.

Engagement. The dog's voluntary choice to focus on the handler. Not commanded, not lured — offered. Engagement is what makes the rest of training possible.

Existential food model. The framing where food is positioned as the dog's paycheck for living, not as a treat. All food comes through engagement with the handler. Continues past the 30-day program as a way of life, not a temporary protocol.

Free-shaping. Teaching a behavior by capturing successive approximations of it, without luring, without verbal cues, without physical positioning. The dog figures out what produces the click. Used in this guide for installing the three base positions.

Functional obedience. Obedience that works in the dog's actual life — not just in clean sessions in a quiet room. The endpoint of the 30-day program is functional indoor obedience. Outdoor functional obedience comes later.

"Get it" cue. A directional release cue that tells the dog *the rep is complete, you're free to chase the food I'm tossing*. Introduced on Day 13 as part of the engagement loop and used throughout free-shaping (Days 15-19) and pressure-paired position work (Day 26). Every time the cue fires during a reset toss, it's being conditioned further. Becomes a foundational tool for every distraction-proofing drill that follows.

Hand-feeding. Delivering the dog's daily food ration piece by piece from your hand, in structured sessions, rather than from a bowl. Used in Week 1 to rebuild food drive and the human-as-source-of-food relationship.

Loaded marker. A marker (clicker or verbal) that the dog has been conditioned to associate with food, to the point that the click itself produces the same response as food appearing. A loaded marker can capture behaviors in real time.

Marker. A precise sound that tells the dog, in the moment they hear it, *that* — that exact thing you just did — is what got you paid. The clicker is the most common marker. A short verbal word ("yes") is also a marker.

Pressure. Physical input transmitted through the leash, used as a directional cue. In my methodology, pressure is conditioned as a positive cue (predicts food) before being used in obedience work. Pressure controlled by the dog — meaning the dog's behavior releases the pressure — is the entire mechanism.

Reinforcer. Anything that, when delivered after a behavior, makes the behavior more likely to happen again. In this program, food is the primary reinforcer. The strength of your reinforcer determines how much punishment you ever have to use — that's the whole math.

Slip lead. A leash that loops through itself to create a sliding loop that goes around the dog's neck. Fitted high, just behind the ears, for clean pressure transmission. The tool used for pressure conditioning starting Day 23.

Successive approximation. Reinforcing closer and closer versions of a target behavior until the full behavior is offered. The mechanism behind free-shaping.

Three base positions. Sit, down, and place — the three foundational stationary positions installed in Week 2. Free-shaped first, then verbally cued in Week 3, then layered with pressure.

Threshold work. The phase of training where a reactive or distractible dog is gradually exposed to their triggers at decreasing distance until they can hold composure in close proximity. Comes after the 30-day arc, typically in Days 60-90.

Trainable-dog test. The Day 9 diagnostic — three subtests that determine whether the food drive work has actually produced the dog we need before moving into Week 2.

Story Index

The stories I told in this guide, the day they appeared, and the principle each one carried. If you want to find a specific one again, here it is.

Day 1 — The 12-day Rottweiler. A dog brought to my facility who refused food for almost two weeks. Used to illustrate that healthy dogs do not starve themselves and that holding the line on the food drive protocol is not cruelty.

Day 1 — The cooked chicken trap. Not a single story but the pattern I see across hundreds of clients. Used to diagnose why the reader's dog "doesn't like food."

Day 5 — The bowl-eating breakthrough. Composite description of the moment dogs flip from refusing to eating, used to give the reader something concrete to recognize when they see it.

Day 11 — Loading the clicker the first time. The mechanical drill, framed through the way I run it with my own dogs.

Day 12 — Break their neck. The phrase I use to describe a fully-loaded marker — the dog's response when they hear the click after conditioning is complete.

Day 13 — Eye contact as the foundation of engagement. The framing for why engagement starts with the dog choosing to look at you, not with you commanding it.

Day 15 — Make them think it was their idea. The mentor line that captures the entire philosophy of free-shaping. Why a dog who *figures something out* learns it deeper than a dog who *gets shown*.

Day 18 — Why place is the most useful behavior in your dog's life. Place as a behavior-plus-location fused into one command, the cot-as-place rule, and why the raised cot's clean edges are what make the command teachable in the first place.

Day 21 — Adding the verbal cue. The 1.4-second rule — why the cue goes *before* the behavior by a precise margin if you want the dog to actually learn the cue, not just associate it loosely.

Day 23 — Pressure as language, not restraint. The conceptual inversion that makes leash work humane. Pressure is something the dog *wants* to respond to, not something they have to fight.

Day 25 — Marrying pressure to a known cue. The point in training where the dog starts responding to dual cues — verbal and tactile — with cleaner reliability than to either alone.

Day 28 — The "wishy-washy" walker. A member call where the owner described herself as inconsistent on walks. The principle: inconsistency is the actual problem, not the dog's behavior. The prescription that came out of that call — heel around food on the ground in your own yard, start small, win small — is the same drill we run indoors today.

Day 30 — We do the hard stuff now so we can have more fun through training as we go. The closing principle. The whole point of restoring food drive: more reward, less correction, more fun, longer.

A Final Note

If you read this guide cover to cover and did the work, you now know more about how to actually train a dog than 95% of pet owners — and frankly more than a meaningful percentage of professional trainers I've met.

That's not flattery. That's the truth of where pet dog training is right now. Most owners are working from a mix of TikTok tips, well-meaning but bad advice from friends, and whatever stuck from the puppy class they took five years ago. The result is a country full of dogs who are loved but not trained, who live in chronic low-grade chaos because nobody ever gave their owners a coherent system to work from.

You now have the start of one. You've built the foundation. The dog who comes out of the next 30 days is a different dog than the one you started with — different in their relationship to food, different in their attention to you, different in how they read leash pressure, different in how they hold position. That difference is real and it's the platform everything else is built on.

But the foundation is just the foundation. The rest of the program — taking this work outside, layering in the e-collar if your dog needs it, addressing whatever specific behavioral issues you came here to solve, building toward true off-leash reliability — that's all in the courses, and that's where you go next.

Show up to the live Q&A calls. Work through the next courses in the order that fits your dog. DM me in the community when you hit something you can't figure out. Use what you've built.

Let's keep going.

— Brian